

Experiencing Jesus through Peter

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To those God loves and to those He has given me to love.

This book walks readers through Peter's experience of Jesus, first in person and then through the Spirit of Christ inside him. Since God is no respecter of persons, Jesus Christ is forever the same, and God's will for believers is to become like Christ, the Holy Spirit is accessible to everyone who confesses their faith in Christ and earnestly follows Jesus, even as Peter did. Based upon 40 selected passages of Scripture, readers come to better understand Peter's walk with Jesus, from first hearing about Him and deciding to follow; to experiencing first hand His righteousness and authority over sin, sickness, death, and nature; to hearing and being expected to do the words of God as a disciple of Christ; to following in Jesus' steps after His ascension to build the church through the power of the Holy Spirit. Meanwhile, the humanity of Peter stands out, even as it does in the Scriptures that record Peter's life, allowing readers to connect with him. Peter was among the closest three disciples to Jesus, the others being James and John. Peter walked on water with Jesus, first confessed Him as the Christ, was rebuked by Jesus as Satan, led the disciples to continue to follow when many turned away, asked to be fully bathed by Jesus when Jesus washed only the other disciples' feet, swung at a Roman soldier with a sword to protect Jesus—and, after all of this, Peter denied Jesus three times after insisting he would not. After he was restored by Jesus, Peter's faith-filled life, led by the Spirit of Christ, was absolutely amazing. Starting at Pentecost, he was the lead to build God's church in Jerusalem through speaking God's words, accompanied by signs, just as he had experienced in Jesus' ministry. Then Peter was the lead to take the gift of the full life of God to the Gentiles, bringing to fruition God's promise to Abraham—that Abraham's offspring would be a blessing to all nations, the readers included. In *Experiencing Jesus through Peter*, readers join the true story of a common, uneducated human as he becomes like Jesus—in his beautiful, godly character; in the words he speaks from God; and in his actions that bring God's righteousness. The readers experience and are invited into the full life designed by the God who loves and values all of His children the same, the God of compassion and generosity who desires to make everything right—the very Author of Life, as Peter called Him.

Introduction

Simon Peter is a fascinating character in Scripture, and most who know something about Christianity know something about him as well. Simon Peter is counted as the first bishop of Rome—or pope—and by Eastern Christian tradition as the first patriarch of Antioch. According to Catholic tradition, Jesus promised Simon Peter a special position in his church. Simon Peter appears prominently in all four gospels and in the book of Acts. The gospel of Mark has traditionally been thought to show the influence of Simon Peter's preaching and eyewitness memories. The epistles of First and Second Peter are also traditionally ascribed to him as well.

The period 2020 through the present has been a very difficult time for many around the world. Change and isolation have been nearly universal. We have felt alone, and social media hasn't made us feel more connected. Discord has been high. Sickness and death have been widespread. Many have felt powerless. Some have struggled to hold onto hope.

During this time, I dug more into the Scriptures and also, enjoying biography as a genre, into the lives and the writings of some the saints from the past few hundred years, including some not from my own Christian tradition. I spent much time on meditation on selected Scriptures and in prayer. During this time, I came to think about and understand the life of Simon Peter in a different light, as well as my own life. This change has brought new nearness of God to my days and consideration of what God has for me and for the church in the world today. The people, the unity, and the work of God's church in the world are very dear to me. I believe God desires to draw all into His church so He can show His goodness to them forever. The church, as you may not have known it yet, is the family of God where each of us experiences belonging and fullness of life.

This book reflects some of this thinking. I do not share personal stories in it, and yet all of it feels deeply personal, as it describes the true story wherein God drew us together into His family, motivated by His great love, which He also shared with us. It consists of forty days of readings from the Bible and reflections on the daily passages, prior passages read, and other Scriptures. I decided to make it available just before the time of lent in 2022. For any interested, I have also included at the end of the book some song suggestions by day and my view of the challenge presented in Peter's life and witness. Each song, tied into some topic from the day, resonates with me in different ways.

My prayer is that you find this book helpful in your life, whether you now count yourself as a believer in Jesus as the Christ or not.

Day 1: Simon hears of Jesus

I find Simon Peter to be an especially worthwhile person to write about for many reasons which will hopefully become clear to you as you read *Experiencing Jesus through Peter*. My main assumption here is that, like me, you've accepted that the Bible is the word of God, inspired by the Holy Spirit, or that you will at least consider this position to be true.

As an aside before we get started, here are some reasons it's reasonable to believe the Bible is God's Word:

- 1) The Bible has been a strong force for freedom and the worth of each human, lifting up the dignity of every race, both men and women, slave and free, and every form of marginalized person
- 2) Most of Jesus' disciples and apostles both lived and died for the gospel including the truth of the resurrected, living Jesus; many saints in the early church did the same
- 3) The truth of the miracles and healings recorded in the Bible in Jesus' Name is more believable in that testimonies of the same continued afterward and continue to this day; there are way too many credible ones to refute; the belief that the natural is all there is completely without merit
- 4) The testimonies of people's lives who have been changed in beautiful ways by making Jesus Lord of their lives and actually following Jesus despite the cost
- 5) The gospel was spread into the world by the power of God (healings, miracles, signs), the blood of the martyrs of the church, and the testimonies of changed lives
- 6) The prophecies of Jesus in the Old Testament were fulfilled in the New Testament by Jesus of Nazareth, and the overall narrative of God's relationship with mankind in the old covenant points toward Jesus
- 7) The Bible is historically accurate and has been verified again and again by historians and archeologists; it contains no contradictions (in the strict sense of the word)
- 8) The Bible is the most read and most famous book in the world
- 9) The Bible is good news, fulfilling our most basic needs to be deeply and unconditionally loved by the God that created us and to belong to a community for which we were made

For now, let's assume we can set aside modern scoffer-ship. To say that the Bible is Word's God is to agree with Peter's statement:

'knowing this first of all, that no prophecy of Scripture comes from someone's own interpretation. For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit.'

2 Peter 1:20-21

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2PE.1.20-21>

In the gospel of John, we learn that Simon heard of Jesus of Nazareth through his brother Andrew:

'One of the two who heard John [the Baptist] speak and followed Jesus was Andrew, Simon Peter's brother. He first found his own brother Simon and said to him, "We have found the Messiah" (which means Christ). He brought him to Jesus. Jesus looked at him and said, "You are Simon the son of John. You shall be called Cephas" (which means Peter). '

John 1:40-42

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.1.40-42>

From Mark 1:16, we know that Andrew and Simon were fishermen operating in the Sea of Galilee: 'Passing alongside the Sea of Galilee, he saw Simon and Andrew the brother of Simon casting a net into the sea, for they were fishermen. '

Mark 1:16

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.1.16>

We also know that Simon was married based upon the gospels, e.g., Mark 1:30.

Before Simon met Jesus of Nazareth, he heard of him from his brother Andrew. Andrew told his brother Simon that he had found the Messiah, or the Christ, the promised deliverer of the Jewish nation prophesied in the Hebrew Bible. From John 1, we understand that Andrew was a disciple of John the Baptist, and he heard and believed John's testimony about Jesus:

'The next day again John was standing with two of his disciples, and he looked at Jesus as he walked by and said, "Behold, the Lamb of God!" The two disciples heard him say this, and they followed Jesus. Jesus turned and saw them following and said to them, "What are you seeking?" And they said to him, "Rabbi" (which means Teacher), "where are you staying?" He said to them, "Come and you will see." So they came and saw where he was staying, and they stayed with him that day, for it was about the tenth hour. One of the two who heard John speak and followed Jesus was Andrew, Simon Peter's brother. '

John 1:35-40

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.1.35-40>

In Acts 4:13, it was made clear that Simon was recognized as an "uneducated, common" man. So Simon was an uneducated, common, married Jewish fisherman, who was aware from the Jewish Scriptures that a Messiah should be coming. Then his brother, also his partner in work, told him he had found the Messiah.

Simon went with his brother to meet Jesus. At that time, Jesus gave Simon a new name, Peter (Cephas), which means stone or rock.

These passages show who Simon was before he became called Peter and before he decided to follow Jesus as a disciple. For those who've decided to follow Jesus, we can all point to such a time in our lives. For others, you may have learned some things about the Messiah and/or about Jesus but you've not yet decided you want to follow. Simon was also once in this place. Tomorrow, we will continue to examine his initial encounter with this Jesus who gave him a new name, Peter, when Jesus met him.

[Song suggestions for Day 1](#)

Day 2: Peter leaves everything to follow Jesus

Yesterday, I gave reasons that it is reasonable to believe the Bible, which gives the trusted account of Peter's life and the account of Jesus' life. We also examined how Simon heard about Jesus from his brother Andrew, who brought Simon to meet Jesus. In this initial meeting, Jesus renamed him Peter.

Peter's interaction with Jesus continued as follows, as recorded in Luke 5:

'Getting into one of the boats, which was Simon's, [Jesus] asked him to put out a little from the land. And he sat down and taught the people from the boat. And when he had finished speaking, he said to Simon, "Put out into the deep and let down your nets for a catch." And Simon answered, "Master, we toiled all night and took nothing! But at your word I will let down the nets." And when they had done this, they enclosed a large number of fish, and their nets were breaking. They signaled to their partners in the other boat to come and help them. And they came and filled both the boats, so that they began to sink. But when Simon Peter saw it, he fell down at Jesus' knees, saying, "Depart from me, for I am a sinful man, O Lord." For he and all who were with him were astonished at the catch of fish that they had taken, and so also were James and John, sons of Zebedee, who were partners with Simon. And Jesus said to Simon, "Do not be afraid; from now on you will be catching men." And when they had brought their boats to land, they left everything and followed him. '

Luke 5:3-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.5.3-11>

In this account, Simon Peter heard Jesus preach to a crowd, and, after submitting to the word of Jesus, came to understand his authority over nature as Lord. I'm sure Peter's initial thrill of the record breaking catch of fish was epic. Then came the realization that his brother Andrew was indeed right; Jesus is the Christ.

Standing in the presence of Jesus, realizing who he was, Peter was afraid, recognizing himself as a sinful man, unworthy of a righteous God. He felt not only conviction, but even fear, as many in the Bible are recorded to have when they are in the presence of angels. But Jesus told him not to fear; Jesus asked Peter to follow him.

So Peter answered Jesus' call to follow. He left his job of being a fisherman to fish for men. Certainly, he was unaware of what this might entail.

The Bible teaches that although we are made in God's image and loved by God, our spirits are dead—in need of resurrection, and our eternal destination is hell. Like Peter, we live in sin and disobedience (Romans 3:23). To be made alive, we must be ready to: 1) give up the worldly,

self-serving life we live that brings death (1 John 2:15-16); 2) count the cost of following Christ over ourselves and the world (Luke 14:26-33).

Simon Peter was not special in what God required of him, for there is no respect of persons with God. In Acts 10:34, Peter was recorded as having said “Truly I understand that God shows no partiality...” In 1 Peter 2:21, Peter told other believers that Christ left them an example “so that you might follow in his steps.” All are to be disciples that follow Christ to become like him, as Peter chose to do.

Peter was about to find out there was much more excitement ahead.

[Song suggestions for Day 2](#)

Day 3: Healings and freedom at Peter's home

Yesterday, we examined how Peter came to his decision to leave everything and follow Jesus.

It has already been mentioned that Peter was a married man. Jesus' interaction with Peter's mother-in-law is recorded in the first three gospels. We read the account from Matthew:

' And when Jesus entered Peter's house, he saw his mother-in-law lying sick with a fever. He touched her hand, and the fever left her, and she rose and began to serve him. That evening they brought to him many who were oppressed by demons, and he cast out the spirits with a word and healed all who were sick. This was to fulfill what was spoken by the prophet Isaiah: "He took our illnesses and bore our diseases." '

Matthew 8:14-17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.8.14-17>

The King James Version records the final verse this way:

'that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by Esaias the prophet, saying, Himself took our infirmities, and bare our sicknesses.'

Matthew 8:17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/1/MAT.8.17>

In this passage, Peter encountered Jesus in a personal way as one who had authority over sickness and the oppression of the devil. First, Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law from a serious illness with a touch. This happened on the Sabbath (Mark 1:21) right after Jesus freed a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Still at Peter's home, the people of Capernaum brought to him at sundown (Mark 1:32) many who were oppressed and sick, and Jesus freed or healed them all. Jesus used his word to do this, so we see in this passage that people were healed by his touch or by his word.

Since we take as truth that the Holy Spirit has inspired all Scripture (see Day 1), we also trust verse 17, which interprets a key prophecy of the life of Jesus from the prophet Isaiah (7th century BC):

'Surely he has borne our griefs [sickness] and carried our sorrows [pains]; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed. '

Isaiah 53:4-5

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.53.4-5>

The words above in brackets are from the notes in the English Standard Version, today regarded an especially trustworthy Bible translation, showing alternative meanings of the Greek words; i.e., griefs could be interpreted as sickness, and sorrows could be interpreted as pains. Matthew 8:17 says we should understand that the Messiah, Jesus Christ, has taken our illnesses or infirmities and borne our diseases or sicknesses. Further, Jesus' action to heal those at Peter's house was a fulfillment of the Isaiah 53 prophecy, which is understood to be mainly about the Jesus' suffering leading up to and during his crucifixion, and how this work affects those who believe in Jesus Christ's saving work for them. It also shows that this was part of God's atonement plan for the Messiah: to free people and heal them physically. This is made possible because of what he has borne, carried—and by his wounds. Furthermore, while the Jewish people waited until sundown after the Sabbath was over to bring people to Jesus for healing of their bodies, Jesus had no such reservation, often healing and freeing people on the Sabbath, Peter's mother-in-law included.

Reflecting on Peter's early experience with Jesus, we recognize Jesus' authority, by a touch or a word, over not only nature but over any oppression or sickness. He has borne and carried and freed mankind from such by his wounds. This is not spiritual freedom or healing about which we speak, but complete: spirit, soul, and body (1 Thess. 5:23). Jesus has authority over all of it for all persons, and

'Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever. '

Hebrews 13:8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/HEB.13.8>

In tomorrow's passage, we examine Jesus' authority over sin.

Prayer:

Bless the Lord, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless His holy name! Bless the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits, who forgives all my iniquity, who heals all my diseases.

- Based on Psalm 103:1-3

[Song suggestions for Day 3](#)

Day 4: A sinful woman forgiven

In yesterday's discussion, Jesus' authority over sickness, disease and oppression was demonstrated at Peter's mother-in-law's house. Jesus referred back to his time at Peter's house during the following occasion at a Pharisee's house:

' One of the Pharisees asked him to eat with him, and he went into the Pharisee's house and reclined at table. And behold, a woman of the city, who was a sinner, when she learned that he was reclining at table in the Pharisee's house, brought an alabaster flask of ointment, and standing behind him at his feet, weeping, she began to wet his feet with her tears and wiped them with the hair of her head and kissed his feet and anointed them with the ointment. Now when the Pharisee who had invited him saw this, he said to himself, "If this man were a prophet, he would have known who and what sort of woman this is who is touching him, for she is a sinner." And Jesus answering said to him, "Simon, I have something to say to you." And he answered, "Say it, Teacher."

"A certain moneylender had two debtors. One owed five hundred denarii, and the other fifty. When they could not pay, he cancelled the debt of both. Now which of them will love him more?" Simon answered, "The one, I suppose, for whom he cancelled the larger debt." And he said to him, "You have judged rightly." Then turning toward the woman he said to Simon, "Do you see this woman? I entered your house; you gave me no water for my feet, but she has wet my feet with her tears and wiped them with her hair. You gave me no kiss, but from the time I came in she has not ceased to kiss my feet. You did not anoint my head with oil, but she has anointed my feet with ointment. Therefore I tell you, her sins, which are many, are forgiven—for she loved much. But he who is forgiven little, loves little." And he said to her, "Your sins are forgiven." Then those who were at table with him began to say among themselves, "Who is this, who even forgives sins?" And he said to the woman, "Your faith has saved you; go in peace."

Luke 7:36-50

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.7.36-50>

A few things can be said of this woman of the city: she had faith Jesus was from God, she loved him, and she wasn't afraid to show her devotion to him. Jesus wasn't concerned with appearances. He dined at the home of a respected Pharisee and showed care to any regarded as a sinner, or any marginalized person. He didn't care what others thought of him; he concerned himself with what is right because he is righteous. Additionally, Jesus, having the Spirit of God in fullness (see Matthew 3:16-17), had the spiritual intuition to know what the Pharisee was thinking.

Jesus chose to speak indirectly to all who were present, including the Pharisee, it would seem, who did not have faith in him, by telling a short parable about the moneylender to Simon Peter. In so doing, he explained the situation that had unfolded with the woman of the city. Her attitude and display toward Jesus showed a correct understanding of her position before God, and her love was welcomed. The God of Israel is known as “merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love... as a father shows compassion to his children, so the Lord shows compassion to those that fear him” (Psalm 103:8,13).

The woman was tender with Jesus: she washed his feet with her tears, then kissed his feet, and anointed his feet and head with oil. In anointing him with oil, she was recognizing him as divine and holy.

Jesus, who is divine and holy, saw her as one of intrinsic value, a daughter of God, and felt tenderly toward her as well. He knew that the attitude of the Pharisee toward her was wrong, so he spoke up to give instruction and correction. Referring back to his visit to Peter’s home, Jesus remarked to Peter that her attitude and tenderness toward Jesus was superior to that of Peter. It was explained that those who are forgiven little, love little.

More importantly, because of her faith in him and great love toward him, Jesus forgave this woman for her many sins, or everything separating her from God, thereby making her right with God, or righteous, and at peace. This act showed that he had the authority to forgive sins. It put the woman in right standing with God, making her whole, and saving her eternally from the main effect of being in sin, which is eternal separation from God.

As the Christ, Jesus brought (and brings) victory over not only sickness, bringing temporary reprieve in this life, but also sin, which has an eternal effect. These are two different facets of salvation, the second of much more significant value.

This lesson teaches us that Jesus forgives sin, and that he values our faith in him, tenderness toward him, and our great love for God. It is remarkable that God desires such tender love from all of us who are made in his image. It also shows that God’s character has never changed; God has always rewarded faith in him. Faith requires knowing who God is, knowing who we are to him, knowing what God commands or desires, and acting on our beliefs despite any pressures to believe or act otherwise. Faith results in action.

Prayer:

You, O Lord, are a God full of compassion, and gracious, longsuffering, and plenteous in mercy and truth.

- Based on Psalm 86:15

[Song suggestions for Day 4](#)

Day 5: Peter sees a woman healed and a girl raised from the dead

Today we read from a passage in Luke:

'Now when Jesus returned, the crowd welcomed him, for they were all waiting for him. And there came a man named Jairus, who was a ruler of the synagogue. And falling at Jesus' feet, he implored him to come to his house, for he had an only daughter, about twelve years of age, and she was dying. As Jesus went, the people pressed around him. And there was a woman who had had a discharge of blood for twelve years, and though she had spent all her living on physicians, she could not be healed by anyone. She came up behind him and touched the fringe of his garment, and immediately her discharge of blood ceased. And Jesus said, "Who was it that touched me?" When all denied it, Peter said, "Master, the crowds surround you and are pressing in on you!" But Jesus said, "Someone touched me, for I perceive that power has gone out from me." And when the woman saw that she was not hidden, she came trembling, and falling down before him declared in the presence of all the people why she had touched him, and how she had been immediately healed. And he said to her, "Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace." While he was still speaking, someone from the ruler's house came and said, "Your daughter is dead; do not trouble the Teacher any more." But Jesus on hearing this answered him, "Do not fear; only believe, and she will be well." And when he came to the house, he allowed no one to enter with him, except Peter and John and James, and the father and mother of the child. And all were weeping and mourning for her, but he said, "Do not weep, for she is not dead but sleeping." And they laughed at him, knowing that she was dead. But taking her by the hand he called, saying, "Child, arise." And her spirit returned, and she got up at once. And he directed that something should be given her to eat. '

Luke 8:40-55

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.8.40-55>

There are so many noteworthy facets of this account. A crowd was waiting on Jesus because he had become famous as the Messiah and as a healer. A ruler of the synagogue asked Jesus to heal his dying daughter. On his way there, the crowd pressed in on him, and he sensed power (dunamin) go out of him. Peter was confused at Jesus' question asked while in a close-packed crowd, "Who was it that touched me?" Peter said, "Master, the crowds surround you and are pressing in on you!" I imagine any of us may have shared Peter's confusion if we were there. It does seem that while Jesus could sense his power for performing miracles leave him, which is interesting in and of itself, there are a few more things one can notice here: the woman made the choice that resulted in her healing, not Jesus; and it seems Jesus truly didn't know who had touched him. The pressure was on the woman though, and she identified herself, trembling. In this sense, her reaction was similar to that of Peter after his unbelievable catch of fish: fear in the presence of the man of God who had just performed a miracle on her behalf. Jesus

explained that it was her faith that made her well. She trusted in Jesus, believing that when she touched Jesus, she would be healed.

And that is what happened, as if it were mechanical, simply governed by a spiritual rule. The woman's faith allowed her to access the power of the Spirit of God in Jesus, independent of Jesus' will to heal her, it would seem, as his attention wasn't even on her. Jesus' power (dumamin) from the Spirit of God is an inherent power, a power that resides in him by virtue of his nature, a power which can be exerted or put forth. In this case, it flowed from Jesus to her body, as if through conduction.

If one were to compare it to conduction, which is always caused by some difference or potential, the difference in her that caused the flow was her faith. Just as the woman of the city that we examined yesterday had faith in Jesus that saved her from sin, a salvation with which we are more familiar, this woman with a chronic condition was saved from her illness by her faith in Jesus as the one who would save her. It was also a saving faith. It saved her of her chronic problem of 18 years wherein no physician could help her. The problem was so significant, she had spent all she had trying. God had the last say and prevailed.

Also, in the same way as with the woman of the city, Jesus told her to go in peace. The Son of God said a blessing of peace, or wholeness, to her. Moreover, he gave a title of endearment to this beloved child of God: daughter. Jesus is the tenderness of God made manifest.

This is really how God feels about his children, and this is just how our compassionate God longs to bless his beloved who have faith in who he is, who know who they are to him, who know what God commands or desires, and who act on their beliefs. God blessed this woman who decided she could only rely on Jesus and had the faith to press in.

If this weren't exciting enough, Jesus isn't done yet. Nor is he discouraged by the word that comes to Jairus just as he is witnessing this victory: "Your daughter is dead." Jesus says some amazing words in the face of the news of the death of his beloved child: "Do not fear; only believe..." This is not the feel-good encouragement to "truly believe" of the Polar Express. These are the words of Jesus, the creator of the human parent-child relationship, in the most serious situation any parent could experience. Jairus was not to fear because this news wasn't the end of the story. God writes the end of the story, and Jesus is always victorious over sin, sickness, and death. Jesus knew his Father would have the last say and prevail.

Peter entered Jairus' home with Jesus. All there were mourning. They had given up hope. Jesus tried to comfort them, informing them she was sleeping rather than dead, and they laughed at

him, thinking what he said was ridiculous. Jesus touched her, power and life flowing from him to her, and commanded her to arise. At this touch and command, her spirit returned to her and she arose. The Spirit of God which is in Jesus is life (zoe). Furthermore, it is one's spirit that gives life to one's body; when it returned, she was well again. She was brought back by the touch of Jesus and the faith of Jesus that what he said would happen through belief would indeed happen: "she will be well." Jesus was right; there was no cause of fear or weeping because of him.

It is through occasions like these that Peter learned rightfully to call Jesus "the Author of Life" (Acts 3:15).

Prayer:

Thank you, Father, that the law of the Spirit of life in me has set me free in Christ Jesus from the law of sin and death.

- Based on Romans 8:2

[Song suggestions for Day 5](#)

Day 6: Jesus sends out Peter among the twelve

In the preceding days, Peter witnessed the righteousness of Jesus, bringing victory after victory over sin, sickness, and death. Jesus being the teacher of teachers, he taught his disciples not only by showing them what to do, but also to have them do it—to follow in his steps in all things:

' And he called to him his twelve disciples and gave them authority over unclean spirits, to cast them out, and to heal every disease and every affliction. The names of the twelve apostles are these: first, Simon, who is called Peter, and Andrew his brother; James the son of Zebedee, and John his brother; Philip and Bartholomew; Thomas and Matthew the tax collector; James the son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus; Simon the Zealot, and Judas Iscariot, who betrayed him. These twelve Jesus sent out, instructing them, "Go nowhere among the Gentiles and enter no town of the Samaritans, but go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. And proclaim as you go, saying, 'The kingdom of heaven is at hand.' Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse lepers, cast out demons. You received without paying; give without pay. Acquire no gold or silver or copper for your belts, no bag for your journey, or two tunics or sandals or a staff, for the laborer deserves his food. And whatever town or village you enter, find out who is worthy in it and stay there until you depart. As you enter the house, greet it. And if the house is worthy, let your peace come upon it, but if it is not worthy, let your peace return to you. And if anyone will not receive you or listen to your words, shake off the dust from your feet when you leave that house or town. Truly, I say to you, it will be more bearable on the day of judgment for the land of Sodom and Gomorrah than for that town. '

Matthew 10:1-15

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.10.1-15>

Mark records also the result:

'So they went out and proclaimed that people should repent. And they cast out many demons and anointed with oil many who were sick and healed them. '

Mark 6:12-13

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.6.12-13>

First, Jesus gave his disciples, Peter included, the same authority they had seen him use: to cast out unclean spirits, and to heal every disease and affliction. They were sent first to Israel, the children of God according to the promise given to Abraham. They were to say the kingdom of heaven is at hand; the signs of this kingdom were the observation of the supernatural power of the righteous God to make everything that was wrong right again—for God's will to be done on earth as it is in heaven, where there is no sickness, no death, and no oppression of the devil. The disciples were to make it right again by the authority given to them.

Just as they received from the ultimate giver, Jesus, without paying, so too they were to give to all children of Israel as servants of men, expecting no pay. They were only to accept the food offered to them to sustain them.

They were to go to all, home by home, without picking or choosing. In any home, they were to greet them and sense whether or not those present were worthy. We know Jesus had spiritual intuition because of the Spirit of God within him, and it appears the disciples were given this by the Spirit of God that went with them as well. The disciples had the ability to confer the peace of God upon those in the house, or to take it back.

So the disciples did what they were instructed to do by Jesus. They went. They called for people to repent. They freed people from the oppression of devils. They healed the sick, even as they had seen Jesus do. Everything which had a name bowed its knee at the name of Jesus.

The twelve disciples were made to multiply the works and the grace of Jesus, and it created quite a stir, as we learn from Herod's recorded reaction:

' Now Herod the tetrarch heard about all that was happening, and he was perplexed, because it was said by some that John had been raised from the dead, by some that Elijah had appeared, and by others that one of the prophets of old had risen. '

Luke 9:7-8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.9.7-8>

The disciples not only heard the word of Jesus and watched what he did; they became doers of his word, obeying his instructions to them. They were given the Spirit of God with authority and power, and they used it to multiply the grace and peace of the kingdom of God. By going and doing, they better understood how to seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, obtaining the same kind of results that Jesus did in his ministry of the kingdom.

In this day, door-to-door evangelism is not a common practice, except among Mormons and Jehovah's witnesses. In my observations, this passage of Scripture is not a common one to preach. Perhaps the church does not know how to connect with it in the present day. For the Mormon church, it is seen as an act of obedience, and it is required by their church. American culture clearly discourages such practice, as we understand from the way a joke has been made of this and other practices of the Mormon church in the hit Broadway play, "The Book of Mormon."

Nonetheless, this event, the sending out of the twelve, is part of the life and training of the disciples, Peter included. It was recorded in Matthew, Mark and Luke (i.e., Luke 9). The experience must have been of great impact to Peter. By this point, he moved from seeing and hearing the good works of Jesus to doing good works and bringing freedom to others himself. Obeying the command of Jesus, he demonstrated in this both his love for God and his love for his neighbors.

Prayer:

I praise You, God, that You have highly exalted Jesus and bestowed on Him the name that is above every name, so that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

- Based on Philippians 2:9-11

[Song suggestions for Day 6](#)

Day 7: Jesus instructs the disciples to feed a multitude

Today's account is one of the rare ones recorded in all four gospels. At least one of these occurrences of feeding multitudes proceeded directly after the sending out of the twelve:

'On their return the apostles told him all that they had done. And he took them and withdrew apart to a town called Bethsaida. When the crowds learned it, they followed him, and he welcomed them and spoke to them of the kingdom of God and cured those who had need of healing. Now the day began to wear away, and the twelve came and said to him, "Send the crowd away to go into the surrounding villages and countryside to find lodging and get provisions, for we are here in a desolate place." But he said to them, "You give them something to eat." They said, "We have no more than five loaves and two fish—unless we are to go and buy food for all these people." For there were about five thousand men. And he said to his disciples, "Have them sit down in groups of about fifty each." And they did so, and had them all sit down. And taking the five loaves and the two fish, he looked up to heaven and said a blessing over them. Then he broke the loaves and gave them to the disciples to set before the crowd. And they all ate and were satisfied. And what was left over was picked up, twelve baskets of broken pieces. '

Luke 9:10-17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.9.10-17>

In a desolate place in Bethsaida, on the northeast side of the sea of Galilee, there was more preaching of the kingdom of God and healing of all those who had need of healing, this time by the Master. At the end of a long day of healing all who presented a need, the disciples asked Jesus to do the logical thing, seeing there was no place to eat or lodge: send them away to take care of themselves.

Jesus commanded his disciples: "You give them something to eat." You take care of them. Another lesson about the ways of God was in store for them from the one who taught them: 'Therefore do not be anxious, saying, 'What shall we eat?' or 'What shall we drink?' or 'What shall we wear?' For the Gentiles seek after all these things, and your heavenly Father knows that you need them all. But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you. '

Matthew 6:31-33

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.6.31-33>

The disciples told Jesus what they saw: "We have no more than five loaves and two fish." They did not know what to do.

So Jesus gave simple instructions, prayed as he looked up to heaven, blessed the food, broke the loaves, and gave the food to the disciples.

The disciples obeyed in faith and brought food to the crowd. Their faith required knowing who Jesus is, knowing who they were to him, knowing what he commanded, and acting on it despite any pressures to believe or act otherwise.

By the faith of Jesus, this was no normal dinner table blessing of the food they were about to eat. Instead, the food was multiplied before their eyes, a creation miracle of the God “who calls into existence the things that do not exist” (Romans 2:16). The faith of Jesus created, and it creates. The thousands in the crowd ate and were satisfied, and there was enough left over for them.

The disciples learned that for the Creator and any connected to him, providing for basic needs is no cause for concern, just as Jesus taught them, “all these things will be added to you.” The multitude was hungry, and Jesus made it right. God provided, and they were satisfied.

Even as Abraham had learned, the Lord will provide (Genesis 22:14).

It does not matter whether or not it seems possible or reasonable.

Prayer:

I praise You, Lord, our Provider (Jireh). Thank You, God, for supplying every need of mine according to Your riches in glory in Christ Jesus.

- Based on Genesis 22:14, Philippians 4:19

[Song suggestions for Day 7](#)

Day 8: Jesus walks better on water than Peter does

In yesterday's reading, we experienced Jesus as Creator and as the one who provides from the riches of the glory of God. The following account occurred right after the feeding of the five thousand men, plus women and children:

' Immediately [Jesus] made the disciples get into the boat and go before him to the other side, while he dismissed the crowds. And after he had dismissed the crowds, he went up on the mountain by himself to pray. When evening came, he was there alone, but the boat by this time was a long way from the land, beaten by the waves, for the wind was against them. And in the fourth watch of the night he came to them, walking on the sea. But when the disciples saw him walking on the sea, they were terrified, and said, "It is a ghost!" and they cried out in fear. But immediately Jesus spoke to them, saying, "Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid." And Peter answered him, "Lord, if it is you, command me to come to you on the water." He said, "Come." So Peter got out of the boat and walked on the water and came to Jesus. But when he saw the wind, he was afraid, and beginning to sink he cried out, "Lord, save me." Jesus immediately reached out his hand and took hold of him, saying to him, "O you of little faith, why did you doubt?" And when they got into the boat, the wind ceased. And those in the boat worshiped him, saying, "Truly you are the Son of God." '

Matthew 14:22-33

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.14.22-33>

After meeting the needs of the multitude, Jesus sent the disciples from Bethsaida across to the other side of the Sea of Galilee. Meanwhile, he went up on the mountain by himself to pray, a frequent practice of his. Since the disciples and we are to learn from what Jesus does, this also means we need to frequently get alone with our Father, away from the ever busy and distracting world, for communion in prayer.

It was a stormy night, and sometime after 3 am, Jesus came to them walking on the sea in the midst of the storm.

As any of us might be while seeing such a sight in the middle of the night during a storm, which likely frightened them already, they were terrified. They shouted out in fear, thinking Jesus was a ghost.

At this, Jesus encouraged them: "Take heart." This is not a common phrase today. Yet, it is instinctive to Jesus. "Do not be afraid," as spoken here, is also commonly spoken by Jesus. Often Jesus just means what he says, not something else. The disciples were clearly afraid, and we would have been too.

Pausing to consider, some of us may have no idea how much fear motivates us. Why do we do the things we do? Is fear behind it? Fear of failure? Fear of not having enough? Fear of not being enough? Fear of what our family, friends, neighbors, or coworkers may think? Fear of discomfort or pain?

Moving back to the Bible account, we see that Peter is growing in faith, wanting to trust Jesus and follow in his steps—in yet another way: “Lord, if it is you, command me to come to you on the water.” That’s a bold statement! Yet, we are beginning to see that Peter was starting to understand that Jesus wanted him to do all of what he was doing, while relying on God the Father and the Spirit of God.

Upon Jesus’ command, Peter obeyed, and by faith like that of Jesus, he also walked on water all the way to Jesus, his faith not wavering. He had his eyes fixed on Jesus and was acting on the word of Jesus. One has faith in what one chooses to rely on.

But when Peter took his focus off of Jesus and his word, he wavered, fixing his attention on the storm, and fear entered him, killing the effect of his faith. He started sinking.

This experience is reminiscent of the words of James, Jesus’ brother, another follower of Christ: 'But let him ask in faith, nothing wavering. For he that wavereth is like a wave of the sea driven with the wind and tossed. For let not that man think that he shall receive any thing of the Lord. A double minded man is unstable in all his ways. '

James 1:6-8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/1/JAS.1.6-8>

Due to the wavering of his initially Christ-like faith, Peter quite literally became unstable. But the Teacher took hold of Peter, as he cried out for saving, and brought him back to the boat.

Making this a teaching moment, Jesus rebukes Peter: “O you of little faith, why did you doubt?” Faith was one of the most frequent subjects of instruction for Peter and the disciples, in a variety of ways.

Is our faith stronger than Peter’s?

About faith, the Apostle Paul wrote “whatever does not proceed from faith is sin” (Romans 14:23) and encouraged “all to attain to the unity of the faith of the knowledge of the Son of

God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ, so that we may no longer be children, tossed to and fro by the waves..." (Ephesians 4:13-14).

Jesus was an example of complete faith in God the Father. He did not sin. We should always be seeking to build our faith to be like that of Jesus until we are mature.

The Apostle John wrote this about Jesus: "whoever says he abides in [Jesus] ought to walk in the same way he walked " (1 John 2:6).

At the end of this passage, the disciples worshipped Jesus, the one who had authority over nature during the storm, by walking on the waves and by saving the sinking Peter. They praised him as the "Son of God."

Prayer:

Praise to You, O God, who quickens the dead, and calls those things which be not as though they were. I thank You that I may put my faith fully in You, Your ability, and Your words.

- Based on Romans 4:17

[Song suggestions for Day 8](#)

Day 9: Peter confesses Jesus as the Christ

In today's discussion, we have a passage whose interpretation is a source of some controversy in the church. I give credit for part of my discussion of this passage to Eugene Bach, the author of "Chasing Revival: A Road Trip Bible Study."

The gospel author Luke was a follower of the Apostle Peter, and he records an event where Peter discerned who Jesus really was in chapter 9. However, Matthew has a more detailed account of this event:

' Now when Jesus came into the district of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, "Who do people say that the Son of Man is?" And they said, "Some say John the Baptist, others say Elijah, and others Jeremiah or one of the prophets." He said to them, "But who do you say that I am?" Simon Peter replied, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God." And Jesus answered him, "Blessed are you, Simon Bar-Jonah! For flesh and blood has not revealed this to you, but my Father who is in heaven. And I tell you, you are Peter [Petros], and on this rock [petra] I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven, and whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven." Then he strictly charged the disciples to tell no one that he was the Christ. '

Matthew 16:13-20

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.16.13-20>

Real faith goes beyond what one believes, affecting both what one says and what one does. These are both actions that are based on belief.

In this passage, Peter correctly discerned who Jesus is, answering in response to Jesus' question, which Jesus had to ask twice: He is the Christ, the Son of the living God. Jesus replied that the Father had revealed this truth to Peter [Petros], who he had named rock, probably looking forward to this event of Peter's confession with his lips. In the Christian faith, it is the action of confession that brings salvation (sozo):

'But the righteousness based on faith says... "The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart" (that is, the word of faith that we proclaim); because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For with the heart one believes and is justified, and with the mouth one confesses and is saved. '

Romans 10:6-10

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ROM.10.6-10>

It was this confession of who Christ is that is the large rock (Petra) on which God has built his church (ecclesia) and made his followers whole. This occasion was the first time the word church was used. The church refers not to a building, but to the worldwide (catholic) body of believers in Jesus as the Christ who have been given new life in their spirits by God for their confession of faith. These are the ones who enter the kingdom of God. Petra refers to a large rock, the word having similarity to Peter (petros), the first one to confess Jesus as the Son of the living God, but it's not the same word.

This confession occurred at Caesarea, according to the passage, which has significance, giving meaning to Jesus' reply. It was an area dedicated to false gods, a place of pagan practices including orgies and possibly human sacrifices, the darkest place known to the Jews. The primary landmark there, the "Rock of the Gods," still stands today. In the center of this large rock is a cave that was believed to be the gateway to Hades. Within the cave, there exists a water spring considered to be bottomless because it was thought to be the barrier, or gate, between heaven and hell.

It was on such confession of truth that Jesus has built his church, even in the midst of the darkness of the world, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. This all was in fulfillment of the angel's words to Abraham:

'And the angel of the Lord called to Abraham a second time from heaven and said, "By myself I have sworn, declares the Lord, because you have done this and have not withheld your son, your only son, I will surely bless you, and I will surely multiply your offspring as the stars of heaven and as the sand that is on the seashore. And your offspring shall possess the gate of his enemies, and in your offspring shall all the nations of the earth be blessed, because you have obeyed my voice." '

Genesis 22:15-18

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/GEN.22.15-18>

God was to multiply Abraham's offspring through the church of all nations built upon Jesus, which would possess the gate of God's enemies and be a blessing.

We will see that Peter was clearly a leading shepherd for this early church. This church has been given great authority by Jesus to bring righteousness, as we have already started to see: they were instructed to do the same things that Jesus did, including proclaiming the kingdom of heaven, healing the sick, raising the dead, and casting out demons.

To the church, the body of faith-filled believers that includes Peter as a shepherd, God has given the keys of the kingdom of heaven, the power of God to demonstrate the heavenly kingdom

come to earth included. This has included the spiritual power they have with their words, or their confessions, of binding and loosing in the spiritual realm. They could speak directly to spirits to either forbid or permit, as Jesus did. They have had authority over evil with their words, just as Jesus did. As such, the church has had authority to prevail over the gates of hell to accomplish the will of God to build the church, to free people from oppression, and to make things right, or to establish righteousness.

The church is precious to God. It is those of faith who compose the bride of Christ. Those who confess Christ as Lord, as Peter did, and resolve to follow him have been made righteous by identification with the death and the resurrection life of Jesus. To join God in his work to build the church is to participate in the miraculous: God making new creations of men and women.

Peter was key in building the church, as we will discuss in days ahead. He was not the only one though. Paul also established the church among the Gentiles, as is well known. Matthew, Philip, Bartholomew and Mark worked to establish the church in Africa. Bartholomew may have also gone to India with Thomas to spread the gospel, according to tradition. Thaddeus, or Judas the brother of James, also known as Jude, brought the gospel to northern Iraq.

Prayer:

I confess that Jesus is Lord and believe in my heart that God raised Him from the dead, so You have saved me. Thank You, God, for Your grace, for Your life, and for making me a new creation.
- Based on Romans 10:9-10

[Song suggestions for Day 9](#)

Day 10: Jesus rebukes Peter as Satan

Right after the passage discussed on Day 9 where Peter confessed Jesus as the Christ, Jesus foretold his death:

' And he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and the chief priests and the scribes and be killed, and after three days rise again. And he said this plainly. And Peter took him aside and began to rebuke him. But turning and seeing his disciples, he rebuked Peter and said, "Get behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man." And calling the crowd to him with his disciples, he said to them, "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me. For whoever would save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake and the gospel's will save it. For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul? For what can a man give in return for his soul? For whoever is ashamed of me and of my words in this adulterous and sinful generation, of him will the Son of Man also be ashamed when he comes in the glory of his Father with the holy angels."

Mark 8:31-38

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.8.31-38>

Here we read about the occasion where Jesus began to clearly teach Peter and the disciples, who had recognized correctly who he is—the Messiah, the Son of the living God—what would become of him. He would suffer persecution and rejection by the Jews, be killed, and then rise again. This was completely contrary to who Peter understood the Messiah to be and what he was to do, so Peter became outraged. Based upon the Jewish understanding of Scripture and their traditions, they expected the Messiah to be a king from the line of David to come save their nation, deliver them from their oppressors, and rule. Peter's outrage led him to take Jesus aside and rebuke him.

It may seem to us unbelievable that Peter would do this right after he had correctly recognized who Jesus was and Jesus called him a leader to build his church. Peter was deeply disillusioned; Jesus seemed to be speaking nonsense. Jesus was not doing at all what Peter or the others expected him to do. This was not the agenda for the Messiah: to suffer, be rejected, and die. So Peter decided to correct and speak truth to Jesus, as if to say, "No, this is not what you are supposed to be doing!" Perhaps he tried to tell Jesus what it was he was supposed to do for them, according to his understanding, his will, or the understanding of the Jews.

Meanwhile, seeing an intense scene unfolding between Jesus and Peter, the disciples headed their way. Seeing the rest of the disciples head his way, the Teacher and Son of God decided that it was Peter who must receive the most stinging rebuke ever recorded to his followers: "Get

behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man.”

Jesus’ correction revealed that the mind and spirit that Peter was displaying with his thoughts, words, and actions was from Satan, not from God. Not unlike the Pharisees, Peter had an agenda contrary to that of Jesus, and his mind and will had been influenced by the traditions of men, his culture, the world.

If we consider it, is it not the same with us? Do we want Jesus to be to us and do for us what we will? Do we have expectations that we think God should meet? We do make him who we want him to be. Loving our lives in the world, we look to accomplish our own agendas, build our own kingdoms, and we think the all-powerful God should help us to get it done. Our will and our hopes are also his will and hopes for us, we think, so sometimes we are not sure why he doesn’t get with the program of what we think his will is for our lives. It is so easy to take the wide road and set our minds not on the things of God but on the things of man, the traditions of man, the cares of the world. Our lives are self-serving, which brings death. This is not from God, the fountain of all life. As history repeats itself, we have done what the people in Jeremiah’s time did as well:

‘for my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water. ’ Jeremiah 2:13
<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JER.2.13>

Meanwhile, the world has correctly observed what the church has done, what we have done, and they have lost interest in God’s church.

As such, we should also take the stinging rebuke that Jesus gave to Peter for having this mind and acting on it: “Get behind me, Satan!”

Jesus does have an agenda for his disciples and for us, although it may not be the one we really want for ourselves: count the cost.

Calling the crowd over, Jesus made this a teaching moment for all. In order to come after Jesus, we are to deny ourselves, take up our cross, and follow Christ. Jesus had just revealed how he was to die, and so we too are to die. We are not to love our lives in the world (Luke 14:26), but to choose to die to ourselves and to die to the cares of the world. By faith, we are to identify ourselves with Jesus, what he cares about, and his kingdom. We are to deny our own way, our agenda, our will, the building of our own kingdoms. Instead, seeking God’s kingdom and his righteousness, we are to face persecution in the world as he did.

We are not to try to save our lives in the world, but to lose them for the sake of Jesus and the gospel. We are to care about and pursue the advancement of what Jesus cares about rather than pursue the things the world cares about. To lose our lives certainly means losing our lives as we knew them before committing to follow Christ. It could also mean physically losing our lives for the sake of the gospel. It meant this for almost all of the original twelve disciples, including Peter. It meant this for many early Christians. It still means this for many Christians in the world today where the gospel is actively opposed. The gospel has been spread in a large part through the blood of martyrs. Whatever is required of us, we are to count the cost. At the least, it will cost us our reputation as it was and our lives as we knew them. Being saved isn't about saying a prayer, going back to our lives, and thenceforth remaining largely unchanged.

In order to lose our lives, we must also deny ourselves. If we are faced with doing what is right or what feels good—i.e., what we want, we naturally tend to do what we want. Following Christ though is about wanting what God wants, or aligning our own will with God's will. It's about believing that God's will and his Word brings about what is right and best for us, and acting on it. It is trusting that only his way brings life and abundance, not our way. What we believe to be true is tested by the many choices we make every day.

Will we choose to try to gain more in the world? Or to follow God's way? To care about what he cares about? To do what Jesus did? To treasure and live by his words?

Choosing the world, or self, forfeits our soul because we cannot choose both that way and Christ's way. We can only have faith that one of those two ways is the best and the right way. Only one of them is life.

If we boldly choose Jesus Christ in faith, we will not be ashamed of it. There is no shame in what we are passionate about to our core, in that for which we will lose our lives. We cannot help but to speak of it to those in our generation, even as Peter chose to do in his. We see here that taking in this truth didn't come easily to Peter, nor will it come easily to us. To follow Jesus in truth is to count the cost, rather than try to make Jesus conform to our own purpose for him. Only the former is real; the latter is of our own making. It is fake and needs to be destroyed.

And in choosing to do so, we die with Christ, are raised with him in life, and are joined to his spirit. Our spirit becomes alive in us with Jesus' resurrection life, our personality and being energized and enlarged by the quality of God in us. The Word of God takes root in us as an imperishable seed (1 Peter 1:23), or a blueprint for the way our lives in the Spirit of God should unfold. Only then can we really begin to mature, to grow up into the beautiful image of Christ.

Prayer:

I thank You that I have been born again of God, not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living and abiding word of God.

- Based on 1 Peter 1:23

[Song suggestions for Day 10](#)

Day 11: Peter offers to make tents for Jesus, Moses and Elijah

Regarding the account discussed on Day 10 where Peter was strongly rebuked following his own rebuke of Jesus, the account in Luke offers some additional detail about what Jesus said last: 'But I tell you truly, there are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God.' '

Luke 9:27

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.9.27>

The account of the transfiguration directly follows:

' Now about eight days after these sayings he took with him Peter and John and James and went up on the mountain to pray. And as he was praying, the appearance of his face was altered, and his clothing became dazzling white. And behold, two men were talking with him, Moses and Elijah, who appeared in glory and spoke of his departure, which he was about to accomplish at Jerusalem. Now Peter and those who were with him were heavy with sleep, but when they became fully awake they saw his glory and the two men who stood with him. And as the men were parting from him, Peter said to Jesus, "Master, it is good that we are here. Let us make three tents, one for you and one for Moses and one for Elijah" — not knowing what he said. As he was saying these things, a cloud came and overshadowed them, and they were afraid as they entered the cloud. And a voice came out of the cloud, saying, "This is my Son, my Chosen One; listen to him!" And when the voice had spoken, Jesus was found alone. And they kept silent and told no one in those days anything of what they had seen. '

Luke 9:28-36

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.9.28-36>

In what seems like a rare occasion, Jesus took Peter and the sons of thunder, James and John, with him up on a mountain to pray. Usually, Jesus went off to pray alone. As Jesus prayed, a vision of heaven broke into the physical world, the three dimensional world as observed by our five created senses (sight, hearing, touch, smell, and taste), as if from another unseen dimension. In the kingdom of God, those that have chosen life by choosing faith in God are still alive. And so Peter saw Jesus speaking with Moses and Elijah. At least Jesus' appearance was altered and his clothes were dazzling white, an unmistakable manifestation of the heavenly (as when Moses talked with God, Exodus 34:29). Jesus continued the discussion with Moses and Elijah which he had recently brought up with his disciples; they spoke of his departure from the earth by his death, which he was about to accomplish at Jerusalem.

In this vision, Peter, James and John had been heavy with sleep; then they fully woke up, enabling them to respond. At the same time, Jesus, Moses and Elijah began to depart. This was

when Peter made the strange comment to offer for the disciples to make tents for Jesus, Moses and Elijah. Meanwhile, God the Father moved over them in the form of a cloud. God spoke, confirming what Peter had earlier confessed: Jesus is the Son of God, the Messiah. Peter is told “Listen to him!”

The vision then ended, and they were left with just Jesus.

In the book of 2 Peter, Peter reflected again on this experience:

'For we did not follow cleverly devised myths when we made known to you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, but we were eyewitnesses of his majesty. For when he received honor and glory from God the Father, and the voice was borne to him by the Majestic Glory, “This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased,” we ourselves heard this very voice borne from heaven, for we were with him on the holy mountain. And we have the prophetic word more fully confirmed, to which you will do well to pay attention as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts, knowing this first of all, that no prophecy of Scripture comes from someone’s own interpretation. For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit.'

2 Peter 1:16-21

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2PE.1.16-21>

Peter was an eyewitness to the majesty and power of Jesus Christ, the beloved Son who came from God the Father, according to the voice of God that Peter heard in a vision while he was awake. Peter told us as believers: Listen to his words! God’s words are the prophetic words in the Scriptures. Peter had this confirmed directly: “This is my Son, my Chosen One; listen to him!” The authority of Jesus’ words were confirmed again and again throughout his life. Peter learned to and exhorted us to pay attention to God’s Word as to a lamp shining in a dark place. It is the way to see. Without it, one sees nothing.

We are also reminded in the transfiguration about the words Jesus spoke to the Sadducees about resurrection:

'And as for the dead being raised, have you not read in the book of Moses, in the passage about the bush, how God spoke to him, saying, ‘I am the God of Abraham, and the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob’? He is not God of the dead, but of the living. You are quite wrong.’ '

Mark 12:26-27

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.12.26-27>

To God the Father and to Jesus, Moses and Elijah were and are among the living. In the transfiguration, Peter, James, and John were awakened to comprehend and understand and realize, beyond the perception of their usual five senses, what their environment in the Spirit was.

Prayer:

Thank You, Father, that I have been quickened together with Jesus. Thank You for Your Word by which I may understand, see, and experience what is real, what is true, and that which is eternal.

- Based on Colossians 2:13

[Song suggestions for Day 11](#)

Day 12: Jesus drives out a spirit by prayer that some of the disciples cannot

In yesterday's reading, Peter saw and experienced the kingdom of God, and heard the voice of God telling him to listen to the Word of God, Jesus. The next day, Peter, Jesus, James and John came down from the mountain, and the following account unfolded:

' And when they came to the disciples, they saw a great crowd around them, and scribes arguing with them. And immediately all the crowd, when they saw him, were greatly amazed and ran up to him and greeted him. And he asked them, "What are you arguing about with them?" And someone from the crowd answered him, "Teacher, I brought my son to you, for he has a spirit that makes him mute. And whenever it seizes him, it throws him down, and he foams and grinds his teeth and becomes rigid. So I asked your disciples to cast it out, and they were not able." And he answered them, "O faithless generation, how long am I to be with you? How long am I to bear with you? Bring him to me." And they brought the boy to him. And when the spirit saw him, immediately it convulsed the boy, and he fell on the ground and rolled about, foaming at the mouth. And Jesus asked his father, "How long has this been happening to him?" And he said, "From childhood. And it has often cast him into fire and into water, to destroy him. But if you can do anything, have compassion on us and help us." And Jesus said to him, "'If you can! All things are possible for one who believes.'" Immediately the father of the child cried out and said, "I believe; help my unbelief!" And when Jesus saw that a crowd came running together, he rebuked the unclean spirit, saying to it, "You mute and deaf spirit, I command you, come out of him and never enter him again." And after crying out and convulsing him terribly, it came out, and the boy was like a corpse, so that most of them said, "He is dead." But Jesus took him by the hand and lifted him up, and he arose. And when he had entered the house, his disciples asked him privately, "Why could we not cast it out?" And he said to them, "This kind cannot be driven out by anything but prayer." '

Mark 9:14-29

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.9.14-29>

In this account, Jesus walked with Peter, James and John into a commotion among a crowd, his other disciples and the scribes, after the other disciples were unable to help a mute, demon-affected boy. Jesus listened to the problem from the father and accepted the explanation; he had a demon causing the muteness and the unusual behavior. The father hoped that Jesus could heal the boy, based on Jesus' reputation.

Jesus first spoke in frustration with the disciples present who were unable to do anything for the boy despite their training under Jesus to do the things Jesus did. This was a rebuke of his disciples in front of the crowd for their lack of faith to demonstrate the gospel and the kingdom

of God: “O faithless generation, how long am I to be with you? How long am I to bear with you?” The disciples were among a faithless generation, and it required patience on Jesus' part to continue to show them how to maturely exercise faith to demonstrate the kingdom of God.

Jesus did just that: “Bring him to me.” The twelve had already gone off on their own at Jesus' instruction to cast out demons, heal, and raise the dead; but, on this occasion, they couldn't free this boy from the oppression of the devil without him. So Jesus showed the disciples again how faith is exercised.

Now we move to consider the father of the boy. The father's hopeful attitude was shown in the following statement: “But if you can do anything, have compassion on us and help us.” Jesus also spoke with indignation to this statement, which displayed lack of faith in God: “‘If you can’!” The man wasn't sure if Jesus was able to help him and his son. Perhaps we also see this father wonder here if it was God's will to show compassion to them, as Jesus had been known to show compassion to others in healing them and freeing them from oppression.

Jesus' next words spoken to all are instructive: “All things are possible for one who believes.” Who was the only one in the mix here whose belief was unwavering? It wasn't the father who stated, “Help my unbelief!” It was Jesus. He was the one who demonstrated faith in his Father in the following moments. All things are possible to him, the one with compassion for all, the one who heals and frees the multitudes, demonstrating the kingdom of God, without picking or choosing who deserves it and who doesn't. This word from Jesus, “All things are possible for one who believes” is not only directed at the crowd, but also to his disciples, including those who by lack of faith were unable to do this work.

So, as a larger crowd formed in this increasingly emotional scene, Jesus drove out the spirit “by prayer,” one of rebuke with authority over the offending spirit: “You mute and deaf spirit, I command you, come out of him and never enter him again.”

The spirit, who had to obey Jesus' commands said in prayer, then made a scene as it came out of the boy, leaving him afterward appearing though as dead. Jesus then changed the boy's state through touching him and raising him up. He knew the boy had been made well, and he showed it.

Jesus later instructed his disciples privately that he had driven out the spirit by prayer. Jesus was teaching his disciples a different side of prayer here, with differences from the private prayer Jesus had instructed them in previously:

'Pray then like this: "Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name. Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread, and forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil. '

Matthew 6:9-13

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.6.9-13>

Instead, in this public, powerful form of prayer, Jesus showed them how to speak not to the Father, saying hallowed be thy name, but to an oppressing spirit, with an authoritative rebuke, including an address ("You mute and deaf spirit"), and commands: "come out of him" and "never enter him again." This caused the kingdom of God to come to this specific occasion on earth, and for the boy and his father to be delivered from the evil that had oppressed the boy and tried to kill him since childhood. Through Jesus' prayer, with faith that what he said would happen, God's will was done. It was the Father's will to have compassion on the boy and his father, and to demonstrate the power of the kingdom of God. Jesus did not his own will, but the will of the Father. Compassion and generosity are part of the very nature of God.

Prayer:

Lord, help my unbelief, taking every cursed thing out of my soul that keeps me from believing Jesus Christ. God, I praise You that it is Your will to be compassionate, and You are always victorious. I thank You that by faith in Jesus' name, I overcome the world. It is my will to do Your will, to rejoice always, to pray continually, and to give thanks in all circumstances.

- Based on Mark 9:24, 1 John 5:4-5, 1 Thessalonians 5:16-18

[Song suggestions for Day 12](#)

Day 13: Jesus sends out Peter among the seventy-two

Before Jesus sent out his followers to proclaim the kingdom of God in the following account, he interacted with some interested in being followers:

'As they were going along the road, someone said to him, "I will follow you wherever you go." And Jesus said to him, "Foxes have holes, and birds of the air have nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay his head." To another he said, "Follow me." But he said, "Lord, let me first go and bury my father." And Jesus said to him, "Leave the dead to bury their own dead. But as for you, go and proclaim the kingdom of God." Yet another said, "I will follow you, Lord, but let me first say farewell to those at my home." Jesus said to him, "No one who puts his hand to the plow and looks back is fit for the kingdom of God.'"

Luke 9:57-62

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.9.57-62>

'After this the Lord appointed seventy-two others and sent them on ahead of him, two by two, into every town and place where he himself was about to go. And he said to them, "The harvest is plentiful, but the laborers are few. Therefore pray earnestly to the Lord of the harvest to send out laborers into his harvest. Go your way; behold, I am sending you out as lambs in the midst of wolves. Carry no moneybag, no knapsack, no sandals, and greet no one on the road. Whatever house you enter, first say, 'Peace be to this house!' And if a son of peace is there, your peace will rest upon him. But if not, it will return to you. And remain in the same house, eating and drinking what they provide, for the laborer deserves his wages. Do not go from house to house. Whenever you enter a town and they receive you, eat what is set before you. Heal the sick in it and say to them, 'The kingdom of God has come near to you.' But whenever you enter a town and they do not receive you, go into its streets and say, 'Even the dust of your town that clings to our feet we wipe off against you. Nevertheless know this, that the kingdom of God has come near.' "The one who hears you hears me, and the one who rejects you rejects me, and the one who rejects me rejects him who sent me." The seventy-two returned with joy, saying, "Lord, even the demons are subject to us in your name!" And he said to them, "I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven. Behold, I have given you authority to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing shall hurt you. Nevertheless, do not rejoice in this, that the spirits are subject to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven.'"

Luke 10:1-11,16-20

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.10.1-11,16-20>

Jesus' interactions with fans of his continued to show what he expected of those who chose to follow him. The first fan said: "I will follow you wherever you go." With the intuition of the Spirit of God that filled him, Jesus knew where this fan stood, and where he would not follow, so he

replied to this fan that he was homeless during his traveling ministry to proclaim the kingdom of God, unlike even the animals. We can presume that this first fan did not follow; becoming homeless was too costly for him. This was one thing he would not do to become a follower.

To a second fan, Jesus directed him, "Follow me." The second fan wanted to first get his affairs in order: "Lord, let me first go and bury my father." This seems like a legitimate request from this fan; he wanted to honor his father and say goodbye to his family first. Jesus knew this fan's heart though, and this fan wasn't willing to count the cost to be a follower; he replied: "Leave the dead to bury their own dead. But as for you, go and proclaim the kingdom of God." Jesus expected obedience of the man to follow him right then, to be made a priority over other good or important things he could instead do. This man's family was dead in spirit, and these affairs would be handled without him; Jesus was commanding him to choose life. This fan was commanded to do what all followers are: "go and proclaim the kingdom of God." We can presume this all was too much for this fan. He was not ready to count the cost to follow right then. His family or his perceived responsibility to his family took importance over Jesus' call to follow.

The third such fan whose interaction with Jesus was recorded was not unlike the second: "I will follow you, Lord, but let me first say farewell to those at my home." Again, this fan seemed to be making a reasonable request, as his family was important to him, so he asked to have Jesus wait for him to say his goodbyes. Jesus saw his hesitation and understood his priorities. The fan's split priority for his family and lack of focus for the work of God made him unfit to become a follower of Jesus.

Peter had left all to follow Jesus.

Jesus clearly wants followers that are ready now to follow him, abide with him, and proclaim the kingdom of God. These will not let even family or home slow them from saying an immediate, unwavering yes to Jesus: "Not my will, but Your will be done... right now." To abide means we hold nothing back, and we let Jesus and the Spirit of God make themselves at home in us, to go anywhere. There is nothing close in priority to Jesus that causes us to hesitate to obey what followers are called to do. We do not plan to stay; we are ready to go and join the work of God to do the will of God. As shoes for our feet, we have put on the readiness given by the gospel of peace (Ephesians 6:15).

We know that many interested to follow Jesus were ready to count the cost, as Jesus did have seventy-two committed followers traveling with him, ready to go, and to them Jesus gave instructions for proclaiming the kingdom of God. Now Jesus was using and training more

followers, compared to the first time it was recorded that Jesus sent out the twelve in a similar manner. We know women were following Jesus too, so it would not be surprising if many women were among the seventy-two.

Moreover, Jesus' strategy was multiplication; he used the 72 to gather yet more laborers for his harvest, i.e., to sow and reap for the kingdom of God. Jesus used his church, of which Peter was a leader, to build the church. Meanwhile, he was training more leaders. They were being trained by doing ministry themselves—without Jesus. They were to follow in his steps.

Jesus had a plan for the towns and places he was about to visit, and he sent his followers ahead of him, two by two, to 36 pre-selected locations. His authority was delegated to them. He informed them they would be lambs among wolves, referring to the spiritual situation: the Spirit of God who went with them to grow the kingdom of God would be opposed by Satan's kingdom.

Jesus instructed his followers: "Carry no moneybag, no knapsack, no sandals, and greet no one on the road." We know the twelve disciples were among the seventy-two, for later he said to them, "When I sent you out with no moneybag or knapsack or sandals, did you lack anything?" (Luke 22:35). They needed to take no provisions, because God was providing for his work to be done according to his will. They needed only to rely on the Spirit of God. They were also to be fixed in attention and purpose on what Jesus was telling them to do, avoiding any possible distractions.

Their mission was to take place in homes, not on the roads. As Jesus had earlier instructed to the twelve, those among the seventy-two, when they entered a house, they were to declare the peace of God: 'Peace be to this house!' By the presence of God that went with them, they would sense either the peace stay on some there or fully return to them. In the towns, they were to stay and operate in a single home as a base for their kingdom work.

Peter went to one of these 36 spots, following the command of Jesus. Peter and the others were to eat and drink what was provided in the homes where they were received, whatever was set before them. God provided for their needs through the people of peace. As Peter had done before when sent out among the twelve to homes (Day 6), Jesus said the seventy-two were to "Heal the sick in it and say to them, 'The kingdom of God has come near to you.'" They were to preach the kingdom of God, just as they saw Jesus do, and they were to demonstrate the power of the kingdom of God, just as they had seen Jesus do. They were to love their neighbors as themselves (Mark 12:31), meeting all of their needs.

The presence of the kingdom of God would come with blessing to those that received these sent by Jesus, and it would come with judgement to any that did not. The followers were to be recognized as the ambassadors of Jesus, as if they were in his place. Since Jesus is the representative of God, to reject Jesus' followers was to reject God.

When the followers prayed for God's will to be done, for seeds to be planted, and they obeyed Jesus by going out to reap the harvest, it was plentiful. They preached the kingdom of God, and the kingdom of God grew. When sent out to heal and preach as ambassadors of Jesus, they recognized their successes with great joy in the following way: "Lord, even the demons are subject to us in your name!"

In reply, Jesus reinforced this understanding of what did happen and showed his spiritual perception into what occurred: "I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven." The seventy-two, as a result of their victories during ministry at these many homes, a direct result of their taking Jesus' authority over all the power of evil, caused defeat to Satan, reducing his authority and dominion. All those oppressed by the devil were set free. The Spirit of God went with them, and they brought the life of Jesus, multiplying the grace and peace of God.

Jesus had sent them "out as lambs in the midst of wolves," and yet nothing was able to hurt them by any means. In their faith to go as ambassadors of Christ, obeying God's will, they were completely protected in the midst of those that would try to hurt them. The enemy was no match for the power of the kingdom of God that had come near. Jesus instructed them not to rejoice in their many victories over evil—that God's will was being done on earth as it is in heaven—but instead just that their names were written in heaven. They were saved (sozo). They were children of God, beloved to him (John 1:12-13). Their identity was the true source of exceeding joy.

Prayer:

Lord, I praise you that You are my banner, my refuge (Nissi). God, I thank You that by my faith in Jesus, I extinguish all the flaming darts of the evil one, and that when I go and when I speak in Jesus' name, you cause my words to become spirit and life.

- Based on Psalm 20:5-7, Ephesians 6:19-20, John 6:63

[Song suggestions for Day 13](#)

Selah: Counting the cost

Selah is a Hebrew word that has been found at the ending of verses in certain Psalms. It calls for a break in the singing of the Psalm for contemplation. It's also been traditionally interpreted as a blessing meaning "forever."

Up until this point, we have discussed who the living Jesus is as experienced by Peter. According to Scripture, 'Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever. '

Hebrews 13:8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/HEB.13.8>

Jesus has not changed. He is the kindness and tenderness of God, and He calls all of humanity to repentance because the kingdom of God is at hand, 'for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, '

Romans 3:23

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ROM.3.23>

and He offers grace to save you wholly, paid for by the great cost of His suffering and death that is legally able to make you right with God.

We have also discussed the cost of following Jesus. We are not merely fans of Jesus, holding back some of ourselves and our own lives. God asks for everything from us.

Knowing the cost, will you commit to follow Jesus? Will you forsake your own will for your life and choose to seek and serve the Lord, choosing to make God's will Your own?

'...if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For with the heart one believes and is justified, and with the mouth one confesses and is saved. For the Scripture says, "Everyone who believes in him will not be put to shame." For there is no distinction between Jew and Greek; for the same Lord is Lord of all, bestowing his riches on all who call on him. For "everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved." '

Romans 10:9-13

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ROM.10.9-13>

If in prayer and publicly, you confess your faith in Jesus now, God identifies you fully with Jesus Christ, crucifying your sin with Him through his suffering and death, taking any infirmities, any pains, any sicknesses; and raising you up a new creation in Christ Jesus:

'Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come. All this is from God, who through Christ reconciled us to himself and gave us the ministry of reconciliation; that is, in Christ God was reconciling the world to himself, not counting their trespasses against them, and entrusting to us the message of reconciliation. Therefore, we are ambassadors for Christ, God making his appeal through us. We implore you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God. For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.'

2 Corinthians 5:17-21

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2CO.5.17-21>

God's word is true, unable to be broken, and your belief and decision to abide in it and in Jesus Christ sets you free and gives you life (zoe), now and forever. Jesus Christ forgives you and makes you righteous, sinless before him. He makes your spirit alive and makes you whole, spirit, soul and body.

Give thanks to the Lord, for He is good. Rejoice in the God of your salvation. Praise him, for He delights to show mercy and compassion. He is generous beyond anyone or anything you have ever known.

God also rejoices in you, an image bearer and dear child of his, having been brought to life:

' The Lord your God is in your midst, a mighty one who will save; he will rejoice over you with gladness; he will quiet you by his love; he will exult over you with loud singing. '

Zephaniah 3:17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ZEP.3.17>

Put your trust fully in the Lord, who calls you his beloved. Remember Him and put Him first always. Nothing will ever be the same.

Prayer:

Blessed are You, God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to Your great mercy, You have set me free and caused me to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for me. I love You with all my heart, all my soul, all my mind, all my strength, everything that is within me!

- Based on 1 Peter 1:3-4, John 8:32, Deuteronomy 6:4-7, Mark 12:30

[Song suggestions for Selah](#)

Day 14: Jesus tells us to be ready

Today we encounter some parables of Jesus about being ready.

' "Stay dressed for action and keep your lamps burning, and be like men who are waiting for their master to come home from the wedding feast, so that they may open the door to him at once when he comes and knocks. Blessed are those servants whom the master finds awake when he comes. Truly, I say to you, he will dress himself for service and have them recline at table, and he will come and serve them. If he comes in the second watch, or in the third, and finds them awake, blessed are those servants! But know this, that if the master of the house had known at what hour the thief was coming, he would not have left his house to be broken into. You also must be ready, for the Son of Man is coming at an hour you do not expect." Peter said, "Lord, are you telling this parable for us or for all?" And the Lord said, "Who then is the faithful and wise manager, whom his master will set over his household, to give them their portion of food at the proper time? Blessed is that servant whom his master will find so doing when he comes. Truly, I say to you, he will set him over all his possessions. But if that servant says to himself, 'My master is delayed in coming,' and begins to beat the male and female servants, and to eat and drink and get drunk, the master of that servant will come on a day when he does not expect him and at an hour he does not know, and will cut him in pieces and put him with the unfaithful. And that servant who knew his master's will but did not get ready or act according to his will, will receive a severe beating. But the one who did not know, and did what deserved a beating, will receive a light beating. Everyone to whom much was given, of him much will be required, and from him to whom they entrusted much, they will demand the more. '

Luke 12:35-48

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.12.35-48>

In the end of a parable, Peter asked Jesus, "Lord, are you telling this parable for us or for all?" The lack of the answer seems to answer the question: "This isn't just about you, Peter, and I'm not done yet. I'm speaking to everybody."

How is it that we are to be ready, according to Jesus?

Those who are found ready remember who they are, know the master's will, remember the master's will, and act according to his will.

We are to be "dressed for action" and keep our lamps burning, knowing that Jesus may return at any time for his wedding feast with his church. As the church, we are the bride of Christ.

Sanctified by Jesus, we are to be dressed in white, made spotless. We are to use our position in Christ as those who have been made righteous for victory after victory over sin.

We are to be ready to “open the door to him at once when he comes and knocks.” We are to stay alert, be aware, and keep watch. We are to be found awake.

We are to be faithful and wise managers, or stewards, remembering that nothing we have been given belongs to us. Every good and perfect gift comes from God, and we are expected to manage it wisely. This includes anything we have received:

our money,

our time,

our energy,

our family,

our relationships outside of family,

any position,

any responsibility,

any ability,

any gift,

our free will.

We have no right to call it “mine.” We are to recognize it to be from God and manage it appropriately. To those whom much is given, more is expected.

It is not about us. Never. It is not appropriate to decide our master is delayed in coming, then begin to live according to our own will.

Those who know the truth, yet forget who they are and serve themselves instead of God, saying, “my will be done,” will receive punishment, according to Jesus’ teaching.

Instead, we are to live ready as children of God, servants of all, stewards, to whom much has been entrusted.

Those who are found ready remember who they are, know the master’s will, remember the master’s will, and act according to his will.

Prayer:

Father, I present myself as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to You. I renew my mind to Your Word, O God, putting on the new self, created after Your likeness in righteousness. Your kingdom come, Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

- Based on Romans 12:2, Ephesians 4:24, Matthew 6:10

[Song suggestions for Day 14](#)

Day 15: Peter acknowledges Jesus has the words of eternal life

In today's passage of Scripture, Jesus spoke to his disciples and a crowd about eternal life. Jesus told the crowd they were seeking him because they ate their fill of the loaves (v. 26). Jesus had fed them, and they wanted more.

'Then they said to him, "What must we do, to be doing the works of God?" Jesus answered them, "This is the work of God, that you believe in him whom he has sent." So they said to him, "Then what sign do you do, that we may see and believe you? What work do you perform? Our fathers ate the manna in the wilderness; as it is written, 'He gave them bread from heaven to eat.'" Jesus then said to them, "Truly, truly, I say to you, it was not Moses who gave you the bread from heaven, but my Father gives you the true bread from heaven. For the bread of God is he who comes down from heaven and gives life to the world." They said to him, "Sir, give us this bread always." Jesus said to them, "I am the bread of life; whoever comes to me shall not hunger, and whoever believes in me shall never thirst. But I said to you that you have seen me and yet do not believe. All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out. For I have come down from heaven, not to do my own will but the will of him who sent me. And this is the will of him who sent me, that I should lose nothing of all that he has given me, but raise it up on the last day. For this is the will of my Father, that everyone who looks on the Son and believes in him should have eternal life, and I will raise him up on the last day." So the Jews grumbled about him, because he said, "I am the bread that came down from heaven." They said, "Is not this Jesus, the son of Joseph, whose father and mother we know? How does he now say, 'I have come down from heaven'?" Jesus answered them, "Do not grumble among yourselves. No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him. And I will raise him up on the last day. It is written in the Prophets, 'And they will all be taught by God.' Everyone who has heard and learned from the Father comes to me— not that anyone has seen the Father except he who is from God; he has seen the Father. Truly, truly, I say to you, whoever believes has eternal life. I am the bread of life. Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died. This is the bread that comes down from heaven, so that one may eat of it and not die. I am the living bread that came down from heaven. If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever. And the bread that I will give for the life of the world is my flesh." The Jews then disputed among themselves, saying, "How can this man give us his flesh to eat?" So Jesus said to them, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life in you. Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up on the last day. For my flesh is true food, and my blood is true drink. Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood abides in me, and I in him. As the living Father sent me, and I live because of the Father, so whoever feeds on me, he also will live because of me. This is the bread that came down from heaven, not like the bread the fathers

ate, and died. Whoever feeds on this bread will live forever.” Jesus said these things in the synagogue, as he taught at Capernaum. When many of his disciples heard it, they said, “This is a hard saying; who can listen to it?” But Jesus, knowing in himself that his disciples were grumbling about this, said to them, “Do you take offense at this? Then what if you were to see the Son of Man ascending to where he was before? It is the Spirit who gives life; the flesh is no help at all. The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life. But there are some of you who do not believe.” (For Jesus knew from the beginning who those were who did not believe, and who it was who would betray him.) And he said, “This is why I told you that no one can come to me unless it is granted him by the Father.” After this many of his disciples turned back and no longer walked with him. So Jesus said to the twelve, “Do you want to go away as well?” Simon Peter answered him, “Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life, and we have believed, and have come to know, that you are the Holy One of God.” ‘

John 6:28-69

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.6.28-69>

Jesus told the crowd it’s not about the good works they did; it’s important instead that they believed that Jesus was sent by God. They had already seen miracles, yet they asked to see more. Interested mainly in food—or bread, a main source of food in that time—they asked to receive manna from heaven, even as their ancestors did when they were in the desert with Moses after being freed from slavery in Egypt.

Jesus redirected the conversation from the provision of food to their belief: they should understand that the manna was from their living Father in heaven, and so was Jesus. Jesus turned the conversation from the physical to the spiritual: “my Father gives you the true bread from heaven. For the bread of God is he who comes down from heaven and gives life to the world.” Jesus was sent not to feed them, meeting a temporary physical need for them, but to give life to the world, meeting every critical need for those who believe in him.

It is the Spirit who gives life, and Jesus’ words are spirit and life (zoe). This is the life Jesus offers. Fundamentally, God is life, and in Jesus now he offers a choice between life in choosing him and death in rejecting him. The life offered is eternal life, and yet choosing it in faith also leads to abundant life now. Those who choose it do not hunger or thirst; they are satisfied.

This is the true bread of which Jesus spoke. He is the bread of life, the source of life. Those who the Father had given to Jesus would believe his words and be raised to life with Jesus, according to God’s will.

Yet many in the crowd did not believe his words nor the signs that they had seen from Jesus. Perhaps it was just food, intrigue, and a show. At least some of them, probably having traveled to Capernaum from Nazareth, knew his parents. Many were not drawn by God to believe him.

Next, Jesus turned the teaching centered around bread to something most would not understand, a reference to communion, seemingly in part to thin the crowd to those committed to him: “Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life in you. Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up on the last day. For my flesh is true food, and my blood is true drink. Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood abides in me, and I in him. As the living Father sent me, and I live because of the Father, so whoever feeds on me, he also will live because of me. This is the bread that came down from heaven, not like the bread the fathers ate, and died. Whoever feeds on this bread will live forever.”

Jesus referred here to choosing life in him through belief in, communion with, and discipleship under him. This belief would lead the true disciples to life and to obedience to his command to take communion, which represents the blood and body of Jesus sacrificed to provide the life (zoe) of which he spoke. This is the abiding relationship in Jesus as the Vine, the source of life. None of those present understood him, as he spoke of the future—and again of things spiritual rather than physical. He also claimed to be the Son of Man, saying he would ascend to the Father.

Many listeners were not ready for this. “After this many of his disciples turned back and no longer walked with him.” It was not only much of the unbelieving crowd that left him at this point, but also disciples. This likely referred to some of the seventy-two that Jesus had already sent out as his ambassadors to heal and preach the gospel. Some had believed initially and been used by him, and yet their faith did not persevere through these difficult-to-understand, to-them unbelievable, or seemingly blasphemous words of Jesus. Yet they were words of spirit and of life. Even so, Jesus knew some of his disciples would betray him.

This did not include the twelve disciples, of course. Jesus said to them, “Do you want to go away as well?”

‘Simon Peter answered him, “Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life, and we have believed, and have come to know, that you are the Holy One of God.” ’

Peter led the twelve in these renewed words of commitment. They had heard Jesus say words they did not understand before, so they were ready enough for this moment. Sown on good

soil, they took him at his word and believed him (Mark 14:14-20). They knew him as the chosen one, the source of life. They had left everything to follow him and would continue to do so.

Prayer:

I thank You, Jesus, that You came to give me life so I may have it abundantly. As a branch connected to you as the Vine, I ever abide in You, and your words abide in me. Your words have become to me a joy and the delight of my heart.

- Based on John 10:29, John 15:4-7, Jeremiah 15:6

[Song suggestions for Day 15](#)

Day 16: Peter notices that a fig tree cursed by Jesus has withered

The following account occurred just after Jesus' triumphal entry into Jerusalem where he was welcomed as a king in fulfillment of Old Testament prophecy.

' And he entered Jerusalem and went into the temple. And when he had looked around at everything, as it was already late, he went out to Bethany with the twelve. On the following day, when they came from Bethany, he was hungry. And seeing in the distance a fig tree in leaf, he went to see if he could find anything on it. When he came to it, he found nothing but leaves, for it was not the season for figs. And he said to it, "May no one ever eat fruit from you again." And his disciples heard it. And they came to Jerusalem. And he entered the temple and began to drive out those who sold and those who bought in the temple, and he overturned the tables of the money-changers and the seats of those who sold pigeons. And he would not allow anyone to carry anything through the temple. And he was teaching them and saying to them, "Is it not written, 'My house shall be called a house of prayer for all the nations'? But you have made it a den of robbers." And the chief priests and the scribes heard it and were seeking a way to destroy him, for they feared him, because all the crowd was astonished at his teaching. And when evening came they went out of the city. As they passed by in the morning, they saw the fig tree withered away to its roots. And Peter remembered and said to him, "Rabbi, look! The fig tree that you cursed has withered." And Jesus answered them, "Have faith in God. Truly, I say to you, whoever says to this mountain, 'Be taken up and thrown into the sea,' and does not doubt in his heart, but believes that what he says will come to pass, it will be done for him. Therefore I tell you, whatever you ask in prayer, believe that you have received it, and it will be yours. And whenever you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone, so that your Father also who is in heaven may forgive you your trespasses." '

Mark 11:11-25

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.11.11-25>

Jesus had seen the state of the temple in Jerusalem before he went to spend the night in Bethany. It appears that Jesus found the temple just as it was the first time he drove out the sellers with a whip of cords close to the beginning of his public ministry:

' The Passover of the Jews was at hand, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem. In the temple he found those who were selling oxen and sheep and pigeons, and the money-changers sitting there. And making a whip of cords, he drove them all out of the temple, with the sheep and oxen. And he poured out the coins of the money-changers and overturned their tables. And he told those who sold the pigeons, "Take these things away; do not make my Father's house a house of trade." His disciples remembered that it was written, "Zeal for your house will consume me." '

John 2:13-17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.2.13-17>

There was injustice going on in his Father's house, as animals were sold to mostly poor Jewish people, who had traveled to Jerusalem to make sacrifices, at exorbitant prices. Just as with David, zeal for God's house consumed Jesus. He threw over tables, and he drove them out with a whip!

At the end of Jesus's ministry, nothing had changed in the temple, and Jesus was again incensed that his Father's house was being used as a house of trade. It was late, and those who bought and sold in the temple were gone, so he led his disciples to stay in Bethany for the night. It's very likely that they stayed with Mary, Martha, and Lazarus of Bethany, whom Jesus had just raised from the dead with a simple cry of "Lazarus, come out" (John 11:43).

In the morning, Jesus was headed back to the temple in Jerusalem to drive out those who should not be there because it was the right thing to do. On the way there, he was hungry. When he came to the fig tree that had no fruit for him while out of season, perhaps he was feeling hangry. Or perhaps he was just setting up a teaching moment with his disciples. In any case, when he found no fruit to satisfy his hunger on the fig tree, he cursed it while in earshot of Peter, saying, "May no one ever eat fruit from you again."

Then Jesus headed for the temple: "And he entered the temple and began to drive out those who sold and those who bought in the temple, and he overturned the tables of the money-changers and the seats of those who sold pigeons. And he would not allow anyone to carry anything through the temple."

We saw before that while spending time with all the crowds, Jesus was gentle and tender, showing compassion to all. Yet, this situation in the temple caused great offense to him, and he thought it right to stir things up in such situations, as he also sometimes did with the Jewish experts of the law. He was countercultural, and he had no fear of men. He again created a scene in the temple before the Jews. He gave offense to the leaders of Jews who had allowed this to happen in the temple, unwilling to compromise the truth of the Word of God. Jesus did what was right.

Then Jesus taught in the temple, presumably all day, causing astonishment to many, enough to bring fear to the scribes and Pharisees. Among his teachings, he said: "Is it not written, 'My house shall be called a house of prayer for all the nations'? But you have made it a den of robbers."

Jesus confronted the traditions of men that were wrong. According to Isaiah 56, God's "house shall be called a house of prayer for all peoples" (v. 7); God values justice and righteousness (v.1), the Jew as well as the foreigner who has joined himself to the Lord (v. 3,6). Yet the leaders of the Jews were "blind" and "without knowledge" (v. 10)... "they [were] shepherds who [had] no understanding; they [had] all turned to their own way" (v. 11). Their traditions made God's holy temple a den of robbers. Separating himself from the wicked, Jesus gave offense to the leaders of the Jews in his actions and then he gave offense with his words as he taught the people what was right in the eyes of God.

At the end of the day, it seems they went back to Bethany to stay the night, because on the way back to the temple in Jerusalem in the morning, soon to be challenged by the chief priests and elders of the Jews (see Matthew 21:23), they passed by the same fig tree where Jesus had tried to find fruit the morning before:

'As they passed by in the morning, they saw the fig tree withered away to its roots. And Peter remembered and said to him, "Rabbi, look! The fig tree that you cursed has withered." '

Jesus took this occasion to teach his disciples about faith, about their words, and about prayer: 'And Jesus answered them, "Have faith in God. Truly, I say to you, whoever says to this mountain, 'Be taken up and thrown into the sea,' and does not doubt in his heart, but believes that what he says will come to pass, it will be done for him. Therefore I tell you, whatever you ask [aiteo] in prayer, believe that you have received it, and it will be yours. And whenever you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone, so that your Father also who is in heaven may forgive you your trespasses." '

On an earlier occasion, Jesus drove out a spirit by prayer that some of the disciples could not, saying to it, "I command you, come out of him and never enter him again." (Mark 9, see Day 12)

Here Jesus commanded a fig tree, "May no one ever eat fruit from you again," and life was taken from it. The tree withered away all the way to its roots by the power of the one who gives life. In answer to Peter's exclamation about this, Jesus spoke about prayer and commands, suggesting that what he said or what they said in the presence of God, albeit aloud and heard by others, was said in prayer.

Oftentimes, Jesus just meant what he said. For Jesus and for followers of Jesus, their words and our words have spiritual weight, and when faith in God is firm and our belief is unwavering, God answers our prayers, and the spiritual affects the physical. Life was taken from the fig tree, yet the effect of this was not instantaneous. It took some time for the tree to shrivel.

Sometimes the way Jesus prayed or taught the disciples to pray seemed to be less of an ask and more of a demand. Perhaps this is not surprising since the word for ask in Greek, *aiteo*, is used also as request, petition, or demand.

Jesus told his followers they may speak to things physical and spiritual, living or not living, in prayer, and ask or demand, believing they had received it, and it would be theirs. Jesus spoke this to faithful, obedient followers of Jesus who had taken God's will as their will; they were not doing their own will. They were following in Jesus' steps, abiding with him.

Jesus told his followers they should be confident in what they asked for or what they demanded, confident that God heard and that they would have it. He also modeled this spirit of faith. This is from the account of raising Lazarus days before:

'Jesus said to [Martha], "Did I not tell you that if you believed you would see the glory of God?" So they took away the stone. And Jesus lifted up his eyes and said, "Father, I thank you that you have heard me. I knew that you always hear me, but I said this on account of the people standing around, that they may believe that you sent me." When he had said these things, he cried out with a loud voice, "Lazarus, come out." The man who had died came out, his hands and feet bound with linen strips, and his face wrapped with a cloth. Jesus said to them, "Unbind him, and let him go." '

John 11:40-44

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.11.40-44>

Jesus' words were spirit and they were life. He received what he commanded.

Recall also that in an earlier passage (see Day 6), Jesus had sent Peter out among his twelve disciples and commanded: "...proclaim as you go, saying, 'The kingdom of heaven is at hand.' Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse lepers, cast out demons." Jesus included, "...raise the dead." And they obeyed. And it created a stir (see Day 6), just as Jesus did again when he raised Lazarus. God's almighty spirit was applied through them to meet every need.

Jesus' disciples were sent out as ambassadors in the place of Jesus, God making his appeal through them. Sending out the seventy-two (Day 13), Jesus said, "The one who hears you hears me ..."

Jesus also said, "For he whom God has sent utters the words of God, for he gives the Spirit without measure" (John 3:34).

Teaching about prayer, Jesus also said: “And whenever you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone, so that your Father also who is in heaven may forgive you your trespasses.” The disciples were taught that they should hold nothing against anyone. This included even enemies (Luke 6:27-28). God expects us to forgive everyone, just as we have been forgiven by him.

Prayer:

Father, quicken me after your lovingkindness. So shall I keep the testimony of your mouth.

Forever, O Lord, Your word is settled in heaven.

- Based on Psalm 119:88-89

[Song suggestions for Day 16](#)

Day 17: Peter tries to keep Jesus from washing his feet

The following account takes place in the upper room the evening Jesus was betrayed by Judas: 'Now before the Feast of the Passover, when Jesus knew that his hour had come to depart out of this world to the Father, having loved his own who were in the world, he loved them to the end. During supper, when the devil had already put it into the heart of Judas Iscariot, Simon's son, to betray him, Jesus, knowing that the Father had given all things into his hands, and that he had come from God and was going back to God, rose from supper. He laid aside his outer garments, and taking a towel, tied it around his waist. Then he poured water into a basin and began to wash the disciples' feet and to wipe them with the towel that was wrapped around him. He came to Simon Peter, who said to him, "Lord, do you wash my feet?" Jesus answered him, "What I am doing you do not understand now, but afterward you will understand." Peter said to him, "You shall never wash my feet." Jesus answered him, "If I do not wash you, you have no share with me." Simon Peter said to him, "Lord, not my feet only but also my hands and my head!" Jesus said to him, "The one who has bathed does not need to wash, except for his feet, but is completely clean. And you are clean, but not every one of you." For he knew who was to betray him; that was why he said, "Not all of you are clean." When he had washed their feet and put on his outer garments and resumed his place, he said to them, "Do you understand what I have done to you? You call me Teacher and Lord, and you are right, for so I am. If I then, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another's feet. For I have given you an example, that you also should do just as I have done to you. Truly, truly, I say to you, a servant is not greater than his master, nor is a messenger greater than the one who sent him. If you know these things, blessed are you if you do them. '

John 13:1-17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.13.1-17>

To set the stage for today's passage, the gospel of Luke records the following that happened the same evening in the upper room: "A dispute arose among [the disciples], as to which of them was to be regarded as the greatest" (Luke 22:24). In the presence of the King, the disciples jockeyed for position. This was not their first time doing so (see Mark 9-10 for two instances), and they had been corrected by Jesus before. Apparently, the words of Jesus regarding being great in the kingdom of God hadn't been received.

On this occasion of their last supper together, Jesus left his position at the table, removed his outer garments, and took the position of a servant, beginning to wash their feet. Traditionally, people wore sandals at this time, and the roads were dirty, so it was traditional for a servant to wash the feet of guests when they came into one's home to eat. This was a menial job, so it was

unbelievable to the disciples that their Lord and their rabbi would take such a position. They were the followers, not the other way around; and this was the Messiah, the very Son of God.

The attitude of disbelief is revealed by Peter's words as Jesus makes his way to Peter: "Lord, do you wash my feet?" Peter's incredulity next led to offense at what Jesus did: "You shall never wash my feet." Peter felt outrage that his Messiah would humble himself in such a way. The one who before rebuked Jesus for saying he would suffer and be killed (see Day 10), now prohibited this posture of servanthood. It was inconsistent with his view of who the Messiah was. He wouldn't allow it.

On the last occasion of such opposition, Jesus had rebuked Peter as Satan. In this intimate circumstance, the Son of God chose to tenderly correct Peter, "If I do not wash you, you have no share with me."

With a teachable spirit, the passionate Peter responded: "Lord, not my feet only but also my hands and my head!" If his master said accepting this service from Jesus was about abiding with him, then Peter preferred to be fully bathed, as if to say, "I'll take a sponge bath then." Peter often was a stand out among the twelve.

Jesus replied to Peter: "The one who has bathed does not need to wash, except for his feet, but is completely clean." Only the foot washing was necessary. Jesus made Peter and the others clean, all but Judas. In following and obeying Jesus, the eleven had been put in right standing, or made righteous, before God, by the Righteous One.

After washing his disciples' feet, Jesus resumed his place and began to teach them, starting with a question, "Do you understand what I have done to you?" Likely there was no response, only pause.

Jesus answered the question: "You call me Teacher and Lord, and you are right, for so I am. If I then, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another's feet. For I have given you an example, that you also should do just as I have done to you. Truly, truly, I say to you, a servant is not greater than his master, nor is a messenger greater than the one who sent him. If you know these things, blessed are you if you do them."

Counter to expectation, Jesus taught them that they were to be servants of mankind, humbling themselves to be such, just as he had taught them by his example. They were not just to think of themselves as servants; they were to become servants. Like no kingdom on earth to that day, this is Jesus' kingdom way that leads to the blessing of God.

Prayer:

I praise You, Father, for showing us Your way for us in Jesus, who came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.

- Based on Mark 10:45

[Song suggestions for Day 17](#)

Day 18: Following communion, Jesus predicts Peter's denial

Today we examine another account of the same day from the gospel of Mark:

' And as they were eating, [Jesus] took bread, and after blessing it broke it and gave it to them, and said, "Take; this is my body." And he took a cup, and when he had given thanks he gave it to them, and they all drank of it. And he said to them, "This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many. Truly, I say to you, I will not drink again of the fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it new in the kingdom of God." And when they had sung a hymn, they went out to the Mount of Olives. And Jesus said to them, "You will all fall away, for it is written, 'I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered.' But after I am raised up, I will go before you to Galilee." Peter said to him, "Even though they all fall away, I will not." And Jesus said to him, "Truly, I tell you, this very night, before the rooster crows twice, you will deny me three times." But he said emphatically, "If I must die with you, I will not deny you." And they all said the same. And they went to a place called Gethsemane. And he said to his disciples, "Sit here while I pray." And he took with him Peter and James and John, and began to be greatly distressed and troubled. And he said to them, "My soul is very sorrowful, even to death. Remain here and watch." And going a little farther, he fell on the ground and prayed that, if it were possible, the hour might pass from him. And he said, "Abba, Father, all things are possible for you. Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will." And he came and found them sleeping, and he said to Peter, "Simon, are you asleep? Could you not watch one hour? Watch and pray that you may not enter into temptation. The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak." And again he went away and prayed, saying the same words. And again he came and found them sleeping, for their eyes were very heavy, and they did not know what to answer him. And he came the third time and said to them, "Are you still sleeping and taking your rest? It is enough; the hour has come. The Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners. '

Mark 14:22-41

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.14.22-41>

In the upper room where Jesus had washed the feet of the disciples, he also first had communion with them. Jesus had already taught his disciples about this, although they had not understood it at the time (Day 15):

"Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life in you. Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up on the last day. For my flesh is true food, and my blood is true drink. Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood abides in me, and I in him. As the living Father sent me, and I live because of the Father, so whoever feeds on me, he also will live because of me. This is

the bread that came down from heaven, not like the bread the fathers ate, and died. Whoever feeds on this bread will live forever.”

The bread Jesus blessed represented his body that was about to be broken for them, the bread of life. Jesus taught there is eternal life in it.

About this body, Peter wrote:

'He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed. '

1 Peter 2:24

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.2.24>

The wine represented Jesus' blood that was about to be shed, the blood of the new covenant, the new testament, that changed everything for humanity.

About communion, the Apostle Paul wrote:

'Whoever, therefore, eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty concerning the body and blood of the Lord. Let a person examine himself, then, and so eat of the bread and drink of the cup. For anyone who eats and drinks without discerning the body eats and drinks judgment on himself. That is why many of you are weak and ill, and some have died. But if we judged ourselves truly, we would not be judged. But when we are judged by the Lord, we are disciplined so that we may not be condemned along with the world. '

1 Corinthians 11:27-32

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1CO.11.27-32>

Paul taught that we should examine and judge ourselves in communion with the Lord, and that the body, the bread of life, should be discerned, as it impacts our health in this world. Regarding this body that bore our sins on a tree, Peter taught, “By his wounds you have been healed.”

Communion is also to be taken as means of intimacy, of abiding in Christ: “Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood abides in me, and I in him.” He is the true Vine, his followers are the branches, and the Father is the vinedresser (John 15:1-5). It continues the intimacy Christ had with his followers in the upper room, except afterwards, as Jesus noted, it is in the kingdom of God. The kingdom was no longer near; instead, it had come with the new covenant of his blood, “the fruit of the vine,” shed for us.

After the intimacy of their first communion, they sang a hymn together—praise to the Father—then departed for the Mount of Olives.

Jesus said to them, "You will all fall away, for it is written, 'I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered.' But after I am raised up, I will go before you to Galilee."

Peter saw himself as the exception: "Even though they all fall away, I will not."

The gospel of Luke records the following exchange as part of this conversation:

' "Simon, Simon, behold, Satan demanded to have you, that he might sift you like wheat, but I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail. And when you have turned again, strengthen your brothers." Peter said to him, "Lord, I am ready to go with you both to prison and to death."

Luke 22:31-33

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.22.31-33>

Jesus revealed to Peter what had happened in the spiritual dimension, the real one Jesus was able to sense outside of normal human 3 dimensions and 5 senses. This reality of Satan making arguments before God is consistent not only with the account of Job but also with the way Satan was described in Revelation 12:10 as one who accuses the people of God day and night. Jesus prayed for Peter that his faith would not fail, and his prayers were answered.

The gospel of John records the following exchange:

'Simon Peter said to him, "Lord, where are you going?" Jesus answered him, "Where I am going you cannot follow me now, but you will follow afterward." Peter said to him, "Lord, why can I not follow you now? I will lay down my life for you."

John 13:36-37

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.13.36-37>

Jesus replied: "Truly, I tell you, this very night, before the rooster crows twice, you will deny me three times."

This is a very specific prediction from the one Peter should have learned to take as the authority. Yet Peter was emphatic, correcting Jesus: "If I must die with you, I will not deny you." Peter was willing to die with Jesus in spirit, or in intention.

Peter was the leader, and the rest of the disciples said the same. Wouldn't we also have?

At Gethsemane, Jesus instructed his disciples, "Sit here while I pray."

And Jesus took with him Peter and James and John still further, even as he had chosen them to see the transfiguration (Day 11). Jesus, deeply troubled, instructed the three of them, “Remain here and watch,” and Jesus went still a little further.

The moment had come. Jesus was about to be abandoned to the whim of the devil. He fell to the ground in prayer, praying for God’s will to be done.

When Jesus checked back on Peter, Peter had not stayed awake and watched as told. Jesus had to wake him up: “Simon, are you asleep? Could you not watch one hour? Watch and pray that you may not enter into temptation. The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak.” Peter’s flesh was weak, as is ours.

Jesus returned to pray, soaking up the presence of the Father, submitting to his will.

“And again he came and found them sleeping, for their eyes were very heavy, and they did not know what to answer him.” Really? Again? They had no words.

Jesus left to pray a third time, the last time.

“And he came the third time and said to them, ‘Are you still sleeping and taking your rest? It is enough; the hour has come. The Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners.’ ”

Yes, the flesh is weak.

Prayer:

Jesus, thank You for Your body, broken for me.

- Based on 1 Corinthians 11:24-32

[Song suggestions for Day 18](#)

Day 19: In the passion of a moment, Peter lops off the ear of a Roman soldier

Luke records the following conversation on the way up to the Mount of Olives:

'And [Jesus] said to them, "When I sent you out with no moneybag or knapsack or sandals, did you lack anything?" They said, "Nothing." He said to them, "But now let the one who has a moneybag take it, and likewise a knapsack. And let the one who has no sword sell his cloak and buy one. For I tell you that this Scripture must be fulfilled in me: 'And he was numbered with the transgressors.' For what is written about me has its fulfillment." And they said, "Look, Lord, here are two swords." And he said to them, "It is enough." '

Luke 22:35-38

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.22.35-38>

Jesus referred back to his instructions to the seventy-two. Peter was sent out among them to preach and to heal. They chose to go in the place of Jesus in obedience to him, and they needed nothing. The Father provided for them.

Here Jesus told them again that they would not choose Jesus in the events that followed. Jesus would be taken and numbered with the transgressors—the prophecy of Isaiah 53 was about to play out—and they would be on their own, without provision, without protection, even as Jesus was on his own. At Jesus' urging, they bought two swords that they saw for sale as they walked. Knowing how events would play out, Jesus thought it best that they were not unarmed.

We turn now to John's account at the garden of Gethsemane:

'When Jesus had spoken these words, he went out with his disciples across the brook Kidron, where there was a garden, which he and his disciples entered. Now Judas, who betrayed him, also knew the place, for Jesus often met there with his disciples. So Judas, having procured a band of soldiers and some officers from the chief priests and the Pharisees, went there with lanterns and torches and weapons. Then Jesus, knowing all that would happen to him, came forward and said to them, "Whom do you seek?" They answered him, "Jesus of Nazareth." Jesus said to them, "I am he." Judas, who betrayed him, was standing with them. When Jesus said to them, "I am he," they drew back and fell to the ground. So he asked them again, "Whom do you seek?" And they said, "Jesus of Nazareth." Jesus answered, "I told you that I am he. So, if you seek me, let these men go." This was to fulfill the word that he had spoken: "Of those whom you gave me I have lost not one." Then Simon Peter, having a sword, drew it and struck the high priest's servant and cut off his right ear. (The servant's name was Malchus.) So Jesus said to Peter, "Put your sword into its sheath; shall I not drink the cup that the Father has given me?" '

John 18:1-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.18.1-11>

Luke's account gives some additional detail:

'While he was still speaking, there came a crowd, and the man called Judas, one of the twelve, was leading them. He drew near to Jesus to kiss him, but Jesus said to him, "Judas, would you betray the Son of Man with a kiss?" And when those who were around him saw what would follow, they said, "Lord, shall we strike with the sword?" And one of them struck the servant of the high priest and cut off his right ear. But Jesus said, "No more of this!" And he touched his ear and healed him. Then Jesus said to the chief priests and officers of the temple and elders, who had come out against him, "Have you come out as against a robber, with swords and clubs? When I was with you day after day in the temple, you did not lay hands on me. But this is your hour, and the power of darkness." '

Luke 22:47-53

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.22.35-38,47-53>

In the garden, Peter and the disciples saw Judas come toward them with a crowd: "...a band of soldiers and some officers from the chief priests and the Pharisees, went there with lanterns and torches and weapons." The Romans and leaders of the Jews had confronted them.

Jesus, knowing what would happen, asked Judas if he would betray Jesus with a kiss. He asked them whom they sought.

When he identified himself as Jesus of Nazareth, the one they sought, "they drew back and fell to the ground."

Jesus asked them a second time, "Whom do you seek?" After identifying himself again, he insisted they let his disciples go.

Some of the disciples, meanwhile, were confused about how to respond as the crowd came for Jesus, saying, "Lord, shall we strike with the sword?"

At about the same time, one of them, Peter, had no such question: "Then Simon Peter, having a sword, drew it and struck the high priest's servant and cut off his right ear. (The servant's name was Malchus.)"

Peter was making good on what he had said earlier, "If I must die with you, I will not deny you."

But this was not how Jesus was to die. Jesus immediately brought this to a stop: “No more of this!” This was not Jesus’ intended purpose for the swords.

He said to Peter, “Put your sword into its sheath; shall I not drink the cup that the Father has given me?” Jesus was referring to the suffering he was about to endure in obedience to the Father.

Jesus touched Malchus’ ear, and it was instantly healed. Peter had made a dangerous mistake, and Jesus made it right. He again demonstrated the authority and the way of his kingdom; it is not the conventional way of men, by physical force. Jesus did not encourage any fight against flesh and blood, but instead he fought the oppression of the kingdom of Satan using the power of the kingdom of God, and he taught his disciples to do the same.

Jesus then addressed the leaders of the Jews, “Have you come out as against a robber, with swords and clubs? When I was with you day after day in the temple, you did not lay hands on me. But this is your hour, and the power of darkness.”

Jesus submitted himself to the power of darkness because it was God’s will that he do so. So they took only him.

Despite Peter’s impulsive action, the crowd didn’t go after the disciples. This was to fulfill what Jesus has said earlier (see Day 15):

'And this is the will of him who sent me, that I should lose nothing of all that he has given me, but raise it up on the last day. '

John 6:39

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.6.39>

God had other plans for Peter and the other disciples, aside from Judas, who was about to take his own life, still under the strong influence of Satan. He was not among those the Father had given to Jesus.

Prayer:

I praise You, God, that Your ways are not our ways and Your kingdom is not of this world. Thank You that in Your kingdom You made a way for righteousness, peace and joy.

Based on John 18:36, Romans 14:17

[Song suggestions for Day 19](#)

Day 20: Peter looks out for himself when Jesus is arrested

The account from Day 19 continues here. Jesus had just been bound to be taken by the crowd of soldiers and Jews.

'And they all left him and fled. And a young man followed him, with nothing but a linen cloth about his body. And they seized him, but he left the linen cloth and ran away naked. And they led Jesus to the high priest. And all the chief priests and the elders and the scribes came together. And Peter had followed him at a distance, right into the courtyard of the high priest. And he was sitting with the guards and warming himself at the fire. Now the chief priests and the whole council were seeking testimony against Jesus to put him to death, but they found none. For many bore false witness against him, but their testimony did not agree. And some stood up and bore false witness against him, saying, "We heard him say, 'I will destroy this temple that is made with hands, and in three days I will build another, not made with hands.'" Yet even about this their testimony did not agree. And the high priest stood up in the midst and asked Jesus, "Have you no answer to make? What is it that these men testify against you?" But he remained silent and made no answer. Again the high priest asked him, "Are you the Christ, the Son of the Blessed?" And Jesus said, "I am, and you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power, and coming with the clouds of heaven." And the high priest tore his garments and said, "What further witnesses do we need? You have heard his blasphemy. What is your decision?" And they all condemned him as deserving death. And some began to spit on him and to cover his face and to strike him, saying to him, "Prophecy!" And the guards received him with blows. And as Peter was below in the courtyard, one of the servant girls of the high priest came, and seeing Peter warming himself, she looked at him and said, "You also were with the Nazarene, Jesus." But he denied it, saying, "I neither know nor understand what you mean." And he went out into the gateway and the rooster crowed. And the servant girl saw him and began again to say to the bystanders, "This man is one of them." But again he denied it. And after a little while the bystanders again said to Peter, "Certainly you are one of them, for you are a Galilean." But he began to invoke a curse on himself and to swear, "I do not know this man of whom you speak." And immediately the rooster crowed a second time. And Peter remembered how Jesus had said to him, "Before the rooster crows twice, you will deny me three times." And he broke down and wept.'

Mark 14:50-72

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.14.50-72>

Despite what Jesus had told Peter previously, none of this was what Peter expected. He had taken his stand his own way. Jesus told Peter to stop and gave himself over to his captors.

Peter perceived he had lost control, and now he was afraid, so he fled.

They all fled immediately, except for Mark, another follower of Jesus, who followed Jesus, dressed only in a linen cloth. They did go after Mark, but when they grabbed his linen cloth, he ran away naked. Mark seems to have taken pride in having stuck around a little bit longer than the other disciples, Peter included. He is thought to be the same as John Mark, the one who accompanied Paul and Barnabus on parts of their missionary journeys.

Peter followed at a distance as Jesus was led to the high priest, Caiaphus. Peter went into the courtyard of the high priest with John, able to enter since John was known to Caiaphus. A servant girl let Peter in at John's instruction. Peter was among those who began to warm themselves at a fire, as it was cold outside (John 18:12-18).

She looked at him and said, "You also were with the Nazarene, Jesus." But he denied it, saying, "I neither know nor understand what you mean." Peter was looking out for himself.

Focused on saving himself, Peter had forgotten the teaching of Jesus:

'So everyone who acknowledges me before men, I also will acknowledge before my Father who is in heaven, but whoever denies me before men, I also will deny before my Father who is in heaven. '

Matthew 10:32-33

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.10.32-33>

Moreover, here is Jesus' teaching right after he rebuked Peter as Satan (Day 11):

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me. For whoever would save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake and the gospel's will save it. For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul? For what can a man give in return for his soul? For whoever is ashamed of me and of my words in this adulterous and sinful generation, of him will the Son of Man also be ashamed when he comes in the glory of his Father with the holy angels."

In the courtyard, they were below where Jesus was being interrogated: "the chief priests and the whole council were seeking testimony against Jesus to put him to death." There was much traffic as more showed up to give testimony against Jesus. There was also the sound of the beating of Jesus which had begun.

Peter retreated back to the courtyard entrance, and a rooster crowed. Peter should have recognized this crow, as Jesus had just predicted Peter's denials, associating them with this sound.

And the servant girl saw him and began again to say to the bystanders, "This man is one of them." Fear was mounting inside of Peter. He had to save himself. Again he denied it.

Jesus had asked Peter to be willing to follow him in all things, to take up his cross, suffer, and lose his life, just as the Spirit of God had now led Jesus to do. When it came time, Peter was not ready for this level of obedience. He held onto his life, separating himself from the one he had called Christ.

And after a little while the bystanders again said to Peter, "Certainly you are one of them, for you are a Galilean."

John's account records:

'One of the servants of the high priest, a relative of the man whose ear Peter had cut off, asked, "Did I not see you in the garden with him?" '

John 18:26

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.18.26>

In little time, Peter's world had fallen apart, and he was terrified. He turned away from Jesus to save himself. His spirit had been willing, but his mind was full of fear, and his body was weak.

Peter then began to invoke a curse on himself and to swear, "I do not know this man of whom you speak."

'And immediately the rooster crowed a second time. And Peter remembered how Jesus had said to him, "Before the rooster crows twice, you will deny me three times." And he broke down and wept.'

Our actions in difficult circumstances reveal character. Without Jesus, this leader of the disciples was a mess and had become a traitor. After having acted so boldly on many occasions while all had seemed well, Peter was spineless after all.

Would we have acted differently in the situation?

Prayer:

I praise You, Lord, plenteous in mercy, gracious, and slow to anger. You will not always chide: neither will You keep Your anger. You have not dealt with me after my sins; nor rewarded me according to my iniquities. For as the heaven is high above the earth, so great is Your mercy toward them that fear You. As far as the east is from the west, so far have You removed my transgressions from me. I give thanks to You, Lord, for You are good. Your steadfast love endures forever!

- Based on Psalm 103:8-12, Psalm 107:1-2

[Song suggestions for Day 20](#)

Day 21: John beats Peter to Jesus' empty tomb

The following account took place on the Sunday following Jesus' crucifixion:

' But on the first day of the week, at early dawn, they went to the tomb, taking the spices they had prepared. And they found the stone rolled away from the tomb, but when they went in they did not find the body of the Lord Jesus. While they were perplexed about this, behold, two men stood by them in dazzling apparel. And as they were frightened and bowed their faces to the ground, the men said to them, "Why do you seek the living among the dead? He is not here, but has risen. Remember how he told you, while he was still in Galilee, that the Son of Man must be delivered into the hands of sinful men and be crucified and on the third day rise." And they remembered his words, and returning from the tomb they told all these things to the eleven and to all the rest. Now it was Mary Magdalene and Joanna and Mary the mother of James and the other women with them who told these things to the apostles, but these words seemed to them an idle tale, and they did not believe them. But Peter rose and ran to the tomb; stooping and looking in, he saw the linen cloths by themselves; and he went home marveling at what had happened. That very day two of them were going to a village named Emmaus, about seven miles from Jerusalem, and they were talking with each other about all these things that had happened. While they were talking and discussing together, Jesus himself drew near and went with them. But their eyes were kept from recognizing him. And he said to them, "What is this conversation that you are holding with each other as you walk?" And they stood still, looking sad. Then one of them, named Cleopas, answered him, "Are you the only visitor to Jerusalem who does not know the things that have happened there in these days?" And he said to them, "What things?" And they said to him, "Concerning Jesus of Nazareth, a man who was a prophet mighty in deed and word before God and all the people, and how our chief priests and rulers delivered him up to be condemned to death, and crucified him. But we had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel. Yes, and besides all this, it is now the third day since these things happened. Moreover, some women of our company amazed us. They were at the tomb early in the morning, and when they did not find his body, they came back saying that they had even seen a vision of angels, who said that he was alive. Some of those who were with us went to the tomb and found it just as the women had said, but him they did not see." And he said to them, "O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken! Was it not necessary that the Christ should suffer these things and enter into his glory?" And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself. So they drew near to the village to which they were going. He acted as if he were going farther, but they urged him strongly, saying, "Stay with us, for it is toward evening and the day is now far spent." So he went in to stay with them. When he was at table with them, he took the bread and blessed and broke it and gave it to them. And their eyes were

opened, and they recognized him. And he vanished from their sight. They said to each other, “Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road, while he opened to us the Scriptures?” And they rose that same hour and returned to Jerusalem. And they found the eleven and those who were with them gathered together, saying, “The Lord has risen indeed, and has appeared to Simon!” Then they told what had happened on the road, and how he was known to them in the breaking of the bread. As they were talking about these things, Jesus himself stood among them, and said to them, “Peace to you!” But they were startled and frightened and thought they saw a spirit. And he said to them, “Why are you troubled, and why do doubts arise in your hearts? See my hands and my feet, that it is I myself. Touch me, and see. For a spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have.” And when he had said this, he showed them his hands and his feet. And while they still disbelieved for joy and were marveling, he said to them, “Have you anything here to eat?” They gave him a piece of broiled fish, and he took it and ate before them. '

Luke 24:1-43

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.24.1-43>

The gospel of John gives some additional detail about John and Peter’s experience of the resurrection:

' Now on the first day of the week Mary Magdalene came to the tomb early, while it was still dark, and saw that the stone had been taken away from the tomb. So she ran and went to Simon Peter and the other disciple, the one whom Jesus loved, and said to them, “They have taken the Lord out of the tomb, and we do not know where they have laid him.” So Peter went out with the other disciple, and they were going toward the tomb. Both of them were running together, but the other disciple outran Peter and reached the tomb first. And stooping to look in, he saw the linen cloths lying there, but he did not go in. Then Simon Peter came, following him, and went into the tomb. He saw the linen cloths lying there, and the face cloth, which had been on Jesus’ head, not lying with the linen cloths but folded up in a place by itself. Then the other disciple, who had reached the tomb first, also went in, and he saw and believed; for as yet they did not understand the Scripture, that he must rise from the dead. '

John 20:1-9

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.20.1-9>

Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, Salome, Joanna, and other women who followed Jesus, were the first to witness the empty tomb of Jesus. They gave an account of a vision of angels who reported that Jesus was alive. They appear to be the same women who followed him from Galilee that stood at a distance to watch both the death and the burial of Jesus (Luke 23:49,55).

Mary Magdalene took the lead in telling the account of what they saw to Peter and John, “but these words seemed to them an idle tale, and they did not believe them.” This was incredible to Peter.

So Peter and John ran to the tomb to see for themselves. At least John treated it as a race and outran Peter, peeking his head into the tomb first.

When Peter entered the tomb, he “saw the linen cloths lying there, and the face cloth, which had been on Jesus’ head, not lying with the linen cloths but folded up in a place by itself.”

Peter “went home marveling at what had happened.” It took seeing for him to believe what the women had said.

Later that day, Peter walked to Emmaus with Cleopas. Jesus joined them “but their eyes were kept from recognizing him.”

Since they were not understanding what had happened, Jesus first rebuked them, “O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken!”

He then explained to Peter and Cleopas all of what they should understand regarding his fulfillment of Old Testament prophecy. This revelation of truth made their “hearts burn within” them.

Jesus then joined them for the night at the urging of Peter and Cleopas. As Jesus broke bread and gave it to them, his identity was revealed, and they recognized him.

In the Spirit, Jesus then disappeared.

Not staying the night, Peter and Cleopas then turned around and headed 7 miles back to Jerusalem to tell the believers what had just happened. Cleopas started, “The Lord has risen indeed, and has appeared to Simon!”

As they were relaying the day’s events, Jesus himself stood among them, and said to them, “Peace to you!”

Not surprisingly, this frightened them. They thought they saw a ghost.

Jesus reassured them and questioned them:

“Why are you troubled, and why do doubts arise in your hearts? See my hands and my feet, that it is I myself. Touch me, and see. For a spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have.” And when he had said this, he showed them his hands and his feet, which had been pierced.

Jesus also proved he was not a ghost by eating with them.

This had been quite a day for Peter. His Lord had risen!

Prayer:

I praise You that You are the Lord who is present (Shammah). I thank You that Your Spirit which raised up Jesus from the dead dwells in me and quickens my mortal body.

- Based on Exodus 33:14, Romans 8:11

[Song suggestions for Day 21](#)

Day 22: Jesus asks Peter three times if Peter loves him

While Jesus was with his disciples in Jerusalem after the resurrection, '...Jesus said to them, "Do not be afraid; go and tell my brothers to go to Galilee, and there they will see me." '

Matthew 28:10

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.28.10>

John recorded Jesus' time with many of them in Galilee in the greatest detail:

'After this Jesus revealed himself again to the disciples by the Sea of Tiberias, and he revealed himself in this way. Simon Peter, Thomas (called the Twin), Nathanael of Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two others of his disciples were together. Simon Peter said to them, "I am going fishing." They said to him, "We will go with you." They went out and got into the boat, but that night they caught nothing. Just as day was breaking, Jesus stood on the shore; yet the disciples did not know that it was Jesus. Jesus said to them, "Children, do you have any fish?" They answered him, "No." He said to them, "Cast the net on the right side of the boat, and you will find some." So they cast it, and now they were not able to haul it in, because of the quantity of fish. That disciple whom Jesus loved therefore said to Peter, "It is the Lord!" When Simon Peter heard that it was the Lord, he put on his outer garment, for he was stripped for work, and threw himself into the sea. The other disciples came in the boat, dragging the net full of fish, for they were not far from the land, but about a hundred yards off. When they got out on land, they saw a charcoal fire in place, with fish laid out on it, and bread. Jesus said to them, "Bring some of the fish that you have just caught." So Simon Peter went aboard and hauled the net ashore, full of large fish, 153 of them. And although there were so many, the net was not torn. Jesus said to them, "Come and have breakfast." Now none of the disciples dared ask him, "Who are you?" They knew it was the Lord. Jesus came and took the bread and gave it to them, and so with the fish. This was now the third time that Jesus was revealed to the disciples after he was raised from the dead. When they had finished breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, "Simon, son of John, do you love me more than these?" He said to him, "Yes, Lord; you know that I love you." He said to him, "Feed my lambs." He said to him a second time, "Simon, son of John, do you love me?" He said to him, "Yes, Lord; you know that I love you." He said to him, "Tend my sheep." He said to him the third time, "Simon, son of John, do you love me?" Peter was grieved because he said to him the third time, "Do you love me?" and he said to him, "Lord, you know everything; you know that I love you." Jesus said to him, "Feed my sheep. Truly, truly, I say to you, when you were young, you used to dress yourself and walk wherever you wanted, but when you are old, you will stretch out your hands, and another will dress you and carry you where you do not want to go." (This he said to show by what kind of death he was to glorify God.) And after saying this he said to him, "Follow me." Peter turned and saw the disciple whom Jesus loved following them, the one who also had leaned back against him during the supper

and had said, “Lord, who is it that is going to betray you?” When Peter saw him, he said to Jesus, “Lord, what about this man?” Jesus said to him, “If it is my will that he remain until I come, what is that to you? You follow me!”¹

John 21:1-22

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.21.1-22>

As Jesus had done on the way to Emmaus, his identity was again hid when Peter saw him on the shores of Galilee after a night of fishing where they had caught nothing. James and John, sons of Zebedee, who were partners with Peter, were with him again, just as they were on the first day Peter decided to follow Jesus (see Day 2).

Confirming that they have caught no fish, Jesus instructed, “Cast the net on the right side of the boat, and you will find some.” The fishermen obeyed and cast their net. The catch was so big they could not pull it in.

This time Peter didn’t even try, as John said to him, “It is the Lord!”

Ecstatic, Peter put on his outer garment, threw himself into the sea, and swam to meet Jesus. Peter could not wait.

The others were more measured. Unable to pull the fish into the boat, they steered for land, which was only 100 yards away. As they came in, they saw Jesus had already started a charcoal fire and prepared some fish and bread for them to eat after their long night.

Jesus invited them, “Bring some of the fish that you have just caught” and “Come and have breakfast.” Even as he did on the road to Emmaus, Jesus must have appeared differently to them, because John remarked, ‘Now none of the disciples dared ask him, “Who are you?” They knew it was the Lord.’

Jesus gave them bread and fish, and they had breakfast together.

After breakfast, Jesus spoke directly to Peter, “Simon, son of John, do you love me more than these?” Jesus addressed him as Simon, son of John, rather than Peter or Simon Peter. Jesus asked him whether he loved Jesus more than the other disciples who were present.

Simon Peter replied, “Yes, Lord; you know that I love you.” In response to his reply of love, Jesus commanded, “Feed my lambs.” Jesus referred here to his church, specifically those who are young or not mature among his chosen people. Peter was to feed them.

When Peter had first confessed Jesus to be the Christ (see Day 9), Jesus had told Peter, “And I tell you, you are Peter [Petros], and on this rock [petra] I will build my church.” Here Jesus was commanding Peter to do just that.

Yet Jesus went on to ask Peter whether he loved Jesus a total of three times. The second time, Peter replied the same way, “Yes, Lord; you know that I love you.” The third time, Peter was grieved because he knew Jesus was addressing his three time denial of Jesus before his crucifixion. Peter replied, “Lord, you know everything; you know that I love you.” Three times, Peter acknowledged that Jesus knew what was in his heart, and the last time added, “you know everything.”

In Jesus’ subsequent replies, he gave Peter similar instructions regarding Peter’s shepherding of his church, “Tend my sheep” and “Feed my sheep.” Peter was forgiven and restored to ministry despite his denials of Jesus. Even though Peter was unfaithful, God was faithful to him (Deuteronomy 7:9, 2 Timothy 2:13, Lamentations 3:22-23).

Jesus’ prayers regarding Peter’s denials (see Day 18) had been answered: “Simon, Simon, behold, Satan demanded to have you, that he might sift you like wheat, but I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail. And when you have turned again, strengthen your brothers.” Peter’s faith did not fail, and now he was to strengthen the church as a shepherd for God’s sheep.

The chief Shepherd does not lose those the Father has given to him:

‘My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me. I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand. My Father, who has given them to me, is greater than all, and no one is able to snatch them out of the Father’s hand. ’

John 10:27-29

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.10.27-29>

Jesus also told Peter, “Truly, truly, I say to you, when you were young, you used to dress yourself and walk wherever you wanted, but when you are old, you will stretch out your hands, and another will dress you and carry you where you do not want to go.” He commanded, “Follow me.”

Although not recorded in the Bible, historical writings suggest that Peter did die when he was old, likely in his sixties, by crucifixion. Jesus referred here to the future, where Peter would quite literally take up his cross. Peter was commanded to follow him and to build the church, and it

would cost him his life. Peter's obedience in following, this time unto death, would bring glory to God.

While Jesus was on the topic of talking about the future, Peter then asked Jesus about John, "Lord, what about this man?"

Jesus suggested that what happened to John was not Peter's concern, "... what is that to you? You follow me!" Peter's story within the story of God was his own, as is each of ours. We are simply to seek the kingdom of God and his righteousness.

Prayer:

I praise You, Lord; with You one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day. You are not slow to fulfill Your promise as some count slowness, but You are longsuffering and patient toward us, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance.

- Based on 2 Peter 3:8-9

[Song suggestions for Day 22](#)

Day 23: Jesus commissions Peter among his disciples

There are a number of recorded instances in the New Testament of Jesus commissioning the eleven disciples, and the first clearly took place in Galilee, where Jesus had told them to go in order to see him:

'Now the eleven disciples went to Galilee, to the mountain to which Jesus had directed them. And when they saw him they worshiped him, but some doubted. And Jesus came and said to them, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."'

Matthew 28:16-20

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.28.16-20>

The next account took place sometime after Jesus appeared to Peter and Cleopas, although no location is given in the text:

'Afterward he appeared to the eleven themselves as they were reclining at table, and he rebuked them for their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they had not believed those who saw him after he had risen. And he said to them, "Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned. And these signs will accompany those who believe: in my name they will cast out demons; they will speak in new tongues; they will pick up serpents with their hands; and if they drink any deadly poison, it will not hurt them; they will lay their hands on the sick, and they will recover." So then the Lord Jesus, after he had spoken to them, was taken up into heaven and sat down at the right hand of God. And they went out and preached everywhere, while the Lord worked with them and confirmed the message by accompanying signs.'

Mark 16:14-20

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.16.14-20>

Luke recorded the following regarding the command of Jesus to go:

'Then he said to them, "These are my words that I spoke to you while I was still with you, that everything written about me in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms must be fulfilled." Then he opened their minds to understand the Scriptures, and said to them, "Thus it is written, that the Christ should suffer and on the third day rise from the dead, and that repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in his name to all nations, beginning from Jerusalem. You are witnesses of these things. And behold, I am sending the promise of my Father upon you. But stay in the city until you are clothed with power from on

high." And he led them out as far as Bethany, and lifting up his hands he blessed them. While he blessed them, he parted from them and was carried up into heaven. And they worshiped him and returned to Jerusalem with great joy, and were continually in the temple blessing God.'

Luke 24:44-53

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.24.44-53>

Also, in Acts, Luke recorded additional detail:

'And while staying with them he ordered them not to depart from Jerusalem, but to wait for the promise of the Father, which, he said, "you heard from me; for John baptized with water, but you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit not many days from now." So when they had come together, they asked him, "Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?" He said to them, "It is not for you to know times or seasons that the Father has fixed by his own authority. But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth." And when he had said these things, as they were looking on, he was lifted up, and a cloud took him out of their sight. And while they were gazing into heaven as he went, behold, two men stood by them in white robes, and said, "Men of Galilee, why do you stand looking into heaven? This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven." '

Acts 1:4-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.1.4-11>

From the passage in Matthew, we see that not all the disciples believed it was Jesus they saw on the mountain. This seems to be a common theme after the resurrection: disbelief. The ones that did believe worshipped Jesus.

Some asked, "Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?" There was confusion regarding what Jesus would do next as the Messiah.

He said to them, "It is not for you to know times or seasons that the Father has fixed by his own authority." This restoration of the kingdom of Israel written about in the Scriptures was for a different time. It was not their concern.

Jesus told them, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me." In Jesus' ministry, the disciples had seen Jesus' total authority on earth over sin, sickness, death, and nature. Here, he claimed that all authority, both on earth and in heaven, had been given to him. It was given to him by the Father based upon the legal change brought about by his death and resurrection. Jesus had received all authority, taken from the one who Jesus had called the "ruler of this

world” (John 14:30). The spiritual world is operated by a legal system put in place and controlled by the Father.

Jesus commanded his followers to go make disciples of all nations. Jesus had sent them out before. He sent out the twelve (Day 6), he sent out the seventy-two (Day 13), and, generally, he expected them to preach, heal, and even raise the dead. Because Jesus had all authority and they were his ambassadors, they were being sent out without him not just to do this, but to make disciples, or followers of Jesus, to build the church—not only of the Jews, but of all nations.

Jesus also instructed them as to how to make disciples: baptize “them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you.”

The disciples were to be taught the truth that Jesus had lived and shared with them. They were to be taught to obey it, just as the disciples were taught to obey it. They were to be hearers of the word and doers of the word. They were also to be set apart and empowered by a new baptism, one that included the Father, the Son (him), and the Holy Spirit.

And Jesus told them the hidden mystery of the ages and the source of their power to do what he commanded them: “behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.” Christ would be with them always. This would happen by way of Jesus Christ being in them through the Holy Spirit, and them being new creations in Christ. They would be in the one who had all power over all things in heaven and on earth, and so they would have this power available to them as they made themselves available to accomplish His commission to them.

In the account from Mark, Jesus “rebuked them for their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they had not believed those who saw him after he had risen.” It was more than disbelief; Jesus scolded them for unbelief. We saw before (Day 10) how Jesus had rebuked Peter, “Get behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man.” We also saw before (Day 12) how Jesus had rebuked most of the disciples, unable to apply their faith to heal, when he came down from the mountain with Peter after the transfiguration: “O faithless generation, how long am I to be with you? How long am I to bear with you? Bring him to me.” The time after Jesus’ resurrection was an occasion for a similar upbraiding of his followers.

After getting their attention in this manner, Jesus commanded them all, “Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned.” The disciples were commanded to go preach

the gospel, the message of the kingdom of God. Whoever believed their message and demonstrated it through publicly declaring it, counting the cost through the obedience of baptism, was saved. It was dangerous to them to become followers of Christ in their day, and it cost them. Whoever hears the truth and does not believe it and follow Christ is condemned, just as Jesus had said to the twelve and the seventy-two when he sent them out.

Jesus also told them, “And these signs will accompany those who believe: in my name they will cast out demons; they will speak in new tongues; they will pick up serpents with their hands; and if they drink any deadly poison, it will not hurt them; they will lay their hands on the sick, and they will recover.”

In the name of Jesus, “they will cast out demons”; this was not new. Peter may have witnessed it first at his home (Day 3). The disciples had seen Jesus do it as part of his daily life, and the twelve were sent out to do this in Jesus’ name (Day 6). They had done it themselves. Among the seventy-two (Day 13), they had ‘returned with joy, saying, “Lord, even the demons are subject to us in your name!” And he said to them, “I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven. Behold, I have given you authority to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing shall hurt you.’ Jesus had even rebuked the disciples for not being able to cast out a demon without him (Day 12).

“They will speak in new tongues”; this they had yet to see.

“They will pick up serpents with their hands; and if they drink any deadly poison, it will not hurt them.” This sounds very similar to what he told the seventy-two after they returned, “nothing shall hurt you,” because going in Jesus’ name, they had his authority to “tread on serpents” and “over all the power of the enemy.” It also has echos of the words of God in Psalm 91:

'He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty. For he will deliver you from the snare of the fowler and from the deadly pestilence. He will cover you with his pinions, and under his wings you will find refuge; his faithfulness is a shield and buckler. You will not fear the terror of the night, nor the arrow that flies by day, nor the pestilence that stalks in darkness, nor the destruction that wastes at noonday. A thousand may fall at your side, ten thousand at your right hand, but it will not come near you. Because you have made the Lord your dwelling place— the Most High, who is my refuge — no evil shall be allowed to befall you, no plague come near your tent. For he will command his angels concerning you to guard you in all your ways. On their hands they will bear you up, lest you strike your foot against a stone. You will tread on the lion and the adder; the young lion and the serpent you will trample underfoot. “Because he holds fast to me in love, I will deliver him; I will protect him, because he knows my name. '

Psalm 91:1,3-7,9-14

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.91.1,3-7,9-14>

This Psalm, probably written by Moses, ringed of such truth that Satan tried to tempt Jesus with it (see Matthew 4:5-7). The followers who believe and who go in God's name are protected when they exercise the gift of faith (1 Corinthians 12:9). Psalm 91 concludes, 'With long life I will satisfy him and show him my salvation.'" (verse 16)

Jesus also said, "they will lay their hands on the sick, and they will recover." This too the disciples had already seen. They healed as a means of demonstrating the gospel when they preached the kingdom of God, as we have discussed.

"So then the Lord Jesus, after he had spoken to them, was taken up into heaven and sat down at the right hand of God. And they went out and preached everywhere, while the Lord worked with them and confirmed the message by accompanying signs."

The disciples saw Jesus raised up into heaven. From what they heard from him, they understood that his position was seated at the right hand of God. All authority in heaven and on earth had been given to him.

The Spirit of Christ now always with them, "the Lord worked with them." "They went out and preached everywhere" and Christ "confirmed the message by accompanying signs." These include the signs just discussed which "accompany those who believe." They believed this commission applied to them, and they obeyed it.

Luke reports that Jesus told them, "...repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in his name to all nations, beginning from Jerusalem. You are witnesses of these things. And behold, I am sending the promise of my Father upon you. But stay in the city until you are clothed with power from on high."

Their preaching in Jesus' name was to go to all nations, but it would begin in Jerusalem. Jesus would send the Holy Spirit, the promise of the Father, upon them and all believers:

' "And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh; your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, and your young men shall see visions. Even on the male and female servants in those days I will pour out my Spirit. "And I will show wonders in the heavens and on the earth, blood and fire and columns of smoke. The sun shall be turned to darkness, and the moon to blood, before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes. And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls on the name of the Lord shall be

saved. For in Mount Zion and in Jerusalem there shall be those who escape, as the Lord has said, and among the survivors shall be those whom the Lord calls.'

Joel 2:28-32

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JOL.2.28-32>

Jesus said about this promise: "you heard from me; for John baptized with water, but you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit not many days from now." They would have a new baptism. They were commanded to stay in Jerusalem until "clothed with power from on high." They already had power from Jesus that accompanied their preaching of the gospel, as seen when they went among the seventy-two (Day 13), but they would be "clothed with power from on high." His followers would have even more power after Christ was glorified by the Father.

Jesus said: "But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth." The power of Jesus to be given to them was to enable them as Jesus' witnesses, carrying Jesus' life and proclaiming the truth to the end of the earth.

The account from the gospel of Luke concludes: "And he led them out as far as Bethany, and lifting up his hands he blessed them. While he blessed them, he parted from them and was carried up into heaven. And they worshiped him and returned to Jerusalem with great joy, and were continually in the temple blessing God."

Luke added in Acts 1: "...he was lifted up, and a cloud took him out of their sight. And while they were gazing into heaven as he went, behold, two men stood by them in white robes, and said, "Men of Galilee, why do you stand looking into heaven? This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven."

Jesus lifted up his hands and blessed Peter and the disciples before his ascension. What a vision!

Peter was asked by angels, "...why do you stand looking into heaven?"

They had great joy in: their new understanding of what had become of Jesus under the new covenant; fulfillment of Old Testament prophecies that were made clear to them by Jesus; their new commission to go as ambassadors of Jesus and his kingdom; their expectation of what was to come, starting in Jerusalem; their expectation that they would see Jesus return, even as he left. This caused them to be centered around the temple in Jerusalem, blessing God, expecting much.

What good news that his followers are made alive together with Christ as his workmanship; raised up with him and seated in heavenly places in Christ; commissioned to bring glory to God by showing the immeasurable riches of his grace and peace in kindness toward his church!

And since those who live in Christ live forever, Peter will see Jesus return to earth just as he saw him ascend to heaven. As Jesus said, “He is not God of the dead, but of the living” (see Day 12).

Prayer:

I thank You that I am joined as one spirit with You, Lord, because of Jesus.

- Based on 1 Corinthians 6:17

[Song suggestions for Day 23](#)

Day 24: Peter receives the Holy Spirit and preaches in Jerusalem

'When the day of Pentecost arrived, they were all together in one place. And suddenly there came from heaven a sound like a mighty rushing wind, and it filled the entire house where they were sitting. And divided tongues as of fire appeared to them and rested on each one of them. And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit gave them utterance. Now there were dwelling in Jerusalem Jews, devout men from every nation under heaven. And at this sound the multitude came together, and they were bewildered, because each one was hearing them speak in his own language. And they were amazed and astonished, saying, "Are not all these who are speaking Galileans? And how is it that we hear, each of us in his own native language? Parthians and Medes and Elamites and residents of Mesopotamia, Judea and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia, Phrygia and Pamphylia, Egypt and the parts of Libya belonging to Cyrene, and visitors from Rome, both Jews and proselytes, Cretans and Arabians—we hear them telling in our own tongues the mighty works of God." And all were amazed and perplexed, saying to one another, "What does this mean?" But others mocking said, "They are filled with new wine." But Peter, standing with the eleven, lifted up his voice and addressed them: "Men of Judea and all who dwell in Jerusalem, let this be known to you, and give ear to my words. For these people are not drunk, as you suppose, since it is only the third hour of the day. But this is what was uttered through the prophet Joel: "'And in the last days it shall be, God declares, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh, and your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, and your young men shall see visions, and your old men shall dream dreams; even on my male servants and female servants in those days I will pour out my Spirit, and they shall prophesy. And I will show wonders in the heavens above and signs on the earth below, blood, and fire, and vapor of smoke; the sun shall be turned to darkness and the moon to blood, before the day of the Lord comes, the great and magnificent day. And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls upon the name of the Lord shall be saved.'" "Men of Israel, hear these words: Jesus of Nazareth, a man attested to you by God with mighty works and wonders and signs that God did through him in your midst, as you yourselves know— this Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men. God raised him up, loosing the pangs of death, because it was not possible for him to be held by it. For David says concerning him, "'I saw the Lord always before me, for he is at my right hand that I may not be shaken; therefore my heart was glad, and my tongue rejoiced; my flesh also will dwell in hope. For you will not abandon my soul to Hades, or let your Holy One see corruption. You have made known to me the paths of life; you will make me full of gladness with your presence.'" "Brothers, I may say to you with confidence about the patriarch David that he both died and was buried, and his tomb is with us to this day. Being therefore a prophet, and knowing that God had sworn with an oath to him that he would set one of his descendants on his throne, he foresaw and spoke about the resurrection of the

Christ, that he was not abandoned to Hades, nor did his flesh see corruption. This Jesus God raised up, and of that we all are witnesses. Being therefore exalted at the right hand of God, and having received from the Father the promise of the Holy Spirit, he has poured out this that you yourselves are seeing and hearing. For David did not ascend into the heavens, but he himself says, “The Lord said to my Lord, “Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool.” Let all the house of Israel therefore know for certain that God has made him both Lord and Christ, this Jesus whom you crucified.” Now when they heard this they were cut to the heart, and said to Peter and the rest of the apostles, “Brothers, what shall we do?” And Peter said to them, “Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself.” And with many other words he bore witness and continued to exhort them, saying, “Save yourselves from this crooked generation.” So those who received his word were baptized, and there were added that day about three thousand souls. And they devoted themselves to the apostles’ teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers. And awe came upon every soul, and many wonders and signs were being done through the apostles. ’

Acts 2:1-43

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.2.1-43>

Seven weeks after Passover, the Jewish feast of Pentecost was mainly a thanksgiving for the first fruits of the wheat harvest. It also came to be a celebration of God writing his law on tablets of stone at Mt. Sinai. All Jews were commanded to travel to Jerusalem to celebrate the feast, so the faithful had come in all directions of travel from great distances—as far as Rome.

The disciples were all together, probably celebrating the feast. “And suddenly there came from heaven a sound like a mighty rushing wind, and it filled the entire house where they were sitting. And divided tongues as of fire appeared to them and rested on each one of them. And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit gave them utterance.”

Wind and breath are associated with the Holy Spirit and the giving of life. Fire is a sign of the presence of God. The disciples were filled with the Holy Spirit, tongues of fire resting on each one of them, and they began to speak in other tongues—just as Jesus had told them about the signs that would accompany those who believe; they would “speak in new tongues” (Day 23).

On this occasion, the disciples spoke in the tongues of all of those who were present to celebrate Pentecost, and they all heard the disciples speaking in their own languages, so they

came together 'amazed and astonished, saying, "Are not all these who are speaking Galileans? And how is it that we hear, each of us in his own native language?'

In those languages, the disciples were telling "the mighty works of God." Some wondered, "What does this mean?" But others mocking said, "They are filled with new wine."

The eleven disciples were speaking these different languages, probably all at the same time rather than one by one, to a very large crowd of devout Jews in the area, each one magnifying God in the tongue of some of the those present for the occasion, and yet it could be clearly heard. Many saw the significance of this and wondered what it meant, having never seen such a thing before, desiring to hear an explanation. Yet some scoffers assumed they were just drunk with wine on the occasion of the festival.

At this moment, Peter felt led to raise his voice and preach, and so he did, filled and "carried along by the Holy Spirit" (2 Peter 1:21). This is consistent with what Jesus taught Peter: 'For he whom God has sent utters the words of God, for he gives the Spirit without measure. ' John 3:34

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.3.34>

His voice raised, Peter spoke to thousands at once. He first cleared up the misunderstanding of some: "Men of Judea and all who dwell in Jerusalem, let this be known to you, and give ear to my words. For these people are not drunk, as you suppose, since it is only the third hour of the day." Getting their attention, Peter informed the crowd which had gathered that he and the disciples were not drunk. It was too early in the day for that.

Instead, he explained to the Jews who listened that what they had just witnessed was in fulfillment of their Scriptures, "I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh... and they shall prophesy." Prior to this, the Holy Spirit had only come on a small number of selected leaders of the Jews, e.g., King David and Joel, who then had increased intimacy with God and could speak his words to the people. Joel had prophesied that in the last days, the Holy Spirit would be poured out by God on all flesh, and they would prophecy. All flesh included not just Jews but all, "even on my male servants and female servants." It included women. It included those lowly esteemed in society. That was a radical change. Peter explained they had just witnessed this from a group of uneducated Galileans, himself included, who didn't know the languages of their homelands. It was by the power of God in fulfilling their Scripture that they spoke truth of the mighty works of God, exalting their God in diverse tongues.

The quoted prophecy ends, “And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls upon the name of the Lord shall be saved.” The “everyone” had been described in this Scripture. Now Peter moved to tell them of “the Lord”: “Men of Israel, hear these words: Jesus of Nazareth, a man attested to you by God with mighty works and wonders and signs that God did through him in your midst, as you yourselves know.”

Peter addressed not the whole crowd but those of Israel who had seen and heard the mighty works, wonders and signs that God did through Jesus of Nazareth. Jesus had healed all the sick, raised some of the dead, created food to feed the masses, forgiven sinners, and shown great authority, giving testimony that he was sent by God. Jesus had trained and sent out his disciples to do the same, creating quite a buzz. Many of them had seen it with their own eyes, and more of them had heard about it from sources they trusted.

Peter testified that Jesus came from God and the things that happened to him were by the plan of God, including the death and resurrection of Jesus, which fulfilled David’s prophecy (Psalm 16), who “foresaw and spoke about the resurrection of the Christ, that he was not abandoned to Hades, nor did his flesh see corruption. This Jesus God raised up, and of that we all are witnesses.” By “we,” Peter referred to himself and the other disciples with him. Peter identified the resurrected Jesus as the one referred to when “God had sworn with an oath to [David] that he would set one of his descendants on his throne.”

Peter went on to explain how this related to what they had just beheld: “Being therefore exalted at the right hand of God, and having received from the Father the promise of the Holy Spirit, he has poured out this that you yourselves are seeing and hearing.” Jesus, now at the Father’s right hand, had received and just then poured out, according to Joel’s prophecy, the Holy Spirit on the disciples.

Peter also cited another prophecy of King David (Psalm 110) and explained it: ‘The Lord said to my Lord, “Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool. Let all the house of Israel therefore know for certain that God has made him both Lord and Christ, this Jesus whom you crucified.’ Jesus was the one David had referred to as “my Lord,” the one the Father told to sit at his right hand, the place of greatest significance to God, until the Father makes Christ’s enemies his footstool.

At Peter’s words, the Holy Spirit brought conviction of truth to many present: “Now when they heard this they were cut to the heart.” With some surprise at this result and not having been in such a situation before, Peter asked the others what should be done.

Jesus' commission to them (Day 23) was then brought to Peter's remembrance, and he told them what was to be done: "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself."

The promise and commission of God (Day 23) were for them and the entire church that God calls to himself, including those who are "far off": "Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned. And these signs will accompany those who believe..."

Peter's word to the crowd went on beyond what is recorded in Acts 2: 'And with many other words he bore witness and continued to exhort them, saying, "Save yourselves from this crooked generation." ' They were told that there would be a cost; they would need to separate themselves from their generation in their newfound beliefs.

The result of the outpouring of the Spirit from Peter's speaking of words by the Spirit was beyond anything the ministry of the disciples had ever yielded before: "So those who received his word were baptized, and there were added that day about three thousand souls. And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers. And awe came upon every soul, and many wonders and signs were being done through the apostles."

Peter not only preached, but the disciples followed Jesus' command to make disciples out of these new believers in Jerusalem. Many of these three thousand Jews left their homelands to become disciples. Additionally, the signs and wonders that Joel had prophesied about were seen among these followers of Jesus, being done through the apostles. These things they did by the Spirit of Christ in them—"the Lord worked with them and confirmed the message by accompanying signs"—to grow the church according to the will and command of God.

Prayer:

Spirit of God, Your word is like fire, like a hammer that breaks the rock into pieces. Father, thank You that today is the day of Your salvation. Thank You that You have made us the temple of the living God, making Your dwelling among us. Thank You that You have called us sons and daughters.

- Based on Jeremiah 23:29, 2 Corinthians 6

[Song suggestions for Day 24](#)

Day 25: Peter gives life to a lame beggar at the Beautiful Gate

The last excerpt ended with “many wonders and signs were being done through the apostles,” and today we see a specific example of this recorded:

'Now Peter and John were going up to the temple at the hour of prayer, the ninth hour. And a man lame from birth was being carried, whom they laid daily at the gate of the temple that is called the Beautiful Gate to ask alms of those entering the temple. Seeing Peter and John about to go into the temple, he asked to receive alms. And Peter directed his gaze at him, as did John, and said, “Look at us.” And he fixed his attention on them, expecting to receive something from them. But Peter said, “I have no silver and gold, but what I do have I give to you. In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk!” And he took him by the right hand and raised him up, and immediately his feet and ankles were made strong. And leaping up, he stood and began to walk, and entered the temple with them, walking and leaping and praising God. And all the people saw him walking and praising God, and recognized him as the one who sat at the Beautiful Gate of the temple, asking for alms. And they were filled with wonder and amazement at what had happened to him. '

Acts 3:1-10

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.3.1-10>

Peter had repeatedly watched Jesus, and then he learned to do what Jesus did, even before he was filled with the Holy Spirit.

At the Beautiful Gate, Peter came across a man lame from birth, asking for alms. He didn't go about his business, making his way where he intended to go, but instead, led by the Spirit that filled him, he made himself fully available to serve. Now joined to the Lord, Peter had become filled with compassion, grace, and generosity. He was led to do unto others what he would want done for him.

Peter and John fixed their gaze upon the man and demanded he do the same, saying “look at us.” Peter and John gave the man their full attention. Upon their command, they had his full attention, and the man expected to receive something.

As a co-worker with Jesus (Mark 16:20), Peter decided he would be the one who took action. He said, “I have no silver and gold, but what I do have I give to you.” Peter had the life of the Spirit in him, and in Jesus' name he had the authority of Jesus Christ over heaven and earth, the spiritual and the physical. Peter was filled with faith and obedient to the commission of Jesus to act in his place, taking responsibility for this man loved by God. He had no silver or gold, but he had the living Jesus ever with him, and Jesus changes everything.

Peter boldly demanded, “In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk!” With faith in Jesus’ name, he spoke words of spirit and life with authority to the lame man, telling him to rise up and walk, and he believed it would come to pass. Jesus would have victory over this man’s disability.

Knowing that God was with him, in him, for him, and had heard his words, “he took him by the right hand and raised him up.” On account of Peter’s position in Christ, his four word command in Jesus’ name, and his action—his contact to raise the man up, all in unwavering faith in God’s will to have compassion on this man in demonstration of the gospel, “immediately [the man’s] feet and ankles were made strong” by the life of the Holy Spirit which flowed into the man at Peter’s touch. When this resurrection life (zoe) filled his body, Jesus took the man’s infirmity. His disability from birth was instantly made right by the Holy and Righteous One. God’s righteousness was fulfilled on earth in this man’s life.

The man’s reaction to the quickening he immediately received through the Holy Spirit was ecstatic: “And leaping up, he stood and began to walk, and entered the temple with them, walking and leaping and praising God.” The man was filled to overflowing with joy as he followed Peter and John into the temple, and, having been set free by God from his lifelong disability, he couldn’t help but testify of the goodness of God.

Since the man was at the temple day after day, everyone there had seen him again and again asking for alms. Now he was leaping for joy, glorifying God for his healing, which was accomplished by the wounds of Jesus. “And they were filled with wonder and amazement at what had happened to him.” At this sign brought through Peter’s now-mature faith, the people were ready to hear an explanation.

Peter was growing up into Christ, part of his functioning body. He was no longer tossed to and fro, no longer a child, but growing up, taking his place in the kingdom of God. He had set himself about doing the will of God by the Spirit of God.

Life was in Peter. He spoke it, and it flowed out of him.

Prayer:

God, thank you for Jesus who has borne my sicknesses, carried my sorrows (pains), taken my infirmities. He was stricken, smitten by You, and afflicted. Thank you that He was pierced for my transgressions, crushed for my iniquities; upon Him was the chastisement that brought me peace. With His wounds I have been healed, and so I am healed.

- Based on Isaiah 53:4-5, Matthew 8:16-17, 1 Peter 2:24

[Song suggestions for Day 25](#)

Day 26: Peter preaches about the Author of life at Solomon's portico

Taking his place in the kingdom of God, Peter had taken responsibility for a man and healed him. Next, he took responsibility for those around him who drew near, preaching the gospel. Peter spoke, led by the Spirit, as the man who had been set free stayed by them:

' While he clung to Peter and John, all the people, utterly astounded, ran together to them in the portico called Solomon's. And when Peter saw it he addressed the people: "Men of Israel, why do you wonder at this, or why do you stare at us, as though by our own power or piety we have made him walk? The God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob, the God of our fathers, glorified his servant Jesus, whom you delivered over and denied in the presence of Pilate, when he had decided to release him. But you denied the Holy and Righteous One, and asked for a murderer to be granted to you, and you killed the Author of life, whom God raised from the dead. To this we are witnesses. And his name—by faith in his name—has made this man strong whom you see and know, and the faith that is through Jesus has given the man this perfect health in the presence of you all. "And now, brothers, I know that you acted in ignorance, as did also your rulers. But what God foretold by the mouth of all the prophets, that his Christ would suffer, he thus fulfilled. Repent therefore, and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out, that times of refreshing may come from the presence of the Lord, and that he may send the Christ appointed for you, Jesus, whom heaven must receive until the time for restoring all the things about which God spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets long ago. Moses said, 'The Lord God will raise up for you a prophet like me from your brothers. You shall listen to him in whatever he tells you. And it shall be that every soul who does not listen to that prophet shall be destroyed from the people.' And all the prophets who have spoken, from Samuel and those who came after him, also proclaimed these days. You are the sons of the prophets and of the covenant that God made with your fathers, saying to Abraham, 'And in your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed.' God, having raised up his servant, sent him to you first, to bless you by turning every one of you from your wickedness."

Acts 3:11-26

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.3.11-26>

Peter preached to the crowd gathered to hear how the lame man they knew had been healed, causing him to be filled with life and vigor: "Why do you stare at us, as though by our own power or piety we have made him walk?" Peter started by saying it wasn't about him or John.

Instead, Peter lifted up the living Jesus, the servant of the living God: "The God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob, the God of our fathers, glorified his servant Jesus..."

Peter continued: "...whom you delivered over and denied in the presence of Pilate, when he had decided to release him. But you denied the Holy and Righteous One, and asked for a murderer to be granted to you, and you killed the Author of life, whom God raised from the dead." Himself a Jew, Peter pointed his finger at the Jews in the temple, some of whom, under the influence of Satan, delivered Jesus over to the authorities, and many of whom were guilty of asking for the murderer Barabbas to be released instead of Jesus—the Holy and Righteous One and the Author of Life—on the morning that Jesus was crucified.

God's word was alive in Peter when he testified that Jesus was the Author of Life, the same God of whom it was written:

'In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth. The earth was without form and void, and darkness was over the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters. And God said, "Let there be light," and there was light... Then God said, "Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. And let them have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over the livestock and over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth." So God created man in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them. And God blessed them. And God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and subdue it, and have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over every living thing that moves on the earth." '

Genesis 1:1-3,26-28

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/GEN.1.1-3,26-28>

It was the one who created the heavens and the earth, the one who created mankind in his own image, the one who gave mankind dominion on earth, the one sent to make everything right that they rejected, wrongly accused, and murdered. The living God glorified Jesus, the Author of Life, raising him to life after his murder. To this Peter and John were witnesses. They also witnessed the "I am" statements of Jesus claiming to be God, three of which pertain to life: "I am the bread of life" (Day 15); "I am the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25); and "I am the way, the truth, and the life" (John 14:6).

Jesus is life (zoe). Jesus gives life (quicken).

Peter continued to address their main question: "And his name—by faith in his name—has made this man strong whom you see and know, and the faith that is through Jesus has given the man this perfect health in the presence of you all." Peter testified that it was by the name of Jesus, the Author of Life, that the infirm man they know was given life, made immediately strong and of perfect health by the extended grace of God when Peter spoke. Peter had an

unwavering spirit of faith in the Author of Life present with them, and so the Spirit of God gave life as confirmation of Peter's proclamation of the kingdom of God.

And so Peter continued to proclaim it, led by the Holy Spirit that was present to heal: "And now, brothers, I know that you acted in ignorance, as did also your rulers. But what God foretold by the mouth of all the prophets, that his Christ would suffer, he thus fulfilled." What the Jews had done, they had done in accordance with the prophecies in their Scriptures.

Peter referred to Jesus as the servant and the righteous one, just as he is referred to by Isaiah at the end of this prophecy:

' He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief; and as one from whom men hide their faces he was despised, and we esteemed him not. Surely he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed. All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned—every one—to his own way; and the Lord has laid on him the iniquity of us all. He was oppressed, and he was afflicted, yet he opened not his mouth; like a lamb that is led to the slaughter, and like a sheep that before its shearers is silent, so he opened not his mouth. By oppression and judgment he was taken away; and as for his generation, who considered that he was cut off out of the land of the living, stricken for the transgression of my people? And they made his grave with the wicked and with a rich man in his death, although he had done no violence, and there was no deceit in his mouth. Yet it was the will of the Lord to crush him; he has put him to grief; when his soul makes an offering for guilt, he shall see his offspring; he shall prolong his days; the will of the Lord shall prosper in his hand. Out of the anguish of his soul he shall see and be satisfied; by his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous, and he shall bear their iniquities. '

Isaiah 53:3-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.53.3-11>

Revealing these truths regarding recent events to them, Peter called them to "Repent therefore, and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out, that times of refreshing may come from the presence of the Lord, and that he may send the Christ appointed for you, Jesus, whom heaven must receive until the time for restoring all the things about which God spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets long ago."

Peter revealed that which had been revealed to him: "Moses said, 'The Lord God will raise up for you a prophet like me from your brothers. You shall listen to him in whatever he tells you. And it shall be that every soul who does not listen to that prophet shall be destroyed from the

people.' And all the prophets who have spoken, from Samuel and those who came after him, also proclaimed these days."

Jesus is the prophet of which Moses spoke in Deuteronomy 18:

'I will raise up for them a prophet like you from among their brothers. And I will put my words in his mouth, and he shall speak to them all that I command him. And whoever will not listen to my words that he shall speak in my name, I myself will require it of him. '

Deuteronomy 18:18-19

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/DEU.18.18-19>

Jesus had claimed to speak to the Jews of the words of God, and he was rejected by them.

Furthermore, many of the prophets proclaimed the days of Jesus. One of these was Nathan, speaking to King David:

' "When your days are fulfilled and you lie down with your fathers, I will raise up your offspring after you, who shall come from your body, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son. When he commits iniquity, I will discipline him with the rod of men, with the stripes of the sons of men, but my steadfast love will not depart from him, as I took it from Saul, whom I put away from before you. And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever.'" In accordance with all these words, and in accordance with all this vision, Nathan spoke to David. '

2 Samuel 7:12-17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2SA.7.12-17>

Peter spoke to the sons of men who brought the rod and the stripes to God's son, who took on the iniquity of mankind. In the kingdom of God, the throne of God's son had now been established forever with all authority. Peter spoke to them in Solomon's portico, part of the temple built by Solomon, David's offspring; David was only to gather materials for it.

Peter addressed the Jews in the portico: "You are the sons of the prophets and of the covenant that God made with your fathers, saying to Abraham, 'And in your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed.' God, having raised up his servant, sent him to you first, to bless you by turning every one of you from your wickedness." Peter revealed Jesus as the offspring and the servant by which all would be blessed, according to God's promise to Abraham. Jesus was sent to the Jews first because Abraham obeyed God even unto the sacrifice of his son Isaac (Genesis 22:10). They had witnessed the work of the Author of Life—the one who now possessed the gates of God's enemies (Genesis 22:17)—through Peter moments ago; to be followed by God's call through Peter for them to turn from their wickedness. Not surprisingly, these words spoken in the temple caused some opposition from the leaders of the Jews.

Prayer:

I praise You, God, for You are life itself, and You are generous to give life. I thank You, Jesus, Author of Life, for Your Spirit which comes upon those who are Yours, anointing them to bring good news to the poor, sending them to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to those who are bound; to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor.

- Based on John 11:25, Isaiah 61:1-2, Luke 4:18-19

[Song suggestions for Day 26](#)

Day 27: Peter boldly faces opposition from the council

This passage continues from the preaching of Peter of Solomon's portico at the temple in Jerusalem:

'And as they were speaking to the people, the priests and the captain of the temple and the Sadducees came upon them, greatly annoyed because they were teaching the people and proclaiming in Jesus the resurrection from the dead. And they arrested them and put them in custody until the next day, for it was already evening. But many of those who had heard the word believed, and the number of the men came to about five thousand. On the next day their rulers and elders and scribes gathered together in Jerusalem, with Annas the high priest and Caiaphas and John and Alexander, and all who were of the high-priestly family. And when they had set them in the midst, they inquired, "By what power or by what name did you do this?" Then Peter, filled with the Holy Spirit, said to them, "Rulers of the people and elders, if we are being examined today concerning a good deed done to a crippled man, by what means this man has been healed, let it be known to all of you and to all the people of Israel that by the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, whom you crucified, whom God raised from the dead—by him this man is standing before you well. This Jesus is the stone that was rejected by you, the builders, which has become the cornerstone. And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved." Now when they saw the boldness of Peter and John, and perceived that they were uneducated, common men, they were astonished. And they recognized that they had been with Jesus. But seeing the man who was healed standing beside them, they had nothing to say in opposition. But when they had commanded them to leave the council, they conferred with one another, saying, "What shall we do with these men? For that a notable sign has been performed through them is evident to all the inhabitants of Jerusalem, and we cannot deny it. But in order that it may spread no further among the people, let us warn them to speak no more to anyone in this name." So they called them and charged them not to speak or teach at all in the name of Jesus. But Peter and John answered them, "Whether it is right in the sight of God to listen to you rather than to God, you must judge, for we cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard." And when they had further threatened them, they let them go, finding no way to punish them, because of the people, for all were praising God for what had happened. For the man on whom this sign of healing was performed was more than forty years old. When they were released, they went to their friends and reported what the chief priests and the elders had said to them. And when they heard it, they lifted their voices together to God and said, "Sovereign Lord, who made the heaven and the earth and the sea and everything in them, who through the mouth of our father David, your servant, said by the Holy Spirit, "'Why did the Gentiles rage, and the peoples plot in vain? The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers were gathered together, against the Lord and against his Anointed' — for truly in this city there were gathered together against your

holy servant Jesus, whom you anointed, both Herod and Pontius Pilate, along with the Gentiles and the peoples of Israel, to do whatever your hand and your plan had predestined to take place. And now, Lord, look upon their threats and grant to your servants to continue to speak your word with all boldness, while you stretch out your hand to heal, and signs and wonders are performed through the name of your holy servant Jesus.” And when they had prayed, the place in which they were gathered together was shaken, and they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and continued to speak the word of God with boldness. '

Acts 4:1-31

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.4.1-31>

The Sadducees were a party of the leaders of the Jews who were known as experts in the law, yet they did not take the Scriptures literally. More secular in their practice of religion than the Pharisees, they did not believe in the resurrection of the dead, heaven and hell, nor the existence of spirits. They tended to be aristocratic, and some were well connected with the ruling authority among the Roman government. Some Sadducees had been listening and watching Peter's preaching and watching the response of the crowd, and, "greatly annoyed" at Peter, they had decided to put an end to it by arresting Peter and John.

Yet the sowing of the word of God by the Christians, especially Peter, had reaped yet another harvest: "But many of those who had heard the word believed, and the number of the men came to about five thousand." There were certainly many women beyond the five thousand as well, possibly thousands, as they were also welcomed to follow.

The next day, Peter and John were brought before the high priest, his family, and many of the Jewish leaders for interrogation. The man Peter healed the day before was brought there as well. It wasn't long since Peter and John had both been at the high priest's residence; their interrogation could have also taken place at this location. In its courtyard, Peter had denied Jesus three times when questioned, after John got them into the gate (Day 20).

Referring to the healing of the lame man they knew that had caused a great stir in their temple, the council began, "By what power or by what name did you do this?"

This time Peter did not deny Jesus. He was "filled with the Holy Spirit," and he was obedient to Jesus' words to him:

' "I tell you, my friends, do not fear those who kill the body, and after that have nothing more that they can do... And I tell you, everyone who acknowledges me before men, the Son of Man also will acknowledge before the angels of God, but the one who denies me before men will be denied before the angels of God... And when they bring you before the synagogues and the

rulers and the authorities, do not be anxious about how you should defend yourself or what you should say, for the Holy Spirit will teach you in that very hour what you ought to say.”¹

Luke 12:4,8-9,11-12

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.12.4,8-9,11-12>

Taught by the Holy Spirit, Peter replied regarding his source of power and authority, “Rulers of the people and elders, if we are being examined today concerning a good deed done to a crippled man, by what means this man has been healed, let it be known to all of you and to all the people of Israel that by the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, whom you crucified, whom God raised from the dead—by him this man is standing before you well. This Jesus is the stone that was rejected by you, the builders, which has become the cornerstone. And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved.” Peter testified that it was Jesus of Nazareth they, the “builders,” rejected—as predicted by their Scripture (Psalm 118:22)—and had crucified, the Christ from God who was raised back to life, that healed the man standing before them. Jesus has become the cornerstone, the one God’s church was being built upon, even in their own temple.

Under the new covenant with God, Jesus Christ of Nazareth is now the name by which all must be saved (sozo). It’s important to understand that the words used for salvation in the New Testament are comprehensive. Sozo includes spiritual salvation by the forgiveness of sins, healing from sickness, deliverance from the work of the devil, rescue from harm, and being brought to wholeness by God. Here Peter was answering the council’s question about how the man standing before them was healed, so Peter’s response certainly pertained in part to his healing from sickness and infirmity, but it very likely was broader, with spiritual implication as well. Peter told them all that the resurrected Jesus is the only one able to save, and the name by which they all must be saved—including those who had rejected and crucified the Christ.

This rather short and pointed testimony from Peter took the council by great surprise: “Now when they saw the boldness of Peter and John, and perceived that they were uneducated, common men, they were astonished. And they recognized that they had been with Jesus.” These uneducated, common men from Galilee spoke with great authority. Peter was well spoken and bold! Peter and John had certainly been with and been changed by Jesus. This was undeniable, and, moreover, “...seeing the man who was healed standing beside them, [the council] had nothing to say in opposition.” Peter’s preaching of the word from God that was within him came with a sign that confirmed his message, the Lord working with him.

Being unable to come up with anything else they could do, the council decided to “warn them to speak no more to anyone in this name.” They commanded it.

Peter and John both replied, “Whether it is right in the sight of God to listen to you rather than to God, you must judge, for we cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard.” God was their authority, not these men, and had given them a commission, or orders, through Jesus. Furthermore, they couldn’t unsee what they have seen nor unhear what they had heard.

When filled with the Spirit, Jeremiah spoke

‘If I say, “I will not mention him, or speak any more in his name,” there is in my heart as it were a burning fire shut up in my bones, and I am weary with holding it in, and I cannot. ’

Jeremiah 20:9

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JER.20.9>

Neither could Peter hold in the burning fire. The fires of God burned in his soul like they burn in the risen Jesus, the source of Peter’s faith and power.

Peter had decided to obey Jesus rather than men:

‘ “So have no fear of them, for nothing is covered that will not be revealed, or hidden that will not be known. What I tell you in the dark, say in the light, and what you hear whispered, proclaim on the housetops. ’

Matthew 10:26-27

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.10.26-27>

Under the influence of the Spirit, Peter had become both bold and determined. No longer did he try to save himself. No longer did he fear men, so the further threatening of the council had no effect on him. He spoke what he knew by faith to be true, he spoke up, and he would continue to speak the words God had for him to speak. The mind, the thoughts, the objectives, and the plans of Jesus were also those of Peter. Peter had laid down his own life and taken up Jesus’ life, his life hid in Christ.

The council let Peter and John go, and they went back to tell their friends among the believers about what had happened. Their victories were cause for great rejoicing to the “Sovereign Lord, who made the heaven and the earth and the sea and everything in them,” to the living, righteous Jesus who has victory over sin, sickness, death, and any opposition the enemy could bring their way.

The believers then saw themselves in the Psalm written by King David about this day of opposition by their rulers:

‘ Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain? The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the Lord and against his Anointed, saying, “Let us burst their bonds apart and cast away their cords from us.” He who sits in the heavens laughs;

the Lord holds them in derision. Then he will speak to them in his wrath, and terrify them in his fury, saying, “As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill.” I will tell of the decree: The Lord said to me, “You are my Son; today I have begotten you. Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession. You shall break them with a rod of iron and dash them in pieces like a potter’s vessel.” Now therefore, O kings, be wise; be warned, O rulers of the earth. Serve the Lord with fear, and rejoice with trembling. Kiss the Son, lest he be angry, and you perish in the way, for his wrath is quickly kindled. Blessed are all who take refuge in him.’

Psalm 2:1-12

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.2.1-12>

The believers had taken refuge in the Anointed One, the Son begotten by the Father, who had authority over all the earth. Encouraged by their position in Christ and in the foreordained plan of God, the followers of Christ prayed, “Lord, look upon their threats and grant to your servants to continue to speak your word with all boldness, while you stretch out your hand to heal, and signs and wonders are performed through the name of your holy servant Jesus.” They asked to be strengthened by the Spirit to be boldly obedient to Jesus’ call to all believers in Mark 16 (Day 23): “Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned. And these signs will accompany those who believe...”

When the truth is heard, faith is born. When it is embraced and acted upon, the Holy Spirit confirms the truth, and signs result. The believers saw healing—God stretching out his hand to heal, even as he did for the lame man—among the signs and wonders that went along with their speaking of the word to build the church. Their prayer, their faith, and their obedience also brought glory to the Holy Spirit, who shook the place where they prayed and filled them. Their will was aligned with God’s will expressed through Jesus, and they continued to speak the word with boldness and build the church, only encouraged by the persecution that Peter and John had faced with rock-solid faith.

Prayer:

God, I will talk of your righteousness all day long, for those who seek my hurt are confounded and brought to shame. God, thank You that You cause me to overcome the world as I follow Christ, for greater is He who is in me than he that is in the world.

Based on Psalm 71:24, 1 John 4:4

[Song suggestions for Day 27](#)

Day 28: Peter leads the Jerusalem community of the followers of Jesus

The followers of Jesus in Jerusalem are described in the following passages:

'Now the full number of those who believed were of one heart and soul, and no one said that any of the things that belonged to him was his own, but they had everything in common. And with great power the apostles were giving their testimony to the resurrection of the Lord Jesus, and great grace was upon them all. There was not a needy person among them, for as many as were owners of lands or houses sold them and brought the proceeds of what was sold and laid it at the apostles' feet, and it was distributed to each as any had need. Thus Joseph, who was also called by the apostles Barnabas (which means son of encouragement), a Levite, a native of Cyprus, sold a field that belonged to him and brought the money and laid it at the apostles' feet.'

Acts 4:32-37

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.4.32-37>

'But a man named Ananias, with his wife Sapphira, sold a piece of property, and with his wife's knowledge he kept back for himself some of the proceeds and brought only a part of it and laid it at the apostles' feet. But Peter said, "Ananias, why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit and to keep back for yourself part of the proceeds of the land? While it remained unsold, did it not remain your own? And after it was sold, was it not at your disposal? Why is it that you have contrived this deed in your heart? You have not lied to man but to God." When Ananias heard these words, he fell down and breathed his last. And great fear came upon all who heard of it. The young men rose and wrapped him up and carried him out and buried him. After an interval of about three hours his wife came in, not knowing what had happened. And Peter said to her, "Tell me whether you sold the land for so much." And she said, "Yes, for so much." But Peter said to her, "How is it that you have agreed together to test the Spirit of the Lord? Behold, the feet of those who have buried your husband are at the door, and they will carry you out." Immediately she fell down at his feet and breathed her last. When the young men came in they found her dead, and they carried her out and buried her beside her husband. And great fear came upon the whole church and upon all who heard of these things.'

Acts 5:1-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.5.1-11>

Peter and the disciples had heard Jesus teach them:

' "The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field, which a man found and covered up. Then in his joy he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field. "Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a merchant in search of fine pearls, who, on finding one pearl of great value, went and sold all that he had and bought it. '

Matthew 13:44-46

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.13.44-46>

Jesus had since been glorified, and the Jerusalem community now had been given this treasure, this pearl of great value. Nothing compares to it.

Having the spirit of Christ, the Jerusalem community—the Jews baptized into Christ’s body—exhibited the unity that Jesus had prayed for in his church (John 17:21-26). The church showed selflessness, caring for one another, and the generosity of Jesus. The grace of Jesus is his beautiful, unwarranted giving, a divine outflowing of his nature as God. The church followed the will of God and the command of Jesus, preaching the gospel message. They were sowers, and they reaped. They were doers of the word, and along with doing the word came the power of the Spirit of God in confirmation, God working along with them.

Led by the apostles of Christ including Peter, the Jerusalem church also knew what it meant to count the cost of following Jesus in the face of persecution from the Jewish authorities and those they knew outside of the church. They did not see what God had given them as their own, but they were focused on doing the will of God, building up the church, and loving each other. The church was their family, precious to them even as it is precious to God, bought with the blood and sacrifice of Jesus Christ. There were no needy among them. They told the truth to each other and built each other up, having a common mission and love. Seeking first the kingdom of God, they were consecrated to God and to each other.

Yet, Satan worked against the growth of the church and the purposes of God, both through persecution by men like and including Saul (Acts 8:1-3), and from within. With regard to the latter, nothing is known about Ananias and Sapphira except what is written in the passage above. Ananias was living as part of the church, yet did not act as other members of the church fellowship, including Barnabus, did. Ananias was not willing to give all, and he was not willing to say so. His heart and his trust were not fully with Jesus and his church. He was distracted by the cares of the world. As such, Jesus was not his master, for his devotion lay elsewhere. In a community where the Holy Spirit filled and bore much fruit through the body of Christ, a body of fully devoted followers, Ananias was living a lie.

When Ananias laid the proceeds at Peter’s feet, the Holy Spirit, who was grieved, revealed the truth to Peter and gave him words to say: “Ananias, why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit and to keep back for yourself part of the proceeds of the land? While it remained unsold, did it not remain your own? And after it was sold, was it not at your disposal? Why is it that you have contrived this deed in your heart? You have not lied to man but to God.” The Spirit of God was grieved because Ananias had lied to him through his action. The Spirit of God

is not soft on sin; he is righteous. The Father allowed the Son to be tortured and crucified for the sins of many, and yet Ananias was not identified with Jesus. He was an imposter in a group of fully devoted followers where otherwise the Spirit of God was moving with great power and effect.

Ananias fell down, died, and was taken out to be buried. The expectations upon those who commit themselves to follow Jesus are great; they are accountable to God. Ananias was counted by God among the wicked:

' The fear of the Lord prolongs life, but the years of the wicked will be short. '

Proverbs 10:27

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PRO.10.27>

Ananias' death resulted in fear among those who heard of it.

Sapphira knew Ananias "kept back for himself some of the proceeds," and she did not stop him from giving only part of what they should have given. Later, Sapphira came to Peter, and he tested her, "Tell me whether you sold the land for so much." Sapphira then chose to lie directly to Peter, who replied, "How is it that you have agreed together to test the Spirit of the Lord? Behold, the feet of those who have buried your husband are at the door, and they will carry you out."

Her life was immediately taken from her as well, either directly by the Spirit of God, or by God allowing the accuser to do what he does—to kill and destroy. She was buried beside her husband.

And great fear came upon the whole church and upon all who heard of these things.

Referring back to Jesus' teaching discussed on Day 14, followers of Jesus are to be faithful and wise managers, or stewards, remembering that nothing they have been given belongs to them.

Every good and perfect gift comes from God, and we are expected to manage it wisely. This includes anything we have received:

our money,

our time,

our energy,

our family,

our relationships outside of family,

any position,

any responsibility,

any ability,
any gift,
our free will.

We have no right to call it “mine.” We are to recognize it to be from God and manage it appropriately. To those whom much is given, more is expected.

It is not about us. Never. It is not appropriate to decide our master is delayed in coming, then begin to live according to our own will.

Those who know the truth, yet forget who they are and serve themselves instead of God, saying, “my will be done,” will receive punishment.

Instead, we are to live ready as children of God, servants, stewards, to whom much has been entrusted.

Those who are found ready remember who they are, know the master’s will, remember the master’s will, and act according to his will.

Prayer:

Father, thank You for the mystery revealed to me that had been hidden for ages and generations, Christ in me, the hope of glory. You are my treasure, and You have brought me exceeding joy.

- Based on Colossians 1:26-27, Matthew 13:44-46

[Song suggestions for Day 28](#)

Day 29: Peter becomes healing

In recent days we have seen how Peter was used to speak God's words by his Spirit, with God confirming the word and the church experiencing great growth. Today's short passage shows further growth of Peter into the likeness of Jesus:

'Now many signs and wonders were regularly done among the people by the hands of the apostles. And they were all together in Solomon's Portico. None of the rest dared join them, but the people held them in high esteem. And more than ever believers were added to the Lord, multitudes of both men and women, so that they even carried out the sick into the streets and laid them on cots and mats, that as Peter came by at least his shadow might fall on some of them. The people also gathered from the towns around Jerusalem, bringing the sick and those afflicted with unclean spirits, and they were all healed. '

Acts 5:12-16

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.5.12-16>

"Now many signs and wonders were regularly done among the people by the hands of the apostles." This is the fifth mention of signs or signs and wonders in the book of Acts. The followers of Jesus spread the word of God by signs and wonders, consistent with the command of Jesus and the description of what followed in Mark 16. Many miracles came with the preaching of the gospel to confirm it. The Holy Spirit brought life through healing along with eternal life. The Holy Spirit brought a full salvation, often a double cure, to others through the obedience of the disciples of Jesus. The preaching of the word of God with signs by the church brought multitudes more men and women to faith in Jesus.

From the time of Jesus' life on earth onward, the gospel, where it has been embraced, has been a strong force for freedom and the worth of each human, lifting up the dignity of every race, both men and women, slave and free, and every form of marginalized person.

The disciples continued to meet in Solomon's Portico of the temple, where Peter had preached words of the Spirit after Jesus healed the lame man through him at the Beautiful Gate (Day 26).

The healing and freedom brought by the ministry of Jesus through the apostles, especially Peter, had become especially noteworthy. The word about it was out, and people came not only from Jerusalem but from the towns around Jerusalem to be healed and set free.

There were so many coming to be healed from oppression that they came everywhere they knew Peter to frequent; "...they even carried out the sick into the streets and laid them on cots and mats, that as Peter came by at least his shadow might fall on some of them."

They were all healed—healed from their diseases and/or freed from the spirits that afflicted them. Just as Jesus did when he was doing it directly, Peter through Jesus healed all who came to him (Matthew 8:16, Matthew 12:15, Matthew 14:4, Matthew 19:2, Matthew 21:14, Mark 3:10, Mark 6:56, Luke 4:40, Luke 5:17, Luke 6:10).

Peter had witnessed Jesus heal and deliver so many. Jesus healed through his word. He healed through his touch. People were healed by touching his garments (Day 5). Jesus is Life (zoe), and life flows from him.

Similarly, Peter, with the resurrection life of Jesus in him, healed through his words and through his touch. Here it even seems that life was radiating from him: "...they even carried out the sick into the streets and laid them on cots and mats, that as Peter came by at least his shadow might fall on some of them... and they were all healed." What Jesus had proclaimed had become true of Peter, filled by the Spirit:

'Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture has said, 'Out of his heart will flow rivers of living water.'" Now this he said about the Spirit, whom those who believed in him were to receive, for as yet the Spirit had not been given, because Jesus was not yet glorified. '

John 7:38-39

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.7.38-39>

Yet it is not only Peter's faith that mattered according to God's ways; just as when Jesus healed directly, the faith of others mattered as well, such as the woman who touched his garment and was healed. Many people came to Jesus to be healed over the course of his ministry, believing they would be based on the testimony of another. They were all healed.

Still speaking of God's ways, there also seems to be a "cumulative power of mass faith" when the Spirit of Christ heals, as F.F. Bosworth first said. The faith on the part of many together accumulates, or builds up, to an overflow of the Spirit, bringing the Spirit of God to give life to all who are in need of it.

In this passage, we see that Peter—with the glorified Christ working powerfully in him—had become healing to the masses. He was filled with the fullness of Christ, the Author of Life. Peter's whole being was brought into perfect harmony with the living God so that the resurrection life of the Spirit of God radiated through his spirit, his mind, and his body. He did

the kingdom works that Jesus did, becoming a channel (or conduit) of God to the world: healing, blessing, deliverance, all things in heaven. He made himself available and gave freely to all who had need.

Prayer:

Father, I thank You that to set my mind on the Spirit is life and peace. I thank You that out of my heart flow rivers of living water because I believe in Jesus. I thank You that all things, whatsoever I ask in prayer, believing, I shall receive.

- Based on Romans 8:5-6, John 7:38, Matthew 21:22

[Song suggestions for Day 29](#)

Day 30: Peter preaches Life after being freed from prison by an angel

The apostles' continued victories through Jesus came with continued opposition prompted by the enemy:

'But the high priest rose up, and all who were with him (that is, the party of the Sadducees), and filled with jealousy they arrested the apostles and put them in the public prison. But during the night an angel of the Lord opened the prison doors and brought them out, and said, "Go and stand in the temple and speak to the people all the words of this Life." And when they heard this, they entered the temple at daybreak and began to teach. Now when the high priest came, and those who were with him, they called together the council, all the senate of the people of Israel, and sent to the prison to have them brought. But when the officers came, they did not find them in the prison, so they returned and reported, "We found the prison securely locked and the guards standing at the doors, but when we opened them we found no one inside." Now when the captain of the temple and the chief priests heard these words, they were greatly perplexed about them, wondering what this would come to. And someone came and told them, "Look! The men whom you put in prison are standing in the temple and teaching the people." Then the captain with the officers went and brought them, but not by force, for they were afraid of being stoned by the people. And when they had brought them, they set them before the council. And the high priest questioned them, saying, "We strictly charged you not to teach in this name, yet here you have filled Jerusalem with your teaching, and you intend to bring this man's blood upon us." But Peter and the apostles answered, "We must obey God rather than men. The God of our fathers raised Jesus, whom you killed by hanging him on a tree. God exalted him at his right hand as Leader and Savior, to give repentance to Israel and forgiveness of sins. And we are witnesses to these things, and so is the Holy Spirit, whom God has given to those who obey him." When they heard this, they were enraged and wanted to kill them. But a Pharisee in the council named Gamaliel, a teacher of the law held in honor by all the people, stood up and gave orders to put the men outside for a little while. And he said to them, "Men of Israel, take care what you are about to do with these men. For before these days Theudas rose up, claiming to be somebody, and a number of men, about four hundred, joined him. He was killed, and all who followed him were dispersed and came to nothing. After him Judas the Galilean rose up in the days of the census and drew away some of the people after him. He too perished, and all who followed him were scattered. So in the present case I tell you, keep away from these men and let them alone, for if this plan or this undertaking is of man, it will fail; but if it is of God, you will not be able to overthrow them. You might even be found opposing God!" So they took his advice, and when they had called in the apostles, they beat them and charged them not to speak in the name of Jesus, and let them go. Then they left the presence of the council, rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name. And every

day, in the temple and from house to house, they did not cease teaching and preaching that the Christ is Jesus.'

Acts 5:17-42

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.5.17-42>

Peter and John continued to defy the command of the high priest and the Sadducees (Day 27) not to speak the name of Jesus anymore, as they said they would. The other apostles did the same, and together they continued to draw Jews from Jerusalem into following Jesus: "more than ever believers were added to the Lord, multitudes of both men and women." "Filled with jealousy," the authorities put them in prison, thinking that making all of their leaders captive would stop the growth of the church. But it's not possible to thwart the will of God, who sent an angel to free these ambassadors of Jesus: "during the night an angel of the Lord opened the prison doors and brought them out." They were freed in such a way that nobody noticed them leave.

The angel gave the command of God to them: "Go and stand in the temple and speak to the people all the words of this Life." God's will was to give life, life abundantly, and life eternal through the continued ministry of these apostles by the Holy Spirit. This is still his will. The life of God is planted as an imperishable seed through the preaching of the word of God by the ambassadors of God as part of the kingdom of God.

The imperishable seed is born by the living and abiding Word of God when one confesses Jesus Christ as Lord with one's lips. Like DNA is in the physical, it is a blueprint for the way our lives in the Spirit should unfold. It is in us a new creation, not unlike the creation of the physical universe at the beginning, born by the spoken word of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit. God watches over his word to perform it. The sower's seed abiding in us is a fountain of life, and it brings forth life, creating something of divine nature that grows in us which lasts forever. It has joined us to Him forever as one spirit, making us the temple of the living God, the very dwelling of God. The image of God is formed in us through Christ. As we seek and behold the glory of the Lord, while loving Him and fervently loving others with His compassion, the resurrection life of Jesus Christ expands into us, into our souls and our bodies, and we are transformed into the image of Christ, from one degree of glory to another. It is Christ in us that quickens, the Spirit of the living God, and we are hid in Christ. Having been slayed with Him, so that we no longer live. Instead, we are made alive together with the regnant Christ— freed, purified, sanctified, our minds renewed to have the mind of Christ— and, seated in Him, we are adopted as sons (heirs) of God, equipped with all of His fullness to bear fruit that displays His glory and the glory of His creation. In this new creation, He blesses us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places, supplies all of our needs and all things that pertain to life and godliness, and He makes our joy

complete in answering prayers that are prayed in faith, in His name, for His glory. Out of our hearts flow rivers of living water. As the new creation expands in the body of Christ, the beloved, His will is done on earth as it is in heaven, and our righteous, ever victorious God makes everything He encounters right. In His new creation, He does far more abundantly than all we ask or think, according to the power at work within us. This is Life by God's design.

Jesus taught many parables about the kingdom of God that were heard by Peter, John, and many others. Among these were the parable of the mustard seed (Matthew 13:31-32, Mark 4:3-34, Luke 13:18-19), an especially small seed that grows into an impressively large tree. (The mustard tree is native to Persia, growing best in hot, arid climates in sandy soil.) And so it is that God's life grows in us from the seed of the Word of God.

Now we return to today's passage. At daybreak, the apostles started to sow seeds among the people in the temple in accordance with the command of God to expand his kingdom. Their escape cloaked by the action of God, it took awhile for the authorities to find that they were not in prison anymore and to hear that they were in the temple teaching. The apostles had such rapport with the people and the crowds were so unruly that, afraid for their lives, the officers decided to bring the apostles to the Jewish council this time in a peaceful manner.

The high priest then made his offense known: "We strictly charged you not to teach in this name, yet here you have filled Jerusalem with your teaching, and you intend to bring this man's blood upon us."

Peter and the other apostles began by restating the message Peter had already conveyed to them: "We must obey God rather than men. The God of our fathers raised Jesus, whom you killed by hanging him on a tree." Not afraid to speak the truth and to confront those who sent Jesus to his death, Peter informed the high priest that the authority of God trumped his authority, and so they would obey God. Having no fear of men, Peter stood up and spoke up boldly for the Truth again.

The apostles continued their testimony: "God exalted him at his right hand as Leader and Savior, to give repentance to Israel and forgiveness of sins. And we are witnesses to these things, and so is the Holy Spirit, whom God has given to those who obey him." They stated that both Jesus, at the right hand of God, having authority over all things, and the Holy Spirit were with them because they were obedient. This Jesus they killed is now Savior and Leader, and he had called all Israel, them included, to repentance. Filled with the Spirit, Peter and the apostles were determined.

At the apostles' continued defiance and perceived blasphemy, the council was enraged, wanting to kill them. At this time, "Gamaliel, a teacher of the law held in honor by all the people" used his influence and sent the apostles away so he could reason with the council. He spoke wisely, giving a recommendation for how to proceed in a new way based upon the history of Theudas and Judas the Galilean. His counsel ended: "...in the present case I tell you, keep away from these men and let them alone, for if this plan or this undertaking is of man, it will fail; but if it is of God, you will not be able to overthrow them. You might even be found opposing God!"

The council thought that the undertaking of the apostles was of man rather than of God, so they agreed to Gamaliel's advice. In order to try to deter the apostles, they beat them and "charged them not to speak in the name of Jesus" before releasing them.

The apostles' arrest and beating did not have the intended effect. Instead, the apostles rejoiced "that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name," even as they did after Peter and John were arrested previously. Genuinely excited to be such a part of the story of God, the apostles were also obedient to the command of Jesus to them to rejoice and be glad:

' "Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are you when others revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account. Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven, for so they persecuted the prophets who were before you. "

Matthew 5:10-12

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.5.10-12>

This is the way the church grew and has always grown. The disciples did not ask to have it any other way. They rejoiced to be counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name of Jesus.

"And every day, in the temple and from house to house, they did not cease teaching and preaching that the Christ is Jesus." Following in Jesus' steps and led by his Spirit, they preached openly, just as Jesus did:

' The high priest then questioned Jesus about his disciples and his teaching. Jesus answered him, "I have spoken openly to the world. I have always taught in synagogues and in the temple, where all Jews come together. I have said nothing in secret." '

John 18:19-20

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.18.19-20>

This was Jesus' way, so it was Peter's way. Like Jesus, Peter also made himself available. Like Jesus, he was bold. Like Jesus, he was compassionate, and he was determined.

Peter and the apostles continued to evangelize from house to house, as trained by Jesus when he sent them among the twelve (Day 6) and among the seventy-two (Day 13). In public and in private, they taught, making disciples first in Jerusalem, as commanded by Jesus.

This was and is the will of God for all of the believers: to join God in the growing of his church, the bride of Christ. This is his kingdom purpose, and, in the center of God's will, they could not fail.

Prayer:

Thanks be to You, God, who in Christ always leads me in triumphal procession, and through us spreads the fragrance of the knowledge of him everywhere. I praise you, Lord, for the ways You choose to overcome through the blood of the Lamb and through the word of our testimony. You have made me as bold as a lion.

- Based on 2 Corinthians 2:14-15, Revelation 12:11, Proverbs 28:1

[Song suggestions for Day 30](#)

Day 31: Peter confronts Simon the Magician for trying to buy power

Peter's recorded ministry to this point had focused in Jerusalem, where Jesus had commanded the disciples to go and wait to be "clothed with power from on high" (Day 23), which they had been (Day 24). In the following passage, we find that Peter was led to leave Jerusalem to minister in Samaria:

'But there was a man named Simon, who had previously practiced magic in the city and amazed the people of Samaria, saying that he himself was somebody great. They all paid attention to him, from the least to the greatest, saying, "This man is the power of God that is called Great." And they paid attention to him because for a long time he had amazed them with his magic. But when they believed Philip as he preached good news about the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ, they were baptized, both men and women. Even Simon himself believed, and after being baptized he continued with Philip. And seeing signs and great miracles performed, he was amazed. Now when the apostles at Jerusalem heard that Samaria had received the word of God, they sent to them Peter and John, who came down and prayed for them that they might receive the Holy Spirit, for he had not yet fallen on any of them, but they had only been baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. Then they laid their hands on them and they received the Holy Spirit. Now when Simon saw that the Spirit was given through the laying on of the apostles' hands, he offered them money, saying, "Give me this power also, so that anyone on whom I lay my hands may receive the Holy Spirit." But Peter said to him, "May your silver perish with you, because you thought you could obtain the gift of God with money! You have neither part nor lot in this matter, for your heart is not right before God. Repent, therefore, of this wickedness of yours, and pray to the Lord that, if possible, the intent of your heart may be forgiven you. For I see that you are in the gall of bitterness and in the bond of iniquity." And Simon answered, "Pray for me to the Lord, that nothing of what you have said may come upon me." Now when they had testified and spoken the word of the Lord, they returned to Jerusalem, preaching the gospel to many villages of the Samaritans. '

Acts 8:9-25

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.8.9-25>

Peter and John went to Samaria because they had "heard that Samaria had received the word of God." Very similar things that were happening in Jerusalem through Peter and the Spirit of God were happening also in Samaria through Philip: "they believed Philip as he preached good news about the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ, they were baptized, both men and women." Additionally, there were "signs and great miracles performed" in confirmation of the good news that was being preached, as had become usual among the ministry of the apostles, according to the design of God (Mark 16:20).

However, there was one difference in the outcome in Samaria compared to that in Jerusalem, and this is why they had come. Peter and John “came down and prayed for them that they might receive the Holy Spirit, for he had not yet fallen on any of them, but they had only been baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.” The believers in Samaria had not received the Holy Spirit, only having been baptized in Jesus’ name. The apostles knew that Peter and John could bring them baptism also in the Holy Spirit, transferred through Christ-in-them by means of the laying on of their hands.

So “[Peter and John] laid their hands on them and they received the Holy Spirit.” Even the Samaritans! God had sent them out— and not just to Jerusalem. Jesus had said to them, “But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth” (Day 23).

The Spirit of God within him, Peter followed the word of God to bring toward completion to the work of God within this part of God’s church, according to the commission of Jesus to him and all the believers. This being the will of God, God worked with him.

This power was not understood by Simon the Magician in Samaria, who practiced magic and wanted to be great through showing people his power. People thought he had the power of God. After hearing the word of God preached by Philip with signs and wonders following, Simon the Magician was amazed and he believed, but he did not yet understand the ways of God. When he saw Peter and John’s power to give the Holy Spirit to the Samaritan believers by the laying on of their hands, he decided that he wanted this power. He would pay for it with his silver obtained from his career in magic. He told Peter and John, “Give me this power also, so that anyone on whom I lay my hands may receive the Holy Spirit.”

Taken aback, Peter upbraided Simon the Magician, speaking rebuke from God: “May your silver perish with you, because you thought you could obtain the gift of God with money! You have neither part nor lot in this matter, for your heart is not right before God. Repent, therefore, of this wickedness of yours, and pray to the Lord that, if possible, the intent of your heart may be forgiven you. For I see that you are in the gall of bitterness and in the bond of iniquity.”

The gift of the Holy Spirit was earned by Jesus Christ through his own suffering and crucifixion. After descending to hell, Jesus was raised to life and glorified by the Father, seated at his right hand, given all authority, and provided the ability to give the Holy Spirit to his followers in accordance with the promise in Scripture. Obtained at such a price, Jesus does not give the Holy Spirit to those whose hearts are not right before him.

Simon the Magician thought he could obtain the presence and power of God through purchase. In the Spirit, Peter saw him as God did. Still in the bondage of his sin, Simon the Magician had no part in God. His heart was wicked. Having intuition from the Spirit, Peter also discerned bitterness in his heart.

In the Spirit, Peter had both knowledge and wisdom from God, his consciousness fused into God's at His Throne as part of Christ's body. That which was said of Jesus by Isaiah could also be said of Peter, now filled with the fullness of the Spirit:

'And the Spirit of the Lord shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding, the Spirit of counsel and might, the Spirit of knowledge and the fear of the Lord . '

Isaiah 11:2

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.11.2>

Referring back to the passage, this was an occasion that the Spirit of the Lord brought rebuke. And it was effective. Simon the Magician had listened, and he responded to Simon Peter, "Pray for me to the Lord, that nothing of what you have said may come upon me."

Peter and John then "testified and [spoke] the word of the Lord" to the Samaritan believers they had baptized in the Spirit, making disciples. Obedient to the commission of Jesus to them, they also preached the gospel to many nearby Samaritan villages before returning to Jerusalem. As a leader in the church, Peter was the mouth and the feet of Jesus. He spoke the words of Jesus and went where the Lord wanted him to go, multiplying the grace and peace of God and doing the will of God.

Peter was one of whom Isaiah spoke, "How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news, who publishes peace, who brings good news of happiness, who publishes salvation..." (Isaiah 52:7).

Prayer:

Jesus, I thank You that as part of Your church I have become one flesh with You. God, stir up your gift in me. I thank You for giving me not a spirit of fear, but of power, of love, and of a sound mind.

- Based on Ephesians 5:30-32, 2 Timothy 1:6-7

[Song suggestions for Day 31](#)

Day 32: Peter heals a bedridden man

Peter's preaching of the kingdom of God had come with confirmation through signs and wonders that God was working with him in Jerusalem. As the Spirit of God moved with the believers that were led to speak the gospel, Peter moved as well:

'So the church throughout all Judea and Galilee and Samaria had peace and was being built up. And walking in the fear of the Lord and in the comfort of the Holy Spirit, it multiplied. Now as Peter went here and there among them all, he came down also to the saints who lived at Lydda. There he found a man named Aeneas, bedridden for eight years, who was paralyzed. And Peter said to him, "Aeneas, Jesus Christ heals you; rise and make your bed." And immediately he rose. And all the residents of Lydda and Sharon saw him, and they turned to the Lord. '

Acts 9:31-35

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.9.31-35>

The church in all of Israel was being built up and multiplied through the work of living God to give life, accomplished through the obedience of the apostles. On the occasion recorded in this passage, Peter had headed northwest from Jerusalem to minister with the church in Lydda. At Lydda, Peter freed a man who had been bedridden for eight years.

At Peter's home, Peter had seen Jesus heal his mother-in-law with a touch. Then he healed and freed many others with his word (Day 3). After receiving the Holy Spirit at Pentecost, Peter had healed many. To the lame man at the Beautiful Gate (Day 23), Peter gazed at him and said, "In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk!" And he had raised the man up. After that, we saw that Peter had become healing to everyone in need that was even near to him (Day 29).

To Aeneas, Peter simply informed him, "Aeneas, Jesus Christ heals you..." and demanded, "rise and make your bed." His faith mature, Peter expected that God would act according to his word, his nature, and his general will.

By Peter's command in faith, Aeneas was healed. Peter said what the living Jesus willed to do for the man, he believed it was done, and it was so. Aeneas heard Peter's command and obeyed: "immediately he rose."

And just as at the Beautiful Gate, many who saw it turned to the Lord. This way of complete salvation is clearly the way Jesus chooses to work in a general sense.

The love of God had been shed abroad in Peter's heart by the Holy Ghost (Romans 5:5), and he loved people as Jesus did, leading many to repentance. In his ministry, Peter continued to demonstrate to the world that all power had been given to the church. Healing opened the doors to people's hearts, leading them to seek salvation. The power of God in healing is one of Jesus' mightiest weapons, as is well shown in Peter's ministry.

Prayer:

I praise You, O Lord, for You are my healer (Rapha). Your words are life and healing to all of my flesh. From my heart flow the springs of life.

- Based on Exodus 15:26, Proverbs 4:23

[Song suggestions for Day 32](#)

Day 33: Peter raises a dead woman

This passage continues the account of Peter's trip to minister among the church in Lydda:

'Now there was in Joppa a disciple named Tabitha, which, translated, means Dorcas. She was full of good works and acts of charity. In those days she became ill and died, and when they had washed her, they laid her in an upper room. Since Lydda was near Joppa, the disciples, hearing that Peter was there, sent two men to him, urging him, "Please come to us without delay." So Peter rose and went with them. And when he arrived, they took him to the upper room. All the widows stood beside him weeping and showing tunics and other garments that Dorcas made while she was with them. But Peter put them all outside, and knelt down and prayed; and turning to the body he said, "Tabitha, arise." And she opened her eyes, and when she saw Peter she sat up. And he gave her his hand and raised her up. Then, calling the saints and widows, he presented her alive. And it became known throughout all Joppa, and many believed in the Lord. And he stayed in Joppa for many days with one Simon, a tanner.'

Acts 9:36-43

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.9.36-43>

Below is part of the passage from Day 5 where Peter had witnessed Jesus raise a dead girl:

'...While [Jesus] was still speaking, someone from the ruler's house came and said, "Your daughter is dead; do not trouble the Teacher any more." But Jesus on hearing this answered him, "Do not fear; only believe, and she will be well." And when he came to the house, he allowed no one to enter with him, except Peter and John and James, and the father and mother of the child. And all were weeping and mourning for her, but he said, "Do not weep, for she is not dead but sleeping." And they laughed at him, knowing that she was dead. But taking her by the hand he called, saying, "Child, arise." And her spirit returned, and she got up at once. And he directed that something should be given her to eat. '

Peter had seen Jesus raise the dead before on occasions such as this one, where Jesus had said, "...only believe, and she will be well." Jesus had allowed none to witness this time except Peter, John, and James.

These three had also been sent out by Jesus to do the works of Jesus (Day 6), where Jesus commanded them, "...proclaim as you go, saying, 'The kingdom of heaven is at hand.' Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse lepers, cast out demons. You received without paying; give without pay."

The twelve disciples were made to multiply the works of Jesus, and it created quite a stir, as we learn from Herod's recorded reaction:

' Now Herod the tetrarch heard about all that was happening, and he was perplexed, because it was said by some that John had been raised from the dead, by some that Elijah had appeared, and by others that one of the prophets of old had risen. '

Luke 9:7-8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.9.7-8>

Peter had likely raised the dead himself before the incident recorded here in Acts 9. When Peter was at Lydda, he heard of the death of another disciple, Tabitha, in a nearby town. Some believers sent for Peter, likely knowing he had a reputation of being able to raise the dead through his faith: "Please come to us without delay." We know Tabitha was a godly woman, "full of good works and acts of charity." What a beautiful description of a wonderful follower of Jesus.

Obedient to the will of God to give as he had received and do what he would want done for him, Peter believed and he went without delay to Tabitha in Joppa: "Peter rose and went with them." Tabitha had "saints and widows" gathered to mourn her. Those who show up when one dies are telling of one's life. Tabitha was a devoted follower of Christ. Her main "good works and acts of charity" were to local widows. The widows there wept, and they showed off some of Tabitha's creativity and the charity she had shared with them: "tunics and other garments that Tabitha made while she was with them." These were very likely clothes for both the women and their children, and they were well done enough to be prized by these women. Tabitha was like a sister to them, one sent from God, who "executes justice for the fatherless and the widow, and loves the sojourner, giving him food and clothing."

Deuteronomy 10:18

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/DEU.10.18>

We are also reminded here of what the disciple James wrote:

"Religion that is pure and undefiled before God the Father is this: to visit orphans and widows in their affliction, and to keep oneself unstained from the world."

James 1:27

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JAS.1.27>

Tabitha was close to the heart of God.

Even as Jesus had wanted to be alone except for those in his inner circle, Peter included, when he raised the dead girl, "Peter put them all outside [the upper room where Tabitha lay], and knelt down and prayed." God was his source of power and life, and Jesus had taught him to pray and to have such faith. Peter's faith and works had been strengthened by receiving the Holy Spirit

and becoming a bold speaker and doer of the word. Peter had decided to live the life and ministry that Jesus did, he who said:

' "Truly, truly, I say to you, whoever believes in me will also do the works that I do; and greater works than these will he do, because I am going to the Father. Whatever you ask [demand] in my name, this I will do, that the Father may be glorified in the Son. '

John 14:12-13

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.14.12-13>

'...and turning to the body he demanded, "Tabitha, arise"', even as he had witnessed Jesus say to the dead girl, "Child, arise" to give her life through the Spirit of God. Peter followed in Jesus' steps, believing Tabitha would be made whole through speaking the words of Jesus. And it was so: "...she opened her eyes, and when she saw Peter she sat up."

The word of Christ dwelled in Peter richly in all wisdom, and His word was alive in Peter. God's Word is sharper than a two-edged sword.

Just as he had seen Jesus take the girl by the hand, life (zoe) flowing into her, Peter "gave [Tabitha] his hand and raised her up. Then, calling the saints and widows, he presented her alive." The law of the Spirit of life in Peter had set Tabitha free in Christ Jesus from the law of sin and death. God had prepared good works in advance (Ephesians 2:20) for Peter on this journey. Two of them were named Aeneas and Tabitha, and Peter was faithful to make right what had been wrong.

This giving of life from the fountain of living waters "became known throughout all Joppa, and many believed in the Lord. And he stayed in Joppa for many days with one Simon, a tanner." While he stayed with them, Peter ministered and made disciples.

Peter was joined to the Lord and had become one spirit with him, just as it is written "... he who is joined to the Lord becomes one spirit with him. '

1 Corinthians 6:17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1CO.6.17>

Peter had become what Jesus said of him (Day 6): "And I tell you, you are Peter [Petros], and on this rock [petra] I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it." Even death did not prevail against the growth of the church; we see here that the power of God to prevail against the gates of hell just caused it to grow further.

Prayer:

God, You sent out Your word and healed me, and delivered me from my destruction. I thank You, Lord, for Your steadfast love, for Your wondrous works to the children of man! I offer sacrifices of thanksgiving, and tell of Your deeds in songs of joy!

- Based on Psalm 107:20-22

[Song suggestions for Day 33](#)

Day 34: God speaks to Peter through visions

While Peter stayed at Simon the tanner's house on the Mediterranean sea, God was also at work north of him near the sea in Caesarea:

'At Caesarea there was a man named Cornelius, a centurion of what was known as the Italian Cohort, a devout man who feared God with all his household, gave alms generously to the people, and prayed continually to God. About the ninth hour of the day he saw clearly in a vision an angel of God come in and say to him, "Cornelius." And he stared at him in terror and said, "What is it, Lord?" And he said to him, "Your prayers and your alms have ascended as a memorial before God. And now send men to Joppa and bring one Simon who is called Peter. He is lodging with one Simon, a tanner, whose house is by the sea." When the angel who spoke to him had departed, he called two of his servants and a devout soldier from among those who attended him, and having related everything to them, he sent them to Joppa. The next day, as they were on their journey and approaching the city, Peter went up on the housetop about the sixth hour to pray. And he became hungry and wanted something to eat, but while they were preparing it, he fell into a trance and saw the heavens opened and something like a great sheet descending, being let down by its four corners upon the earth. In it were all kinds of animals and reptiles and birds of the air. And there came a voice to him: "Rise, Peter; kill and eat." But Peter said, "By no means, Lord; for I have never eaten anything that is common or unclean." And the voice came to him again a second time, "What God has made clean, do not call common." This happened three times, and the thing was taken up at once to heaven. Now while Peter was inwardly perplexed as to what the vision that he had seen might mean, behold, the men who were sent by Cornelius, having made inquiry for Simon's house, stood at the gate and called out to ask whether Simon who was called Peter was lodging there. And while Peter was pondering the vision, the Spirit said to him, "Behold, three men are looking for you. Rise and go down and accompany them without hesitation, for I have sent them." And Peter went down to the men and said, "I am the one you are looking for. What is the reason for your coming?" And they said, "Cornelius, a centurion, an upright and God-fearing man, who is well spoken of by the whole Jewish nation, was directed by a holy angel to send for you to come to his house and to hear what you have to say." So he invited them in to be his guests. The next day he rose and went away with them, and some of the brothers from Joppa accompanied him. And on the following day they entered Caesarea. Cornelius was expecting them and had called together his relatives and close friends. When Peter entered, Cornelius met him and fell down at his feet and worshiped him. But Peter lifted him up, saying, "Stand up; I too am a man." And as he talked with him, he went in and found many persons gathered. And he said to them, "You yourselves know how unlawful it is for a Jew to associate with or to visit anyone of another nation, but God has shown me that I should not call any person common or unclean. So when I was sent for, I came without objection. I ask then why you sent for me." And Cornelius said, "Four days ago,

about this hour, I was praying in my house at the ninth hour, and behold, a man stood before me in bright clothing and said, 'Cornelius, your prayer has been heard and your alms have been remembered before God. Send therefore to Joppa and ask for Simon who is called Peter. He is lodging in the house of Simon, a tanner, by the sea.' So I sent for you at once, and you have been kind enough to come. Now therefore we are all here in the presence of God to hear all that you have been commanded by the Lord." So Peter opened his mouth and said: "Truly I understand that God shows no partiality, but in every nation anyone who fears him and does what is right is acceptable to him. As for the word that he sent to Israel, preaching good news of peace through Jesus Christ (he is Lord of all), you yourselves know what happened throughout all Judea, beginning from Galilee after the baptism that John proclaimed: how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him. And we are witnesses of all that he did both in the country of the Jews and in Jerusalem. They put him to death by hanging him on a tree, but God raised him on the third day and made him to appear, not to all the people but to us who had been chosen by God as witnesses, who ate and drank with him after he rose from the dead. And he commanded us to preach to the people and to testify that he is the one appointed by God to be judge of the living and the dead. To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name." While Peter was still saying these things, the Holy Spirit fell on all who heard the word. And the believers from among the circumcised who had come with Peter were amazed, because the gift of the Holy Spirit was poured out even on the Gentiles. For they were hearing them speaking in tongues and extolling God. Then Peter declared, "Can anyone withhold water for baptizing these people, who have received the Holy Spirit just as we have?" And he commanded them to be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ. Then they asked him to remain for some days.'

Acts 10:1-48

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.10.1-48>

Though a Gentile and part of the Roman occupation of Israel, Cornelius was described as "a devout man who feared God with all his household, gave alms generously to the people, and prayed continually to God." Such a man must have been rare.

Revelation describes the prayers of the saints as an offering that rises to God on his throne from golden bowls of incense by the hand of an angel (5:8,8:3-4). An angel appeared to Cornelius in a vision in response to his prayer, causing him "terror," yet able to speak. Asked to speak, the angel reported, "Your prayers and your alms have ascended as a memorial before God." Not a respecter of persons, God had heard this Gentile's prayer and was answering it, first asking Cornelius to send for Peter in Joppa.

While two of Cornelius' servants and a devout soldier traveled south to Joppa, Peter was up on Simon the tanner's roof, probably looking out at the sea, praying, and he became hungry, most likely for lunch (assuming the sixth hour is given in Jewish time, which is noon, rather than Roman time). Peter asked his host to prepare him food and waited.

'...while they were preparing it, he fell into a trance and saw the heavens opened and something like a great sheet descending, being let down by its four corners upon the earth. In it were all kinds of animals and reptiles and birds of the air. And there came a voice to him: "Rise, Peter; kill and eat." '

Peter had a vision of his own from God as he waited to eat. He was given a command from God to kill and eat any of the animals he saw in the vision. A follower of Jewish law, Peter replied, "By no means, Lord; for I have never eaten anything that is common or unclean." He had once before received a command from Jesus about what to eat when he was sent to minister to one of 36 towns in Israel as part of the seventy-two (Day 13): "Whenever you enter a town and they receive you, eat what is set before you. Heal the sick in it and say to them, 'The kingdom of God has come near to you.' "

Yet now, led by Peter, Jesus' followers were about to be sent to the Gentiles, in accordance with Jesus' command (Day 23): "It is not for you to know times or seasons that the Father has fixed by his own authority. But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

In a new season, God told Peter, "What God has made clean, do not call common." Just as Jesus asked him to care for his sheep three times (Day 22), God sent Peter this vision three times. It's possible here that Peter also denied God three times when it came to what he would be willing to eat: "By no means..."

In any case, this vision greatly perplexed Peter. 'And while Peter was pondering the vision, the Spirit said to him, "Behold, three men are looking for you. Rise and go down and accompany them without hesitation, for I have sent them." ' Peter learned that Cornelius had been ' "directed by a holy angel to send for [Peter] to come to his house and to hear what [Peter had] to say." So after inviting them to stay at Simon's for the night, Peter obeyed God and set out to see Cornelius the next day. Some of the brothers from the church in Joppa accompanied him; Peter calls them "witnesses of all that [Jesus] did both in the country of the Jews and in Jerusalem."

“When Peter entered, Cornelius met him and fell down at his feet and worshiped him” because Peter was sent by God according to the vision that Cornelius had received. Peter quickly corrected him, and Peter came to find that Cornelius had invited his friends and family to hear from the Lord through Peter.

Peter was God’s first chosen messenger to the Gentiles, the one to speak for Jesus! It was not lawful for him according to Jewish tradition, but he was obedient to God, saying, “God has shown me that I should not call any person common or unclean.” Further, Peter no longer lived, but instead Christ lived in him, and he was hid in Christ.

And so he opened his mouth and spoke words from the Spirit of God, “Truly I understand that God shows no partiality, but in every nation anyone who fears him and does what is right is acceptable to him.” God is no respecter of persons, all of whom he has created. He is a God that rewards faith and the pursuit of righteousness.

Peter continued to speak words from God, summarizing the ministry of Jesus to the Jews in the following way: “...God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him.”

This summary is worth reading twice. In all that Peter saw Jesus do, God the Father and the Holy Spirit were with him to do good and to heal all who were oppressed by the devil. Peter had seen Jesus perform many healings and drive devils out of many at Peter’s home (Day 3), heal a woman who touched his garment and raise a girl from the dead (Day 5), feed a multitude through the disciples (Day 7), and drive out a spirit by prayer (Day 12). Jesus had compassion on and healed *all* who came to him—those oppressed by the devil (Matthew 8:16, Matthew 12:15, Matthew 14:4, Matthew 19:2, Matthew 21:14, Mark 3:10, Mark 6:56, Luke 4:40, Luke 5:17, Luke 6:10). Jesus took all situations that the devil meant for bad and turned them into glory to his Father.

After Jesus’ lead, it was Peter’s turn. Jesus had sent Peter out among the twelve (Day 6) and then among the seventy-two (Day 13), after which Jesus had told them, “I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven.” This was the kind of force against Satan’s kingdom that Jesus and Peter applied through their ministry of the kingdom of heaven: ‘From the days of John the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven has suffered violence, and the violent take it by force.’ Matthew 11:12

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.11.12>

This ministry of Christ continued to those at Cornelius' home according to the plan of God. Peter testified to Cornelius' friends and family that he and the believers saw Jesus a number of times in different places after he rose from the dead and ate with him (Day 21, Day 22, Day 23). Jesus Christ was ever victorious over sin, sickness and death, causing defeat after defeat to the kingdom of Satan. Jesus is righteous, and he came to usher in the kingdom of God wherein he makes things right to demonstrate his kingdom ways. Jesus sought out and always brought about righteous results, and he urged his disciples to do the same. Peter continued, "[Jesus] commanded us to preach to the people and to testify that he is the one appointed by God to be judge of the living and the dead. To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

Everyone who believes receives freedom and life (zoe) in Jesus.

And just as Jesus was anointed with the Holy Spirit and power at his baptism and Peter was anointed with the Holy Spirit and power among the disciples at Pentecost, the Holy Spirit anointed the Gentiles at that moment where Peter preached truth to them and they believed: "the Holy Spirit fell on all who heard the word. And the believers from among the circumcised who had come with Peter were amazed, because the gift of the Holy Spirit was poured out even on the Gentiles. For they were hearing them speaking in tongues and extolling God."

Peter exclaimed, "Can anyone withhold water for baptizing these people, who have received the Holy Spirit just as we have?" And he commanded them to be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ.

Peter came to understand he was not to judge. He wasn't to qualify people. He was not to decide. Walking in the name and power of Jesus Christ, he was just to love all of mankind as he did himself, and he was to preach the gospel, proclaiming the liberty of God to the captives, letting the goodness of God draw them to freedom and repentance. He had taken on the right attitude of God, one of peace, love, and faith. His faith had become mature; in Christ, it was the faith of the Son of God.

"Then they asked him to remain for some days," during which time Peter no doubt taught them of the things of God. Anointed by God, they were also taught by the Spirit of God (1 John 2:27), even as Peter had been taught.

Peter was obedient to God in the vision and also to the commission of Jesus to all believers (Day 23): "Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you."

As described on Day 9, it was on Peter's confession of truth that Jesus began to build his church, even in the midst of the darkness of the world, and the gates of hell have not prevailed and shall not prevail against it. This all was in fulfillment of the angel's words to Abraham:

'And the angel of the Lord called to Abraham a second time from heaven and said, "By myself I have sworn, declares the Lord, because you have done this and have not withheld your son, your only son, I will surely bless you, and I will surely multiply your offspring as the stars of heaven and as the sand that is on the seashore. And your offspring shall possess the gate of his enemies, and in your offspring shall all the nations of the earth be blessed, because you have obeyed my voice." '

Genesis 22:15-18

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/GEN.22.15-18>

God has multiplied Abraham's offspring through the church of *all nations* built upon Jesus, which has possessed the gate of God's enemies and been a blessing. Moreover, Abraham was himself a Gentile, as the Jewish nation had not yet begun when God made a covenant with him.

Peter, an uneducated man from Galilee, came to show great faith and obey God's voice, even as Abraham did. Peter, empowered by Christ living through him, caused this most beautiful promise of God to unfold as a blessing to the whole world, multiplying the grace and peace of God on earth from the riches of heaven.

Prayer:

Thank You, Father, that where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is liberty. Thank You that by Your Spirit as we follow You and behold Your glory, we are changed into the same image from glory to glory.

-Based on 2 Corinthians 3:17-18

[Song suggestions for Day 34](#)

Day 35: The heavily guarded Peter walks unseen from prison a second time

Yesterday, we read the account of Peter bringing God's liberty to the Gentiles (Luke 4:18-19), fulfilling the promise of God to Abraham. In Acts 12, it's Peter who came to need liberty:

'About that time Herod the king laid violent hands on some who belonged to the church. He killed James the brother of John with the sword, and when he saw that it pleased the Jews, he proceeded to arrest Peter also. This was during the days of Unleavened Bread. And when he had seized him, he put him in prison, delivering him over to four squads of soldiers to guard him, intending after the Passover to bring him out to the people. So Peter was kept in prison, but earnest prayer for him was made to God by the church. Now when Herod was about to bring him out, on that very night, Peter was sleeping between two soldiers, bound with two chains, and sentries before the door were guarding the prison. And behold, an angel of the Lord stood next to him, and a light shone in the cell. He struck Peter on the side and woke him, saying, "Get up quickly." And the chains fell off his hands. And the angel said to him, "Dress yourself and put on your sandals." And he did so. And he said to him, "Wrap your cloak around you and follow me." And he went out and followed him. He did not know that what was being done by the angel was real, but thought he was seeing a vision. When they had passed the first and the second guard, they came to the iron gate leading into the city. It opened for them of its own accord, and they went out and went along one street, and immediately the angel left him. When Peter came to himself, he said, "Now I am sure that the Lord has sent his angel and rescued me from the hand of Herod and from all that the Jewish people were expecting." When he realized this, he went to the house of Mary, the mother of John whose other name was Mark, where many were gathered together and were praying. And when he knocked at the door of the gateway, a servant girl named Rhoda came to answer. Recognizing Peter's voice, in her joy she did not open the gate but ran in and reported that Peter was standing at the gate. They said to her, "You are out of your mind." But she kept insisting that it was so, and they kept saying, "It is his angel!" But Peter continued knocking, and when they opened, they saw him and were amazed. But motioning to them with his hand to be silent, he described to them how the Lord had brought him out of the prison. And he said, "Tell these things to James and to the brothers." Then he departed and went to another place. Now when day came, there was no little disturbance among the soldiers over what had become of Peter. And after Herod searched for him and did not find him, he examined the sentries and ordered that they should be put to death. Then he went down from Judea to Caesarea and spent time there. '

Acts 12:1-19

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.12.1-19>

In this passage, we find that Satan opposed the advancement of the kingdom of God through Herod in Jerusalem, in accordance with what Jesus said following the death of John the Baptist: “From the days of John the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven has suffered violence, and the violent take it by force” (Matthew 11:12). Satan continued to steal, kill and destroy (John 10:10), causing the murder of James the brother of John with the sword. This pleased the Jews due to the spirit that was in the world, the spirit of Satan, even as it was pleased to deliver the righteous Jesus over to be crucified. So Herod arrested Peter also, having the same intent. Satan brings captivity in many ways, sometimes literally.

Peter had escaped from prison in Jerusalem before (Day 30), so Herod delivered him over to four squads of soldiers to guard him this time. He was bound, each of his hands attached by chain to each of two soldiers that stayed with him. There were soldiers at two points in between Peter and the final exit, and sentries stood before the door to the prison.

Knowing Herod’s intent to kill Peter as he had James, the church gathered to pray fervently for Peter at the home of Mary, the mother of John Mark, the gospel author. Their prayers were heard by God, who wasn’t done with Peter yet. God sent an angel to free Peter. A light shone, and the angel woke him, telling him to get up, dress himself, and follow. Peter was unsure if what he was seeing was real: the angel appearing in light, his own chains falling off, walking past the guards and sentries as if he were unseen, the iron gate to the city opening before him to make his exit, the angel then leading him out and disappearing.

When this all had happened, “Peter came to himself,” fully aware, and made his way to the home where the church was praying. The reaction of those present reveals that at this time most of them didn’t expect God to answer their prayers to free Peter, considering the situation impossible or Peter to be dead already. The servant Rhoda recognized him by voice, and, in her joy and bewilderment, shut the door in his face, running to tell the others, who first told her she was crazy. After she insisted, they told her it must be Peter’s angel. Meanwhile, the knocking continued. When they finally went to the door to let him in, they were ecstatic, making so much noise that Peter had to quiet them by motion of his hand to tell them what had just transpired, how God had miraculously freed him. God had answered their prayers in a way beyond what they were able to imagine. Peter was alive, and it brought them exceeding joy. They were ever victorious and would continue to do God’s will, building the church and advancing God’s kingdom and interests, to bring him glory.

Through the works of God’s hand, both through the apostles, and by God’s signs and wonders that accompanied them, “...the word of God increased and multiplied” (v. 24). The word of God

is living, active, and ever expanding (Colossians 1:5-6). It is never defeated, and those who hear it and keep it are blessed (Luke 11:28).

Prayer:

Thank You, Spirit of the Lord, for the life you give and enable me to give through You. I praise You that I have been set free and that wherever You are, there is freedom. I thank You because I am born of you and through faith, I overcome the world. Your good news, O Lord, is liberty to the captives and the opening of the prison to those who are bound.

- Based on 2 Corinthians 3:6,17, 1 John 5:4, Isaiah 61:1

[Song suggestions for Day 35](#)

Day 36: Peter calls the church to righteousness

In 1 Peter, Peter wrote to the church that was dispersed because of the extreme persecution of the Roman emperor Nero. We begin in Chapter 1:

'Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, To those who are elect exiles of the Dispersion in Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia, according to the foreknowledge of God the Father, in the sanctification of the Spirit, for obedience to Jesus Christ and for sprinkling with his blood: May grace and peace be multiplied to you. Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you, who by God's power are being guarded through faith for a salvation ready to be revealed in the last time. In this you rejoice, though now for a little while, if necessary, you have been grieved by various trials, so that the tested genuineness of your faith—more precious than gold that perishes though it is tested by fire—may be found to result in praise and glory and honor at the revelation of Jesus Christ. Though you have not seen him, you love him. Though you do not now see him, you believe in him and rejoice with joy that is inexpressible and filled with glory, obtaining the outcome of your faith, the salvation of your souls. Concerning this salvation, the prophets who prophesied about the grace that was to be yours searched and inquired carefully, inquiring what person or time the Spirit of Christ in them was indicating when he predicted the sufferings of Christ and the subsequent glories. It was revealed to them that they were serving not themselves but you, in the things that have now been announced to you through those who preached the good news to you by the Holy Spirit sent from heaven, things into which angels long to look. Therefore, preparing your minds for action, and being sober-minded, set your hope fully on the grace that will be brought to you at the revelation of Jesus Christ. As obedient children, do not be conformed to the passions of your former ignorance, but as he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct, since it is written, "You shall be holy, for I am holy." And if you call on him as Father who judges impartially according to each one's deeds, conduct yourselves with fear throughout the time of your exile, knowing that you were ransomed from the futile ways inherited from your forefathers, not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot. He was foreknown before the foundation of the world but was made manifest in the last times for the sake of you who through him are believers in God, who raised him from the dead and gave him glory, so that your faith and hope are in God. Having purified your souls by your obedience to the truth for a sincere brotherly love, love one another earnestly from a pure heart, since you have been born again, not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living and abiding word of God; for "All flesh is like grass and all its glory like the flower of grass. The grass withers, and the flower falls, but the word of the Lord remains forever." And this word is the good news that was preached to you.'

1 Peter 1:1-25

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.1.1-25>

We continue in Chapter 2:

' So put away all malice and all deceit and hypocrisy and envy and all slander. Like newborn infants, long for the pure spiritual milk, that by it you may grow up into salvation— if indeed you have tasted that the Lord is good. As you come to him, a living stone rejected by men but in the sight of God chosen and precious, you yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ. For it stands in Scripture: “Behold, I am laying in Zion a stone, a cornerstone chosen and precious, and whoever believes in him will not be put to shame.” So the honor is for you who believe, but for those who do not believe, “The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone,” and “A stone of stumbling, and a rock of offense.” They stumble because they disobey the word, as they were destined to do. But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession, that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light. Once you were not a people, but now you are God’s people; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy. Beloved, I urge you as sojourners and exiles to abstain from the passions of the flesh, which wage war against your soul. Keep your conduct among the Gentiles honorable, so that when they speak against you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day of visitation. '

1 Peter 2:1-12

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.2.1-12>

Peter began his letter to the dispersed church by speaking words of blessing from the Spirit of God to them, “May grace and peace be multiplied to you.” The grace of God is an outflow of the divine nature of giving all of that which is good to mankind, including that which was given in Jesus Christ and then through the Holy Spirit. The peace of God is complete, encompassing all of a person, spirit, soul and body (1 Thessalonians 5:23). Multiplication is the inherent nature of the kingdom of God; God’s seed, his word, yields expansion, abundant growth, and fruit. Fundamentally, God gives life (zoe), and those who have God abiding in them, as Peter did, are enabled to give life as well, even through the words they speak to bless.

Peter spoke also of the church’s common bond and hope: together they had been born again with Christ by the same Spirit that raised Jesus Christ from the dead, and they would share an imperishable inheritance, a reason for great rejoicing. Peter encouraged them in their faith; though these younger believers had not seen Jesus as he had, they believed, and by their faith

they were saved, protected from the attacks of the evil one. Peter had experienced this protection.

Peter compared believers to impure gold that is refined by fire, according to the method that is thousands of years old. For the purpose of illustration, say that we might be compared to ore of some type. When the Spirit of God makes one alive, ignited by one's saving faith, God creates something new: there is now gold embedded within the ore. The gold represents Christ in us, in our spirits, connecting us to God through the Holy Spirit. Yet the gold is not visible. Even so, we have been made eternal. If we commit to being refined in the process of sanctification, we choose to fully die to our old lives. This can be compared with the process of being refined by fire. In sanctification, we heed the call of Christ to repent, which means to think in a new way, and surrender ourselves as a living sacrifice. The Spirit of God lights the fire for our refinement. The Word of God also becomes a fire within us as we take it in, believe it, and do it. When we allow ourselves to be led by the Spirit of God, and when we daily choose to act in faith, we are stirred up. The dross rises to the surface. We must cooperate with God to see that it is removed. It's a long process, repeated again and again. At the end of it, there is the pure gold of God, the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ (Ephesians 4:13).

Peter instructed the believers to be ready, just as Jesus had taught him (Day 14). They should be ready to do what is right, just as Jesus did, because it is the nature of God: 'he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct, since it is written, "You shall be holy, for I am holy." ' Furthermore, God expects this of his church, i.e., to be found spotless, since Jesus empowers his body to have victory over sin, just as he always had while he was in the flesh, even while having his own will (Day 15): "For I have come down from heaven, not to do my own will but the will of him who sent me" (John 6:38).

Our general will is what we desire at our core, and it manifests moment by moment in the decisions we make. Jesus aligned himself with his Father's will. Peter aligned himself with God's will as well; this alignment was never so solid as when he was filled with the Holy Spirit, after which he spoke and did the word of God, following in Jesus' steps. Peter instructed the church to do the same. This starts with consecration of oneself to God and with obedience to the word of God, including God's instruction to the people of his covenant, "You shall be holy, for I am holy" (Leviticus 21:8). Our first victory after confessing Jesus Christ as Lord and following Christ, by the power of the Spirit of Christ in us, is the victory over sin. We receive the consciousness that in Christ we have been made the righteousness of God (2 Corinthians 5:21). We have been made as if we were sinless to God the Father, capable of being the temple of the living God, a place where God is pleased to dwell, and to make himself fully at home, if we will have him. We must allow him to abide in us, to go wherever he wants to go in our home, if we are to abide in him. In fully devoted faith, we must give God charge, allowing him to clean us up as spotless,

i.e., “like that of a lamb without blemish or spot,” rather than trying to keep some place for ourselves, some place for our will to be done—or to keep a backup plan in case he does not come through, or in case we decide to go another way, as Ananias did (Day 28). God knows what’s in our hearts and what’s on our minds. The price God paid to make things right for us and within us was costly to God: “the precious blood of Christ.”

In this passage, Peter explained the source of life for believers in Jesus Christ. It is being “born again, not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living and abiding word of God.” Jesus is the Word of God, showing the will of God in who he is, what he said, and all that he did: “doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him” (Day 34). Jesus, the Word of God, was “foreknown before the foundation of the world but was made manifest” for Peter and for the building up of the church. This word cannot fail, just as Peter, identified with and abiding in Christ, did not fail to carry out God’s will. This word is the word of God that Peter preached and wrote about, bearing much fruit. This word lasts forever, beyond the bodily deaths of Jesus and Peter through persecution. The Word of God lives in those who confess Christ as Lord and follow him by speaking and doing the word. It brings the joy and the power of God, revealing the kingdom of God.

Peter called the believers to “love one another earnestly from a pure heart.” The love that comes from God is selfless. In it, there is no room for malice, deceit, hypocrisy, envy, or slander, which come from valuing self over God and his church—from doing one’s own will, or acting according to Satan’s will, rather than making God’s will one’s own. All in the church are called to love whom God loves, serving all of mankind, preaching and demonstrating the kingdom of God.

Peter urged the church to “grow up into salvation,” to crave growth through the Holy Spirit into the very image of Jesus Christ, which was the will of God for every one of their lives. (Paul gives a similar exhortation to the church in Ephesians 4:11-16.) Peter exhorted the church to consider what they “long for” now they have “tasted that the Lord is good.” Those with divided loyalties cannot be expected to grow up into Christ’s “spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood,” experiencing all of God’s goodness.

To those who are lukewarm, Jesus instead said:

“I know your works: you are neither cold nor hot. Would that you were either cold or hot! So, because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will spit you out of my mouth. For you say, I am rich, I have prospered, and I need nothing, not realizing that you are wretched, pitiable, poor, blind, and naked. I counsel you to buy from me gold refined by fire, so that you may be rich, and white garments so that you may clothe yourself and the shame of your

nakedness may not be seen, and salve to anoint your eyes, so that you may see. Those whom I love, I reprove and discipline, so be zealous and repent. Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me. The one who conquers, I will grant him to sit with me on my throne, as I also conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne.”

Revelation 3:15-21 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/rev.3.15-21.ESV>

The lukewarm disobey the word and the will of God and, therefore, reject Christ, the chosen and precious cornerstone. The lukewarm have not held Jesus as precious. Instead, they love their lives in the world, and so the love of the Father is not in them. Meanwhile, those who heed the word of God are refined by fire, transmuted by God’s life injected into them, changed into pure gold. It is the obedient who receive the Holy Spirit from God, according to Peter (Acts 5:32). Whoever does the will of God and the word of God abides forever.

Regarding those who confessed Christ and abide in Christ, Peter said, “But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession, that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.” God’s chosen people have been made sons and daughters of the King, and they speak as Christ’s ambassadors. They are made sinless, a church of priests that have full access to God, who lives in them as his temple. The Spirit of Christ comes to live in their spirit, their soul, their entire body, and to live his life through all of them, bearing much fruit.

Like the woman who was forgiven much through the mercy of God (Day 4), those who know what God has done for them cannot help but love much, demonstrating the compassion of God and the tenderness of Jesus to all. They will seek to give because God has freely and generously given. They will also be obedient to speak of God’s great love that has called all out of darkness into marvelous light.

Prayer:

I praise You, Lord, our Righteousness (Tsidkenu). Thank You, Father, for making me sinless and connecting me to the true Vine, Jesus, as a branch, where I abide in You and Your words abide in me to bear much fruit, and to give away life, as Your disciple, bringing glory to You. Your life and your great love have made my joy full.

- Based on Jeremiah 23:6, John 15:1-17

[Song suggestions for Day 36](#)

Day 37: Peter instructs the church in regard to suffering for righteousness

Christians were widely persecuted and killed under Nero in the Roman Empire after Nero blamed them for the Great Fire of Rome in 64 AD, which destroyed parts of Rome and caused economic devastation. Peter began to address the suffering of the church in 1 Peter 2:

' Be subject for the Lord's sake to every human institution, whether it be to the emperor as supreme, or to governors as sent by him to punish those who do evil and to praise those who do good. For this is the will of God, that by doing good you should put to silence the ignorance of foolish people. Live as people who are free, not using your freedom as a cover-up for evil, but living as servants of God. Honor everyone. Love the brotherhood. Fear God. Honor the emperor. Servants, be subject to your masters with all respect, not only to the good and gentle but also to the unjust. For this is a gracious thing, when, mindful of God, one endures sorrows while suffering unjustly. For what credit is it if, when you sin and are beaten for it, you endure? But if when you do good and suffer for it you endure, this is a gracious thing in the sight of God. For to this you have been called, because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps. He committed no sin, neither was deceit found in his mouth. When he was reviled, he did not revile in return; when he suffered, he did not threaten, but continued entrusting himself to him who judges justly. He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed. For you were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls.'

1 Peter 2:13-25

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.2.13-25>

Peter continued in Chapter 3: 'Finally, all of you, have unity of mind, sympathy, brotherly love, a tender heart, and a humble mind. Do not repay evil for evil or reviling for reviling, but on the contrary, bless, for to this you were called, that you may obtain a blessing. For "Whoever desires to love life and see good days, let him keep his tongue from evil and his lips from speaking deceit; let him turn away from evil and do good; let him seek peace and pursue it. For the eyes of the Lord are on the righteous, and his ears are open to their prayer. But the face of the Lord is against those who do evil." Now who is there to harm you if you are zealous for what is good? But even if you should suffer for righteousness' sake, you will be blessed. Have no fear of them, nor be troubled, but in your hearts honor Christ the Lord as holy, always being prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you; yet do it with gentleness and respect, having a good conscience, so that, when you are slandered, those who revile your good behavior in Christ may be put to shame. For it is better to suffer for doing good, if that should be God's will, than for doing evil. For Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring us to God, being put to death in the flesh but made alive in the spirit, '

1 Peter 3:8-18

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.3.8-18>

Peter instructed the church that in the face of evil and injustice they were always to do good, just as Jesus did. This was the will of God for both Christ and them. The believers were to “live as people who are free” and live as servants of all of mankind, showing honor and love, just as Jesus instructed them to serve. The church was instructed to endure suffering “because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps.” God’s people were to follow him in all things, no matter the cost, even unto taking up their own crosses and losing their lives because of their identification with Jesus. They were to trust themselves to the Father, even as Jesus did.

Peter reminded the believers of the ministry of Jesus for them and mankind, made possible by Jesus’ great suffering, in keeping with the prophecy of Isaiah 53: “He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed.” Let’s also remind ourselves about the way Peter summarized Jesus’ ministry to the Gentiles at Cornelius’ home (Day 34): “God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him.” Based on this association, Peter was certainly referring to the full salvation that the ministry of Jesus brought to the Jews and to the entire church, Jews and Gentiles alike. This full salvation included the forgiveness of sin in the identification of believers with the death of resurrection of Jesus in faith, and it included the healing of their bodies which was an enormous part of the ministry of Jesus and of Peter. These things always came together. They were also the fulfillment of the prophecy of the suffering servant of Isaiah 53, as described in part on Day 3, in reference to the Scripture from Matthew 8: ‘That evening they brought to him many who were oppressed by demons, and he cast out the spirits with a word and healed all who were sick. This was to fulfill what was spoken by the prophet Isaiah: “He took our illnesses and bore our diseases.” ’

Jesus was and is righteous. In the anointing of the Holy Spirit, he was victorious over sin, sickness and death, then he was (and is) seated at the right hand of the Father. To the church he gave the very same, making them righteous in his image, able and expected to do the same victorious things he did, as we see in Peter’s life. Those in the church are also seated next to the Father in the body of Christ, wherein Christ is the head.

The identification with Jesus was full, as these saints and servants of God were to suffer in the same or in very similar ways to the way Jesus, the Righteous One, did (Isaiah 53):

’ Who has believed what he has heard from us? And to whom has the arm of the Lord been revealed? For he grew up before him like a young plant, and like a root out of dry ground; he

had no form or majesty that we should look at him, and no beauty that we should desire him. He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief; and as one from whom men hide their faces he was despised, and we esteemed him not. Surely he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed. All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned—every one—to his own way; and the Lord has laid on him the iniquity of us all. He was oppressed, and he was afflicted, yet he opened not his mouth; like a lamb that is led to the slaughter, and like a sheep that before its shearers is silent, so he opened not his mouth. By oppression and judgment he was taken away; and as for his generation, who considered that he was cut off out of the land of the living, stricken for the transgression of my people? And they made his grave with the wicked and with a rich man in his death, although he had done no violence, and there was no deceit in his mouth. Yet it was the will of the Lord to crush him; he has put him to grief; when his soul makes an offering for guilt, he shall see his offspring; he shall prolong his days; the will of the Lord shall prosper in his hand. Out of the anguish of his soul he shall see and be satisfied; by his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous, and he shall bear their iniquities. Therefore I will divide him a portion with the many, and he shall divide the spoil with the strong, because he poured out his soul to death and was numbered with the transgressors; yet he bore the sin of many, and makes intercession for the transgressors.'

Isaiah 53:1-12

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.53.1-12>

Peter instructed the church, "if you should suffer for righteousness' sake, you will be blessed. Have no fear of them, nor be troubled." Peter repeated here the words he heard Jesus utter: "Do not fear" (Day 5) and "Do not be afraid" (Day 8). Jesus had also taught him: ' "Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. "Blessed are you when others revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account. Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven, for so they persecuted the prophets who were before you. '

Matthew 5:10-12

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.5.10-12>

Christ's way spoken through Peter is a completely different way, the way of the heavenly Father, who is perfect, causing his own to love even their enemies. Christ's way brought his followers peace, healing and righteousness.

Prayer:

My help comes from You, Lord, You who made heaven and the earth. I thank You, God, that You abide in me, as I abide in You. You are love, and I abide in love, which You perfect in me. I thank You that Your perfect love casts out all fear. I thank You that as Jesus is right now, so am I in this world.

- Based on Psalm 121:2, 1 John 4:15-19

[Song suggestions for Day 37](#)

Day 38: Peter instructs the shepherds of the church

Peter's letter continues to the church: ' The end of all things is at hand; therefore be self-controlled and sober-minded for the sake of your prayers. Above all, keep loving one another earnestly, since love covers a multitude of sins. Show hospitality to one another without grumbling. As each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God's varied grace: whoever speaks, as one who speaks oracles of God; whoever serves, as one who serves by the strength that God supplies—in order that in everything God may be glorified through Jesus Christ. To him belong glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen. '

1 Peter 4:7-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.4.7-11>

'So I exhort the elders among you, as a fellow elder and a witness of the sufferings of Christ, as well as a partaker in the glory that is going to be revealed: shepherd the flock of God that is among you, exercising oversight, not under compulsion, but willingly, as God would have you; not for shameful gain, but eagerly; not domineering over those in your charge, but being examples to the flock. And when the chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the unfading crown of glory. Likewise, you who are younger, be subject to the elders. Clothe yourselves, all of you, with humility toward one another, for "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble." Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you, casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you. Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. Resist him, firm in your faith, knowing that the same kinds of suffering are being experienced by your brotherhood throughout the world. And after you have suffered a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to his eternal glory in Christ, will himself restore, confirm, strengthen, and establish you. To him be the dominion forever and ever. Amen. '

1 Peter 5:1-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.5.1-11>

Peter exhorted the church to "keep loving one another earnestly, since love covers a multitude of sins." This is not only the instruction of God, but taking on this attitude of Christ Jesus is the way of unity in the church. The Spirit of Jesus Christ sows love, while the spirit of the world divides.

Peter, building up the church, encouraged them to choose to be led by and to serve by the Spirit of God in them. They were to be faithful managers of the gifts and the generosity of God living in them by that Spirit. Peter spoke here not just of natural, God-given abilities, but also of the

supernatural abilities from God that they demonstrated, including speaking the words of God, even as Peter did, and serving through the abilities of the Spirit, even as Peter did. They were to glorify Jesus Christ by functioning as the body of Christ, with all of the authority Christ gave the church over the spiritual and the physical, even as we have seen that Peter did, following in the steps of Jesus, empowered by the Spirit of Jesus alive in him.

Peter, a leading shepherd for this early church, exhorted the leaders of the church to “shepherd the flock of God that is among” them as ambassadors of “the chief Shepherd” by “being examples to the flock.” They were to show the righteousness and the love of God, do the word of God, and demonstrate the power of God in Jesus Christ through the Holy Spirit as they preached and taught about the kingdom of heaven and the gospel. They were to be the image of Christ in every way, including in Christ’s example of humility in serving mankind and in his suffering and death. They were to count others as more significant than themselves. They were not to look to their own interests and things, but to look to the interests and things of others. It was not about them; it was about the Chief Shepherd and about caring for the sheep.

In word and in deed, Peter was obedient to the commands of Jesus to him (Day 22) after Peter had denied Jesus (Day 20): “Feed my lambs,” “Tend my sheep,” and “Feed my sheep.”

As shepherds under the chief Shepherd, and as they regularly heard about the suffering of their brothers and sisters in the church by the hand of the state, they were to be “casting all [their] anxieties on him, because he cares for [them].”

They were also soldiers of God in an ongoing war, yet one where the outcome was known. Peter instructed them, “Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. Resist him, firm in your faith, knowing that the same kinds of suffering are being experienced by your brotherhood throughout the world.”

Already we have discussed Jesus’ command to “be ready” (Day 14) and later his repeated command to his disciples at Gethsemane to “watch” (Day 18). Jesus had before revealed to Peter that “Satan demanded to have you, that he might sift you like wheat.” This is generally how the accuser of mankind operates, prowling around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. Peter urged the believers to resist any attacks of the devil through standing firm in their faith, trusting in the protection of God because they were obedient to do God’s will. Jesus spoke of protection for those ready and obedient to go, both for the seventy-two (Day 13) and for those obedient to the great commission (Day 23).

Peter pointed the believers to hope in the reward to come for them, concluding, “And after you have suffered a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to his eternal glory in Christ, will himself restore, confirm, strengthen, and establish you. To him be the dominion forever and ever. Amen.” They could rest in the fact that they represented the chief Shepherd, who assured them, “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me” (Day 23).

Peter experienced the dominion of Christ, initially witnessing it firsthand, then having it continue directly through his own ministry. It was to continue through the body of Christ until Christ’s enemies were made his footstool (Day 24).

Prayer:

I praise You, Lord, our Shepherd (Ra’ah). Thank You, Jesus, for giving the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, the shepherds and teachers, to equip your saints for the work of ministry, for building up Your body, until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of You, to the measure of the stature of Your fullness as the Christ.

- Based on Genesis 48:15, Ephesians 4:12-13

[Song suggestions for Day 38](#)

Day 39: Peter speaks to the church as partakers of the divine nature

In Peter's second letter to the church, he wrote:

'Simeon Peter, a servant and apostle of Jesus Christ, To those who have obtained a faith of equal standing with ours by the righteousness of our God and Savior Jesus Christ: May grace and peace be multiplied to you in the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord. His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of him who called us to his own glory and excellence, by which he has granted to us his precious and very great promises, so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature, having escaped from the corruption that is in the world because of sinful desire. For this very reason, make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, and knowledge with self-control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, and godliness with brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love. For if these qualities are yours and are increasing, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. For whoever lacks these qualities is so nearsighted that he is blind, having forgotten that he was cleansed from his former sins. Therefore, brothers, be all the more diligent to confirm your calling and election, for if you practice these qualities you will never fall. For in this way there will be richly provided for you an entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. Therefore I intend always to remind you of these qualities, though you know them and are established in the truth that you have. I think it right, as long as I am in this body, to stir you up by way of reminder, since I know that the putting off of my body will be soon, as our Lord Jesus Christ made clear to me. And I will make every effort so that after my departure you may be able at any time to recall these things. For we did not follow cleverly devised myths when we made known to you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, but we were eyewitnesses of his majesty. For when he received honor and glory from God the Father, and the voice was borne to him by the Majestic Glory, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased," we ourselves heard this very voice borne from heaven, for we were with him on the holy mountain. And we have the prophetic word more fully confirmed, to which you will do well to pay attention as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts, knowing this first of all, that no prophecy of Scripture comes from someone's own interpretation. For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit.'

2 Peter 1:1-21

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2PE.1.1-21>

Peter referred to himself as a servant and an apostle in the introduction to his letter. Peter was known to have built the church in Jerusalem, Samaria, Judea, Antioch, Corinth, and Rome. Some recognize him as chief of the apostles. In modern times, he might also be considered a healing

evangelist, as, like Jesus, he was one who healed and raised the dead as part of his proclamation of the kingdom of God. This was all done as a servant of mankind in obedience to the call of Jesus.

Peter considered the church to whom he wrote to have equal standing with him in faith by way of the righteousness of Jesus, whom he called God and Savior. Though Jesus had a will of his own as a man, he made his Father's will his own, and his righteousness was shown in his consistent victory over sin, sickness and death. By faith, Peter took on this same righteousness, identified with Christ. Peter wrote to those who had done the same.

"May grace and peace be multiplied to you in the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord." As discussed on Day 36, the grace of God is an outflow of the divine nature of giving all of that which is good to mankind, including that which was given in Jesus Christ and then through the Holy Spirit. It is an outcome of knowing God. The peace of God, another outcome of knowing God, is complete, encompassing all of a person, spirit, soul and body. Multiplication is the inherent nature of the kingdom of God; God's seed, his word, yields expansion, abundant growth, and fruit.

Peter continued, "His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of him who called us to his own glory and excellence, by which he has granted to us his precious and very great promises, so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature." Fundamentally, God gives life (zoe), and those who have God abiding in them, as Peter did, are enabled to give life as well, even through the words they speak to bless. Peter came to even radiate life through his spirit, soul and body (Day 29). God has granted to the followers of Christ all things that pertain to life.

Through the divine power of the Holy Spirit, Peter and believers in Christ alike were granted all things that pertain to godliness, becoming partakers of the divine nature. This is what Jesus brought to Peter and his church at Pentecost (Day 24), bought through his precious blood and his broken body. Peter, having recently shown the weakness of a man, became like Christ at this time, spirit, soul, and body, carrying on his ministry in a manner very similar to that of Jesus Christ, the fires of Jesus burning in his heart. Taking on the consciousness of God through the word of God, Peter spoke the words of Jesus, who spoke the words of the Father—words of spirit and life—and Peter demonstrated the power of God as Jesus did. In becoming a partaker of the divine nature, Peter became one with God in nature, character, substance, essence; a co-worker with the regnant, glorified Jesus Christ (1 Corinthians 3:9); having His Spirit abiding within to overflowing. This was in accordance with what Jesus said would happen (John 10:34). Peter showed the dominion of Jesus, taking on the authority and responsibility to bind the

enemy and set people free from the oppression of that enemy, wherever he ministered, for God's glory. He had an intense desire for the fulfillment of God's righteousness on earth. Peter described the fulfillment of God's word in him, and similarly, in the church, as God having "granted to us his precious and very great promises." As Jesus is right now, so is his church in the world, causing it to live in holy triumph.

Some of the qualities of the divine nature and character of God that the church was to take on included faith, virtue, knowledge, self-control, steadfastness, godliness, brotherly affection, and love. Jesus frequently showed, taught, and even rebuked the disciples, Peter included, toward greater faith in God. The rest of these qualities are fruits of being led by the Spirit of God, thus they should ever be increasing in followers of Christ who are growing up into his fullness. Growing up into Christ, followers come to have the mind of Christ and all of the mind of Christ. Peter instructed them, "be all the more diligent to confirm your calling and election, for if you practice these qualities you will never fall."

Peter had answered the call, willing to give his all, and he encouraged others to do the same—to be willing to walk and work and suffer and die for the gospel and the will of God as he was, enabling them to partake of the divine nature, just as he had. His rock-solid faith had brought heaven to him and those to whom he ministered, fusing him into God as part of Christ's body.

Since these believers had not experienced Jesus in person, he next described his eyewitness account of the Transfiguration described on Day 11. This is where Peter had become conscious of his environment in the spiritual world. Heaven is right here, and the body of Christ is linked to God. Further, he directed the followers of Christ to heed the prophecy of Scripture as the words of the Spirit of God, as discussed on Day 1. The place of God's word in Peter's life and in every life is everything. It gives life. It increases. It multiplies the grace and peace of God. Planted in a life yielded to God's will, this seed is the blueprint by which one partakes of the divine nature of God.

Prayer:

I praise You, Lord, my Peace (Shalom). Thank You, Father, for all Your promises find their Yes in Jesus Christ. That is why it is through him that I utter my Amen to You for Your glory. Thank you, God, for establishing me in Christ, anointing me, and putting your seal on me, giving me Your Spirit in my heart as a guarantee. You, Lord, guide me continually, making me like a watered garden, like a spring of water, whose waters fail not.

- Based on Judges 6:24, 2 Corinthians 1:19-22, Isaiah 58:11

[Song suggestions for Day 39](#)

Day 40: Peter stirs up the church to be ready

In 2 Peter 3, his last recorded writing in the Bible, Peter wrote:

'This is now the second letter that I am writing to you, beloved. In both of them I am stirring up your sincere mind by way of reminder, that you should remember the predictions of the holy prophets and the commandment of the Lord and Savior through your apostles, knowing this first of all, that scoffers will come in the last days with scoffing, following their own sinful desires. They will say, "Where is the promise of his coming? For ever since the fathers fell asleep, all things are continuing as they were from the beginning of creation." For they deliberately overlook this fact, that the heavens existed long ago, and the earth was formed out of water and through water by the word of God, and that by means of these the world that then existed was deluged with water and perished. But by the same word the heavens and earth that now exist are stored up for fire, being kept until the day of judgment and destruction of the ungodly. But do not overlook this one fact, beloved, that with the Lord one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day. The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance. But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, and then the heavens will pass away with a roar, and the heavenly bodies will be burned up and dissolved, and the earth and the works that are done on it will be exposed. Since all these things are thus to be dissolved, what sort of people ought you to be in lives of holiness and godliness, waiting for and hastening the coming of the day of God, because of which the heavens will be set on fire and dissolved, and the heavenly bodies will melt as they burn! But according to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells. Therefore, beloved, since you are waiting for these, be diligent to be found by him without spot or blemish, and at peace. And count the patience of our Lord as salvation, just as our beloved brother Paul also wrote to you according to the wisdom given him, as he does in all his letters when he speaks in them of these matters. There are some things in them that are hard to understand, which the ignorant and unstable twist to their own destruction, as they do the other Scriptures. You therefore, beloved, knowing this beforehand, take care that you are not carried away with the error of lawless people and lose your own stability. But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen.'

2 Peter 3:1-18

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2PE.3.1-18>

Peter referred to the church as beloved, warning them of scoffers who doubted the return of Christ. Peter advised them that time is not the same with God, even as Moses wrote:

'For a thousand years in your sight are but as yesterday when it is past, or as a watch in the night. '

Psalms 90:4

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.90.4>

Peter told them “the day of the Lord will come like a thief,” even as Jesus told him, ' “But concerning that day and hour no one knows, not even the angels of heaven, nor the Son, but the Father only. '

Matthew 24:36

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.24.36>

In view of this, Peter stirred up the church to be ready and to pursue righteousness, “diligent to be found by him without spot or blemish” and to grow in the grace of Jesus Christ. This was and is the will of God for the church, the bride of Christ, to be molded until the very image of Christ is reproduced in their lives. This way at the coming of Jesus, the church will be found ready to meet Jesus. They were to be “a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession.” For those who are in God’s church, God lives in them—all of them—a habitation of God. His nature is purity, and the only thing he cannot do is fail.

It is also the will of God that “that all should reach repentance” rather than perish. Since it’s God’s will, it should be the church’s will. Those found without spot or blemish pursue the will of God rather than their own will. The church is equipped to minister God to the world with all generosity as ambassadors of the living, reigning Jesus. This is what the world needs: the love of God. The love of Christ manifested in followers of Christ is the tender love of God for his children, not wanting any of them to perish. The life of Jesus in followers of Christ, the fountain of life, gives life. Mankind is dying for the lack of the love of God, and it needs to experience what the grace of God is through the generosity of the nature of God in his church. Every part of Christ’s body is moved with compassion.

Peter urged the church to have faith in the promise of God for the return of Jesus Christ, which will ultimately yield a “new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells.” The church will then enter into its vast inheritance of the Creator’s abundant life, a life of fellowship with God, the source of good, as well as every good and perfect gift.

Looking forward to the return of Christ, the King of kings and Lord of lords, and the hope of the rest of his inheritance, Peter continued to emulate Christ, obedient to the end of his life on earth.

Prayer:

I praise You, God, rich in mercy, for Your tender love so great that You made us alive together with Christ and seated us with Him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus, so that in the coming ages You might show the immeasurable riches of Your grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus! Thank You for making me Your workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works. I commit to walk in them, Lord, rather than pass them by today.

- Based on Ephesians 2:4-10

[Song suggestions for Day 40](#)

Conclusion

We live in an age of global connectedness, individualism, and continual distraction. There are nearly an infinite number of stories we could choose to follow, and we are built to love stories.

The world of social media that has begun to dominate culture is one self-focus (2 Timothy 3:1-7) and one of followership, i.e., following any individuals or organizations that gain our attention. There is no cost or commitment in doing so.

To certain people or things we do choose to commit ourselves. Also, certain genuine discipleship-like relationships still persist in the world today. In my world, I've observed this both in athletes that seriously train under a mentor or mentors to become among the best in their sport, and I've directly experienced it in PhD students that train under a mentor or mentors to become among the best in their discipline.

Yet, following Jesus is altogether different than this. In these 40 days together, we have seen this through the life of Simon Peter, an uneducated commoner whose life was completely transformed by his experience of Jesus and his decision to follow him. Through the course of his life and writings, we have experienced Peter growing up into Christ, being changed into the same image from one degree of glory to another (2 Corinthians 3:18). How amazing the change!

It's not about Peter though, and it's not about you:

"But God chose what is foolish in the world to shame the wise; God chose what is weak in the world to shame the strong; God chose what is low and despised in the world, even things that are not, to bring to nothing things that are, so that no human being might boast in the presence of God. And because of him you are in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption,"

1 Corinthians 1:27-30 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/1co.1.27-30.ESV>

It's about God. It's about what He is able to do and what He wills to do... *in* you, in the world around you, in the world at large... *through* you and through his church, his treasured possession, his bride.

Will you commit to be part of that story, both today and every day?

As a minister of the Lord and Savior with a mission from God, pray through for this church and this kingdom work. Give God your heart; all of it.

Prayer:

I praise You, God, for nothing is impossible with You! I am Your servant, Lord. Let it be to me according to Your word. I thank You that the anointing that I have received from You abides in me and teaches me about everything, so I abide in You. Having heard Your word, I do Your word, seeking first Your kingdom and Your righteousness. The springs of life and of power are in You.

- Based on Luke 1:37-38, 1 John 2:27, James 1:22, Matthew 6:33

[Song suggestions](#)

Song suggestions by day

To those born around the same time I was, an alternative title might be: “I made you a mixtape.” These mixtapes recorded on cassette tapes took some time, and so they were made for good friends. In any case, here’s what I put together for you at the end of summer in 2021. You are welcomed to use your favorite streaming audio source, if you are so inclined.

[Day 1, Simon hears of Jesus](#)

[God With Us, All Sons & Daughters](#)

[Day 2, Peter leaves everything to follow Jesus](#)

[After all \(Holy\), David Crowder Band](#)

[One Pure and Holy Passion \(feat. Candi Pearson\) \[Live\], Passion](#)

[Day 3, Healings and freedom at Peter’s home](#)

[Pieces \(Live\), Bethel Music & Steffany Gretzinger](#)

[God with Us, Bryan & Katie Torwalt](#)

[Day 4, A sinful woman forgiven](#)

[Alabaster Heart \(Live\), Bethel Music & Kalley](#)

[Mercy, Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)

[Hunger \(feat. MDSN\) \[Live\], David & Nicole Binion](#)

[Day 5, Peter sees a woman healed and a girl raised from the dead](#)

[Miracles \(feat. Chris Quilala\) \[Live\], Jesus Culture](#)

[Revival \(Live\), Jesus Culture & Chris McClarney](#)

[Jubilee \(feat. Naomi Raine & Bryan & Katie Torwalt\), Maverick City Music](#)

[Day 6, Jesus sends out Peter among the twelve](#)

[Follow You \(With Brandon Heath\), Leeland](#)

[Catch the Wind \(Spontaneous\), Bethel Music & Melissa Helser](#)

[Day 7, Jesus instructs the disciples to feed a multitude](#)

[Jireh \(feat. Chandler Moore & Naomi Raine\), Elevation Worship & Maverick City Music](#)

[God Will Work it out \(feat. Naomi Raine, Israel Houghton & May City Gospel Choir\), Maverick City Music](#)

[Day 8, Jesus walks better on water better than Peter does](#)

[No Longer Slaves, Bethel Music, Jonathan David Helser & Melissa Helser](#)

[Closer \(feat. Brandon Lake\), Maverick City Music](#)

[None Like You \(feat. Beckah Shae\), Aaron Shust](#)

[Day 9, Peter confesses Jesus as the Christ](#)

[Build Your Church, Maverick City Music](#)

[Day 10, Jesus rebukes Peter as Satan](#)

[Refiner \(feat. Chandler Moore & Steffany Gretzinger\), Maverick City Music](#)

[Rings the Bells, JOHNNYSWIM, Drew Holcomb & The Neighbors](#)

[Day 11, Peter offers to make tents for Jesus, Moses and Elijah](#)

[Worthy, Worthy, Vertical Worship](#)

[When My Heart Became Aware, Sean Feucht](#)

[Day 12, Jesus drives out a spirit by prayer that some of the disciples cannot](#)

[Build Your Kingdom Here, Rend Collective](#)

[Tremble, Mosaic MSC](#)

[Even The Impossible \(Live\), Mack Brock](#)

[Day 13, Jesus sends Peter among the seventy-two](#)

[Isaiah 6 \(Here am I Send Me\) \[feat. Chloe Brennt, Live\], Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)

[Waging War, CeCe Winans](#)

[Selah: Counting the cost](#)

[Beautiful Surrender, Melissa Helser](#)

[Thank You \(feat. Steffany Gretzinger & Chandler Moore\), Maverick City Music](#)

[Day 14, Jesus tells us to be ready](#)

[You Won't Relent \(feat. David Brymer\), Misty Edwards](#)

[Jesus Cast a Look On Me, Red Mountain Church](#)

[Day 15, Peter acknowledges Jesus has the words of eternal life](#)

[The Sower's Song, Andrew Peterson](#)

[My Heart Your Home \(feat. Alton Eugene & Chandler Moore\)](#)

[Hunger \(Live\), CeCe Winans](#)

[Day 16, Peter notices that a fig tree cursed by Jesus has withered](#)
[Wait On You \(feat. Dante Bowe & Chandler Moore\), Elevation Worship & Maverick City Music](#)
[Believe For It \(Live\), CeCe Winans](#)
[You Came \(Lazarus\), Jonathan David & Melissa Helser](#)
[Over All I Know, Vertical Worship](#)

[Day 17, Peter tries to keep Jesus from washing his feet](#)
[How We Love You \(Live\), Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)
[Paradox, Ellie Holcomb & Natalie Hemby](#)

[Day 18, Following communion, Jesus predicts Peter's denial](#)
[Remember \(feat. Dante Bowe & Eniola Abioye\), Maverick City Music & UPPERROOM](#)
[Lead Me to the Cross, Hillsong United](#)

[Day 19, In the passion of a moment, Peter lops off the ear of a Roman soldier](#)
[Prophecy Your Promise, Bryan & Katie Torwalt](#)

[Day 20, Peter looks out for himself when Jesus is arrested](#)
[My Hallelujah, Bryan & Katie Torwalt](#)
[Have My Heart \(feat. Chris Brown & Chandler Moore\), Maverick City Music](#)

[Day 21, John beats Peter to Jesus' empty tomb](#)
[Jesus Changes Everything, Circuit Rider Music & Taylor Ezzell](#)
[We Will Ride \(Live\), Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)

[Day 22, Jesus asks Peter three times if Peter loves him](#)
[Obedience, Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)
[Take Me Back \(feat. Dante Bowe\), Maverick City Music](#)
[How He Loves, David Crowder Band](#)

[Day 23, Jesus commissions Peter among his disciples](#)
[Missionary Anthem \(feat. Seth Yates\) \[Live\], YWAM Kona Music](#)
[Driven by Love, Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)

[Day 24, Peter receives the Holy Spirit and preaches in Jerusalem](#)
[Temple \(Spontaneous\) \[feat. Amanda Lindsay Cook\], Maverick City Music](#)
[Fire \(Live\), CeCe Winans](#)

[Day 25, Peter gives life to a lame beggar at the Beautiful Gate](#)
[Anything is Possible \(Live\), Bethel Music & Dante Bowe](#)

[Day 26, Peter preaches about the Author of life at Solomon's portico](#)
[Your Great Name \(Acoustic Version\), Natalie Grant](#)
[Break Every Chain \(feat. Kristene DiMarco\) \[Live\], Jesus Culture](#)
[What a Beautiful Name \(Live\), Hillsong Worship](#)
[Overwhelmed, Big Daddy Weave](#)

[Day 27, Peter boldly faces opposition from the council](#)
[Like a Fire \(feat. Steffany Gretzinger\), Sean Feucht](#)
[Names \(feat. Tiffany Hudson\), Elevation Worship & Maverick City Music](#)

[Day 28, Peter leads the Jerusalem community of believers](#)
[Strip it all away, John Wilds](#)
[Not My Will \(Live\), Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)

[Day 29, Peter becomes healing](#)
[Champion \(feat. Brandon Lake & Maryanne J. George\), Maverick City Music & UPPERROOM](#)

[Day 30, Peter preaches Life after being freed from prison by an angel](#)
[Freedom Looks Good on You \(feat. Israel Houghton, Bri Babineaux, Ryan Ofei, May City Gospel Choir\), Maverick City Music](#)
[I cannot be defeated, Cecil J. Glover](#)

[Day 31, Peter confronts Simon the Magician for trying to buy power](#)
[Revival's in the Air \(Live\), Bethel Music & Melissa Helser](#)
[Come Holy One \(feat. Leeland\), Young Oceans](#)

[Day 32, Peter heals a bedridden man](#)
[Mark My Hands, Circuit Rider Music & Lindy Cofer](#)
[Never Lost, CeCe Winans](#)

[Day 33, Peter raises a dead woman](#)
[When You Walk Into the Room, Bryan & Katie Torwalt](#)
[Hands and Feet \(Live\), Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)

[Day 34, God speaks to Peter through visions](#)
[Come with Power, Circuit Rider Music & Mattie Anderson](#)
[Every Nation \(Every Soul\) \[Live\], Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)
[Saved, Delivered and Healed, Carman](#)
[The Blessing \(Live\), Kari Jobe, Cody Carnes & Elevation Worship](#)

[Day 35, The heavily guarded Peter walks unseen from prison a second time](#)
[My Weapon, Natalie Grant](#)
[We Praise You \(Live\), Bethel Music & Brandon Lake](#)

[Day 36, Peter calls the church to righteousness](#)
[Joy of the Lord \(feat. Katie Torwalt, Naomi Raine, May City Gospel Choir & Dante Bowe\),](#)
[Maverick City Music](#)
[Holy, Holy, Holy, Audrey Assad](#)
[O Praise Him \(All This for a King\), David Crowder Band](#)

[Day 37, Peter instructs the church in regard to suffering for righteousness](#)
[Son of Suffering \(feat. Chandler Moore, Jekalyn Carr & May City Gospel Choir\), Maverick City](#)
[Music](#)

[Day 38, Peter instructs the shepherds of the church](#)
[Shall Not Want \(feat. Chandler Moore\), Elevation Worship & Maverick City Music](#)

[Day 39, Peter speaks to the church as partakers of the divine nature](#)
[Remember, Bryan & Katie Torwalt](#)
[Promises \(feat. Joe L Barnes & Naomi Raine\), Maverick City Music](#)
[Yes & Amen \(feat. Chandler Moore\), Maverick City Music](#)

[Day 40, Peter stirs up the church to be ready](#)
[Better is One Day \(feat. Charlie Hall\), Passion](#)
[Stand in Awe, Lindy Cofer & Circuit Rider Music](#)
[King of Kings \(He's a Wonder\), CeCe Winans](#)

[Conclusion](#)
[You Hold It All Together \(feat. Chandler Moore & Elyssa Smith\), Maverick City Music &](#)
[UPPERROOM](#)
[Most Beautiful / So in Love \(feat. Chandler Moore\), Maverick City Music](#)

The challenge presented in Peter's life and witness: my view

'But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us. '

2 Corinthians 4:7

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2CO.4.7>

Peter is one of the cloud of witnesses from whom we can learn and be encouraged. I have been encouraged and even more so challenged as I've reconsidered his life.

In Peter's life, I see myself in certain ways, and it prompts many questions.

After I first heard the truth of Jesus and really understood it, I had to consider what I would do with it. In fact, every time I learn more of God's call — even as Peter testified, He is not a respecter of persons (Acts 10:34, 2:39) — I still must consider what I will do with it. I'm just one person, human, and prone to mistakes.

What do I do with this? How do I move from a life of being a hearer of God's Word more fully into the life of a doer?

Have I actually left everything to follow? Will I actually leave everything? What does that look like in today's world as one who lives in the West? Am I fully willing to count the cost?

Since we don't clearly see our own weaknesses, in what sense am I still like the disciples in their early days of Christ's ministry? Even after they committed to follow and left everything, they had all kinds of problems, even as I have. Still subject to fear. Self-seeking. Proud. Lacking in faith. Lacking humility. Lacking compassion and tenderness. Lacking courage. Wavering in attention, in purpose, in generosity of spirit, in patience, and in hope.

Even when some of the disciples had done the things Jesus did in his ministry, the Spirit of God with them, some of them struggled with unbelief, and some of them chose not to be disciples any longer.

Will I be up to all of that which God has for me? Am I enough? How does the reality of Christ in me affect those around me today?

I am still on a path to change, and change is hard. We all resist change. Yet God is ever wanting to change us into the image of Christ, even as He did with Peter.

How much do I resist giving over all of myself? Will I actually know when I've done it? When I've gotten myself out of the way so the Spirit of God can actually make Himself at home in me?

Has God infused me with His kind of love? How may I daily assimilate it? What does that look like in my life? Do I see people as Jesus sees them? Which people do I not yet see as He sees them?

How do I get personally involved in God's plan today? Has the Holy Spirit made God's plan a consuming passion within me?

Am I listening well to His still, small voice, and to the sometimes subtle ways He speaks? Even over the drone of my own internal voice and over the cacophony of daily distractions?

Will I believe Him for the thing and use what He has given me? Or will I pray myself into unbelief?

Am I up for continuing Jesus' ministry alongside fellow believers, even as Peter did? Am I willing to drop everything and go where I'm called to go? Am I willing to let God walk in me? Am I willing to give like God does? Am I willing to die for what I love?

Why does God have such confidence in me as an agent of His grace and compassion?

Have I aligned myself today with His will, purpose, dreams, and plans?

Do I believe that in doing His work, He will cause me to triumph? As a co-worker with God, am I able to take on God's determination to persevere?

Do I believe that God is able to do anything? That anything is possible for one who believes?

All I know today is that it's these types of questions I am to take to God in prayer, with thanksgiving and praise for who He is, who He has made me to be as a member of His church, what He has done, and what He is about to do.

The faith that Peter was given says:
God will do the thing,
He is doing the thing,
He has done it.

As Peter learned to do, I can expect much of God.

He will accomplish His will, and I can join His story today, knowing that in my weakness, God is strong.

(Let the readers who have to read to this point also note that I tell more of my story in the last section of the book I published online first, *God's Love Plan in Jesus and the Church: 40 Days in the Old Testament*, although I wrote it second. It was made available for download at www.jason.church/downloads on February 14, 2022. Additionally, by the way, my middle initial P is for Peter.)